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Govt seeks details on infra from private schools

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has revised the proforma that private unaided recognised schools are required to submit, significantly expanding the information sought on fee structure, infrastructure, statutory compliance and facilities provided to students, particularly those admitted under the EWS category.

The revised format, issued by the Directorate of Education (DoE) on Tuesday, replaces the earlier proforma that largely focused on fee-related information, the financial records and compliance with provisions of the Delhi School Education

Act and Rules. Compared to the old format, the new proforma seeks a much broader set of details.

While the earlier version primarily asked schools to furnish class-wise fee details, fee hikes over the past seven years, audited financial statements, utilisation of fee collections and compliance relating to EWS admissions, the revised format includes several additional sections on school infrastructure, staff strength, recognition status and student enrolment.

Schools will now have to provide information on the number of classrooms, laboratories, libraries, playgrounds, drinking water and



sanitation facilities, availability of CCTV cameras, fire safety measures, transport facilities and other infrastructure available on the campus, as per DoE.

The revised format also seeks details of teaching and

retained questions related to fee structure and financial compliance but has reorganised them into a more comprehensive format. Schools will still be required to furnish details of tuition fees and other charges, audited accounts, fee hikes, receipts issued to parents, maintenance of accounts and compliance with government orders, it stated.

Like the earlier proforma, the new format continues to seek details on admissions under the Economically Weaker Section (EWS), Disadvantaged Group (DG) and Children With Special Needs (CWSN) categories.

However, it also asks schools to provide additional information on facilities

and services extended to such students.

The revised proforma also includes declarations and certification requirements, making school managements responsible for the accuracy of the information furnished, the department mentioned.

According to the DoE circular, all private unaided recognised schools have been directed to submit the revised proforma along with the prescribed documents within the stipulated timeline. The information will be used by the department while examining schools' compliance with statutory provisions and other regulatory requirements, it added.

Delhi discoms issue advisory to prevent accidents during rains

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Power discoms in the city on Monday issued an advisory urging people to avoid electricity-related accidents even as they have begun undertaking measures under the Monsoon action plan to minimise moisture-related breakdowns and rain-related disruptions.



A BSES spokesperson said that during the monsoon, waterlogging increases the chances of electricity-related mishaps. Simple precautions like staying away from electrical installations, such as electricity poles, substations, transformers and streetlights, and preventing children from playing near electrical installations, can prevent accidents.

The BSES spokesperson said consumers should also get electrical wiring at their premises checked by a licensed contractor and switch off the main supply in case of waterlogging or leakage in the meter cabin.

Installing an earth leakage circuit breaker helps prevent shocks and mishaps; wet switches need to be avoided, and instead a tester could be used to detect if current is leaking, the official said.

Power theft through hooking can be a serious

safety hazard, especially during the monsoon, and should be avoided, the spokesperson said, and added that the BSES discoms have to, at times, switch off the power supply in vulnerable or waterlogged areas in the interest of public safety.

Talking about the Monsoon action plan, the spokesperson said BSES discoms follow an integrated and proactive approach, and measures are being undertaken to minimise moisture-related breakdowns and rain-related disruptions.

In case of an emergency or power disruption, consumers can reach BSES through call centres, WhatsApp and mobile apps. War rooms have been set up and quick response teams deployed to respond swiftly to monsoon-related exigencies.

BSES has also launched a campaign to sensitise consumers on monsoon safety precautions, the official said.

Doctor dies by suicide, note reveals family opposed marriage to colleague

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 35-year-old senior resident doctor at Delhi's Aruna Asaf Ali Hospital was found dead inside a duty room after completing his night shift, with investigators suspecting suicide after recovering a note indicating he was under emotional distress over his family's opposition to his marriage to a colleague.

The deceased, Dr Simarpreet Singh Anand, was a senior resident in the hospital's anaesthesia department and had served there for around three years. According to police, Anand was on duty from 8 pm on Saturday to 8 am on



Sunday. He was reportedly at work until around 11 pm and then went to the duty room 109.

When he failed to emerge after his shift ended, colleagues tried

calling him and repeatedly knocked on the door.

Receiving no response, hospital authorities were informed. The room, locked from the inside, was forced open around 9 am, and Anand was found lying unconscious on the bed. He was immediately taken to the hospital's emergency department, where doctors declared him dead.

Police said a cannula had been inserted into Anand's left hand around 10 pm on Saturday by a technician assistant at the doctor's request during his shift. The district crime team and the Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) examined the scene and recovered

syringes, empty drug vials, a three-page suicide note and a diary from the room.

According to police sources, the note stated that Anand was in a relationship with a female colleague from Madhya Pradesh, but their marriage could not materialise because both families opposed the alliance as they belonged to different castes. The note reportedly mentioned that he had been under severe emotional stress over the issue.

Originally from Ludhiana in Punjab, Anand had completed his MD in anaesthesia and joined the Delhi government service in 2023. He lived in rented accommodation

in Lajpat Nagar while his family resided in Ludhiana.

Following the incident, Anand's uncle alleged that he had been murdered and levelled accusations against a female doctor employed at the hospital.

However, police said no external injury marks were found on the body, and the room was locked from the inside when it was opened. The duty room has since been sealed and forensic evidence collected.

Police said a board of doctors will conduct the post-mortem to determine the exact cause of death. Further investigation is underway.

Govt reconstitutes child rights commission after three years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has reconstituted the Delhi Commission for Protection of Child Rights, which had remained without a full commission for nearly three years.

The Government appointed Om Prakash Vyas as Chairperson and four others as Members for a three-year term each through a notification issued by the Department of Women and Child Development on the directions of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. The four members appointed alongside Vyas are Rahul Gautam, Kundan Kanskar, Swati Gupta, and Monika Sharma.

All appointments will take effect from the date the respective appointees assume office. The chairperson will serve until the completion of the three-year term or until attaining the age of 65 years, whichever is earlier. For the



Members, the corresponding age limit is 60 years.

The Chief Minister said every child deserves a safe, dignified childhood filled with opportunities and that protecting children's rights remains the Delhi Government's highest priority. She expressed confidence that the commission's new leadership will work with sensitivity, transparency, and responsibility to ensure effective protection of children's rights and said the government remains committed to safeguarding the interests of every child and supporting their holistic development.

The reconstitution comes at a time when child protection has received heightened

attention from the Delhi government. Last month, July was designated Child Protection Month by Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, with the Education Department, Delhi Police, and the Department of Women and Child Development rolling out parallel initiatives across the city.

These include implementing student safety checklists in all 5,633 schools across Delhi, constituting Child Protection Committees in schools, running POCOS awareness campaigns at Anganwadi centres and child care institutions, and training teachers and master trainers on child safety protocols.

L&DO fixes July 30 hearing for Gymkhana Club members

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Land and Development Office (L&DO) will hear members of the Delhi Gymkhana Club on July 30 over the eviction issue following the Delhi High Court's direction that the proceedings before the estate officer be ensured after July 28.

Club member Vijay Khurana and the Delhi Gymkhana Club Staff Welfare Association had challenged the June 29 showcause notice issued by the L&DO as part of eviction proceedings against the club under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, 1971.

Khurana said the members and representatives of the staff association met the estate officer on Tuesday and were given July 30 as the next date to present



their submissions in response to the showcause notice.

"We did not present our side today because the matter is listed before the High Court on July 28. After the court's decision, we will decide what can be placed before the estate officer," Khurana said.

On June 29, the L&DO, under the Union Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, issued a showcause notice asking the club to explain why an eviction order should not be passed. The notice had required a reply by July 7 and fixed a personal hearing on the same day.

Police arrest two fugitive brothers convicted for life after nearly a decade

ABEER MANAV
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police Crime Branch has arrested two fugitive brothers, Firasat Ali and Shah Nawaz, who had been on the run for almost ten years. They avoided imprisonment after their appeal was denied by the Delhi High Court in 2016. The two were caught in separate operations in Moradabad, Uttar Pradesh, and Godda, Jharkhand.

According to the Crime Branch, both brothers were found guilty in a 1996 murder case at Rajouri Garden Police Station. A Delhi court sentenced them to life in prison in 2000, but they were released on bail while their appeal was pending. After the Delhi High Court upheld their conviction in 2016, they failed to surrender to authorities and stayed hidden.

Police reported that



Firasat Ali was also wanted for a 2006 contract killing in Mumbai. Investigators claimed he took a contract worth ₹2 lakh to kill a man and then dismembered the victim's body to hide his identity, disposing of the remains in various locations. The police stated that the deceased's wife allegedly hired him for the job.

The arrests followed close surveillance and intelligence work by the Crime Branch. Based on specific information, two police teams launched simultaneous raids on July 4 in Moradabad and Godda. They arrested both brothers at their hideouts.

Authorities explained that they operated at the same time to prevent either brother from warning the other or escaping.

During questioning, police said Firasat Ali revealed that he had been moving around different areas like Uttar Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana while working as a clothes merchant. Shah Nawaz told investigators he stayed in various locations in Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Jharkhand, making a living in the old clothes trade while avoiding capture.

After their arrest, the brothers were taken to Tihar Jail. The Mumbai Police has been notified about Firasat Ali's arrest, as he remains wanted in connection with the Mumbai contract killing. The Delhi Police confirmed that these arrests resulted from the Crime Branch's ongoing efforts to track down long-time fugitives.



सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India

1911 से आपके लिए "सेन्ट्रल" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

F-344/1, TARA BHAWAN, NEAR QUTAB MINAR, OLD M.B. ROAD, LADO SARAI, NEW DELHI-110030

POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)
[Under Rule 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002]

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Central Bank of India, Lado Sarai Branch, New Delhi under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(2) and 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated 22.04.2026, Calling upon the Borrower: **MR. NIKHIL TIWARI S/O SH. RAM SHARAN TIWARI**, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **Rs.48,02,957.17 (Rupees Forty Eight Lakh Two Thousand Nine Hundred Fifty Seven and Paise Seventeen Only)** (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 22.04.2026), plus interest and other charges from 23.04.2026 to till date within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower having failed to pay the entire dues of the Bank, notice is hereby given to the borrower, the Guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule 2002 on this **04th Day of July 2026**. The borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of the Central Bank of India, Lado Sara Branch, New Delhi for the amount of **Rs.48,02,957.17 (Rupees Forty Eight Lakh Two Thousand Nine Hundred Fifty Seven and Paise Seventeen Only)** (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 22.04.2026), plus interest and other charges from 23.04.2026.

The Borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section (13) of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

Property Bearing No. RZ-F1/136A, Third Floor without Roof Rights, Area Measuring 78 Sq.Yds. i.e. 65.2158 Sq.Mtrs. out of Khasra No.88/3, situated in the Revenue Estate of Village Palam, Delhi State Delhi Colony known as Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi-110045.

Owner - Mr. Nikhil Tiwari S/o Sh. Ram Sharan Tiwari. Bounded By:

North: Other's Property South: 20 Feet Road

East: Property No.RZ-F-1/136 B West: Property No.RZ-F-1/135

PLACE: NEW DELHI (Authorised Officer),

DATE: 04/07/2026 Central Bank of India



सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India

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The Borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section (13) of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY

Property Bearing No. RZ-F1/136 A, Upper Ground Floor without Roof Rights, Area Measuring 78 Sq.Yds. i.e. 65.2158 Sq.Mtrs. out of Khasra No.88/3, situated in the Revenue Estate of Village Palam, Delhi State Delhi Colony known as Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi-110045.

Owner - Mr. Nikhil Tiwari S/o Sh. Ram Sharan Tiwari. Bounded By:

North: Other's Property South: 20 Feet Road

East: Property No.RZ-F-1/136 B West: Property No.RZ-F-1/135

PLACE: NEW DELHI (Authorised Officer),

DATE: 04/07/2026 Central Bank of India

AI ASSETS HOLDING LIMITED

Sealed bids are invited from reputed consultancy firms who have experience in development of hangar facilities at Airports.

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PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mr. Vivek who is purchasing Property No.280/5, First and Second Floor with roof rights, Chuna Mandi, Paharganj, New Delhi-110055 from Mrs. Avinder Kaur W/o Late Amarjeet Singh who had owned the subject property vide Regd. General Power of Attorney dated 06.04.2005, along with Notarized Agreement to sell and Will dated 06.04.2005 executed by Mr. Kamal Chaudhary S/o Mr. Vir Bhau Chaudhary, also to be noted that The chain of title documents for the year of 2005 is severely mutilated and in a highly damaged condition. The said subject property was purchased and mortgage the subject property with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD SO, to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of SMT. SUSHILA DEVI AND MR. SRI PAL who is owner of Plot of land area measuring 240 Square Yards., out of Khewat/Khata No. 200/228, Musil/Killa No. 61 // 112 (1-0), 12 (8-0), 132 (6-0), 141 (6-16), 172 (6-12), 18 (8-0), 23 (8-0), 241 (6-12), 65 // 3/1 (3-11), 4/1 (3-0), situated at Village (Mauza) Bhangrola, Tehsil Harsaru, District, Gurugram; (Hereinafter called The Said Property) having acquired the same vide Transfer Deed dated 15.12.2022 duly registered in the office of SR-Harsaru, as registration No. 13260, Addl. Book No. 1, Page Nos. 135/95-96, Volume No. 57/1160. Dated 15/12/2022 now SMT. SUSHILA DEVI AND MR. SRI PAL intend to mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from Protell Finance Ltd. That Original Sale Deed dated 09.01.2013 duly registered in the office of SR-Harsaru, as registration No. 23964, Addl. Book No. 1, Page Nos. 131/73 to 74, Volume No. 13024/2827. Dated 09/01/2013 has been lost/stolen/placed not available etc. To comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucern Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110049 Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327



CHANGE OF NAME

I, Suleman, Father of No.14870190M Sep/MT Sabbeer Mohammad, R/o-Vill- Titali, Post- Tikar, Teh- Sihawal, Dist- Sidhi, M.P., have changed my name from Suleman to Sulemaan, vide affidavit dated 07/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(078)C

I, Asiniya, Mother of No.14870190M Sep/MT Sabbeer Mohammad, R/o-Vill- Titali, Post- Tikar, Teh- Sihawal, Dist- Sidhi, M.P., have changed my name from Asiniya to Asiniya Begam, vide affidavit dated 07/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(079)C

I, Valsala, Mother of- JC-388474A Sub Prethvial L B, R/o- Vill- Avitanallur, PO- Poonath, Teh- Quilandy, Dist- Kozhikode, Kerala- 673614, have changed my name from Valsala to Valsala Amma, vide affidavit dated 07/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(080)C

I, MR06791Y Colonel U Nandakumar, R/o-Bheemanad Pisharam, PO- Bheemanad, Dist- Palakkad, Kerala- 678601, have expanded my name from U Nandakumar to Unnikrishnan Nandakumar, vide affidavit dated 07/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(081)C

I, JC-472604H Sub Rajendra Singh, R/o- Vill- Khaga, Mohalla- Gadhi Thana- Khaga, Dist- Fatehpur, U.P.- 212655, have changed my daughter's name from Ichha Singh to Yashasvi Singh, vide affidavit dated 07/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(082)C

I, Ajay Kumar s/o Babu Lal (No. 14564694H, Rank Hav) r/o VPO Lukhi, Tehsil Kosli, District Rewari Haryana-123303 hereby declare that in the service records of my father, my name and DOB from Ajay Kumar and 27 Sep., 1989 to Ajay Kumar and 29 Aug., 1990. Hence, my name and date of birth may be read as AJAY KUMAR and 29 Aug., 1990 for all future purposes.

PD(083)C

I, Tarun Sood, S/o Raman Kumar, R/o H-1/13, Vijay Chowk Krishna Nagar, Krishna Nagar East Delhi, Delhi -110051, have changed the name of my minor son Kavissh Sood, aged 13 years, and he shall hereafter be known as Sumeep Sood for all purposes.

PD(084)C

Centre, Delhi to develop ridge into forest land in next 4 years: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Launching the Delhi government's ambitious project to plant 70 lakh saplings and increase green cover under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' campaign across the national capital, Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday said the Centre and Delhi Government have resolved to develop 6,300 hectares of green Ridge area into forest land over the next four years and give legal protection to it to conserve its biodiversity, soil and water of the central ridge.

The Union Home Minister, along with Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, also flagged off 300 electric buses to strengthen the city's public transport

infrastructure. The duo also laid the foundation stone for a multi-level bus depot at an event organised in south Delhi's RK Puram.

As part of the programme, Shah planted a sapling in the Central Ridge area and Nanakpura ridge and said trees such as Peepal, Banyan, Gular, Pilkhan, Jamun, Mango, Arjun, Shishamm, Dhak and Neem that survive for 100 years will be planted along with local shrubs and bamboo. The central ridge is the house of the President's bodyguard complex. The mega tree plantation drive was launched at 34 locations in Delhi.

At the mega sapling plantation, Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav, Lt

Governor TS Sandhu, Lok Sabha MPs Manoj Tiwari and Yogender Chandolia, and Delhi Ministers Parvesh Verma and Manjinder Singh Sirsa were present at the event.

He said that the Delhi government will provide green cover to 6,300 hectares of the ridge area through the plantation of one crore local tree species, 23 lakh big tree species and 65 lakh shrubs and medicinal plants in the next four years.

Shah said that many poisonous and thorny trees are visible in Delhi's Ridge area, which create an illusion of a green Delhi when seen but are not favourable to our environment. He said that in 1994, 7,784 hectares of Delhi's Ridge area were notified under the



Union Minister Amit Shah, Union Minister Bhupender Yadav, CM Rekha Gupta, Ministers Parvesh Verma, Manjinder Singh Sirsa and BJP MP Manoj Tiwari during a plantation drive at Central Ridge in New Delhi

Indian Forest Act, but its final notification was not issued for 30 years. Shah also cited a "grand masterplan" to convert the Ridge into a "Green Ridge", which will have more than 70 water bodies and small restaurants, and its archaeological structures will also be preserved there.

He said eight special forests will be developed in the Ridge area, including Nakshatra Van, Mel Van, Rishi Van, Tirthankar Van, Shankar Van, Vaman Vriksha Van, and Purani Vatika. Through these, efforts will be made to connect people with nature.

"We have formulated the Asola Bhatti Wildlife Sanctuary Management Plan and also prepared Delhi's Bird Atlas. He said this is a comprehensive

effort to restore the entire ecosystem. For years, trees that are not environmentally favourable, including Babul, have spread across the Delhi Ridge, Shah said, adding that these will now be removed and replaced with native tree species.

The Union home minister also flagged off 300 e-buses and digitally laid the foundation stone of a high-security prison in Narela and inaugurated three bus depots and an automated vehicle testing station in Nand Nangri. "Today, 300 buses have been flagged off, and the foundation stone has been laid for a multi-level bus depot to strengthen the city's public transportation and clean mobility," Shah said.

Amit Shah lays foundation stone of high-security prison in Narela

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Tuesday virtually laid the foundation stone for a high-security prison designed with a radial-axial layout in the Narela area of outer Delhi. This facility will accommodate 250 inmates and is expected to be completed in two years, officials said.

The prison will feature AI-enabled CCTV surveillance, body-worn cameras, biometric access control, automatic locking systems, full-body scanners, X-ray baggage scanners, mobile signal jammers, video conferencing facilities, an in-house court complex, anti-tunnelling technology, and a state-of-the-art command and control centre, according to a statement from the Delhi Chief Minister's Office.

This prison is set to become one of the most



modern, technology-driven high-security facilities in the country.

The Ministry of Home Affairs has allocated ₹100 crore for the project, while the Delhi Government will cover the remaining costs, bringing the total estimated expenditure to around Rs 150 crore. The facility will be able to accommodate more than 250 inmates.

Unlike conventional prisons, it will be built on global security standards, having a radial-axial design

to enable monitoring of every wing from a central control point. Each inmate will reside in an individual cell, minimising the chances of interaction, gang networking, and other security risks.

Additionally, each cell will include an independent toilet and bathing facility to reduce unnecessary movement among inmates.

This project aims to set a new benchmark in security, surveillance, rapid response, and technology-driven prison management.

Govt rolls out comprehensive ridge conservation plan for 2026-2030

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Taking a path-breaking initiative for the rejuvenation and scientific restoration and long-term conservation of the "Green Lungs of Delhi," the Delhi government has prepared a comprehensive eco-restoration plan (2026-2030) for the Ridge ecosystems. The eco-restoration plan covers 6,303.55 hectares across all Ridge areas of Delhi and envisages the plantation of more than one crore native plants, including 35.51 lakh trees and 64.97 lakh shrubs, climbers and bamboo.

The programme will restore degraded forest ecosystems through the phased removal of invasive alien species such as Vilayati Keekar (Prosopis juliflora), Subabul (Leucaena leucocephala) and Safeda (Eucalyptus), followed by plantation of indigenous species to improve biodiversity, ecological balance and wildlife habitats.

TABLE: YEAR-WISE ECO-RESTORATION PLANTATION TARGETS					
S. No.	Year	Tentative Area (Hectares)	Tree Saplings	Shrubs, Climbers & Bamboo	Total Saplings
1	2026-27	1,490.00	14,27,160	14,29,200	28,56,360
2	2027-28	1,670.00	7,05,650	18,79,900	25,85,550
3	2028-29	1,450.55	7,09,220	17,34,620	24,43,840
4	2029-30	1,693.00	7,09,370	14,53,000	21,62,370
Total	-	6,303.55	35,51,400	64,96,700	100,48,120

Union Home Minister Amit Shah launched the programme along with the Mission 70 Lakh Tree Plantation Campaign under the 'Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam' initiative.

According to the statement, the programme aims to rejuvenate Delhi's Ridge, the "Green Lungs of Delhi" through scientific forest management, large-scale plantation of native species, restoration of biodiversity, strengthening of ecosystem services and active participation of citizens.

"Based on this approved Working Plan, the Government has formulated the Eco-restoration Plan (2026-2030), providing a sci-

entific roadmap for restoration and sustainable management of Delhi's forests," it said.

The statement said that as the first major milestone under the Eco-restoration Plan, a total of 28,56,360 plants will be planted during 2026-27 across all five Ridge ecosystems of Delhi.

This includes 14,27,160 trees and 14,29,200 shrubs, climbers and bamboo, significantly enhancing biodiversity, strengthening ecosystem resilience, and expanding Delhi's green cover over an area of 1,490 hectares in the Southern and Central Ridge, thereby contributing to long-term ecological

restoration and environmental sustainability.

Complementing the eco-restoration plan, the Government has launched Mission Green Delhi under the Green Action Plan (GAP) 2026-27 with an ambitious target of more than 70 lakh plantations across the national capital.

The programme includes the planting of 20.01 lakh trees, 37.07 lakh shrubs and 92,960 bamboo saplings, along with the free distribution of 12.04 lakh saplings to schools, Resident Welfare Associations, institutions and citizens to encourage Jan Bhagidari in environmental conservation.

As part of the "Dust Free

Delhi Campaign", all major road-owning agencies, including MCD, PWD, NDMC, CPWD, NHAI, DDA and IFCD, will undertake the plantation of approximately 24.35 lakh plants along roadsides, medians, central verges and other public spaces.

The statement said, to improve ecological resilience and water security within Delhi's Ridge forests, eight new water bodies will be created during 2026-27 across the Southern and Central Ridge.

To integrate environmental conservation with India's rich cultural heritage, eight special thematic vans will be developed during 2026-27.

DU officials advise students on CSAS forms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hundreds of undergraduate aspirants and their parents attended admission outreach programmes organised by Miranda House and Hansraj College on Tuesday, where University of Delhi officials advised students to exercise caution while filling their Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) preference sheets.

At Miranda House, more than 200 students and parents attended the second day of the college's Open House Session (Phase II), while over 500 registrations were received for the programme.

Addressing the participants, Dean of Admissions, DU, Haneet Gandhi urged students to carefully fill out their CSAS Phase II preference sheets, stressing that seat allocation would depend on both merit and the order of preferences submitted.

She advised students to pay equal attention to course and subject combinations, multidisciplinary options and career aspirations while preparing their preference lists.

"There should be careful consideration not only of



the college but also of the course, subject combinations and multidisciplinary options. Students should choose subjects according to their interests, abilities and future career goals," Gandhi said. The session was also attended by Joint Dean of Admissions Anand Sonkar, Miranda House Principal Bijayalaxmi Nanda and Vice Principal Seema, who responded to queries from students and parents on admissions.

Participants sought clarification on issues including whether to prioritise a college or a course, the distinction between B.A. (Hons.) and B.A. Programme, multidisciplinary subject choices, admis-

sions through the Extra-Curricular Activities (ECA) and sports quotas, hostel admissions and career-oriented subject selection. The officials advised students to choose programmes based on their interests, aptitude and long-term career plans rather than solely on a college's reputation.

Principal Bijayalaxmi Nanda said the college remained committed to providing timely guidance to students and parents throughout the admission process to help them make informed decisions.

Meanwhile, Hansraj College concluded its two-day admission outreach initiative, "Campus Connect 2026", aimed at familiaris-

ing prospective students and parents with the college's academic programmes, admission process and campus facilities ahead of the University of Delhi undergraduate admissions.

The programme featured interactive sessions with University of Delhi admission officials, faculty members and student volunteers, besides guided campus tours. The inaugural session was attended by Hansraj College Principal Rama, Dean of Admission and others.

Students and parents also interacted with the college administration on scholarships, hostel facilities, internships, placements, research opportunities, student support services and campus life. The participants were later taken on guided tours of the campus, including classrooms, laboratories, the Central Library, seminar halls, sports facilities and other academic infrastructure.

Both colleges said the outreach initiatives were aimed at helping students and parents better understand the undergraduate admission process and make informed academic choices.

Driver held in Jahangirpuri hit-and-run case

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

A man has been arrested for allegedly mowing down a scooter rider with a Mercedes and fleeing the scene in northwest Delhi's Jahangirpuri, marking the latest in a series of fatal hit-and-run cases reported in the Capital.

The accident took place on July 5 near the foot overbridge at the Jahangirpuri Bus Stand on the Outer Ring Road (GTK Bypass towards ISBT). Police received information about a road accident and found the scooter rider critically injured. He was rushed to Babu Jagjivan Ram Memorial Hospital, where doctors declared him dead. The deceased was



identified as Deepak, a resident of Mangolpuri.

During the investigation, a PCR caller provided a crucial lead, informing police that a Mercedes bearing a Haryana registration number had struck the scooter before speeding away. The vehicle was subsequently traced, and after

a notice was served on its registered owner under Section 133 of the Motor Vehicles Act, police learned that Ansh Pratap Singh was driving the car at the time of the crash.

Based on the findings, Singh was identified as the accused and arrested. An FIR has been registered at

Jahangirpuri police station under Sections 281 (rash driving) and 106(1) (causing death by negligence) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. The Mercedes has been seized, and further investigation is underway to establish the exact sequence of events leading to the fatal collision.

The arrest comes days after another fatal hit-and-run case in south Delhi's Vasant Kunj, where 34-year-old Gurugram resident Sarthak Mattoo was killed after his motorcycle allegedly rammed into a Mahindra Thar that made an abrupt lane change on June 25.

Police later arrested the SUV driver, Apurv Singh, for allegedly fleeing the scene without helping the injured rider.

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IN FOCUS



An Indian chameleon perches on a tree branch, in the outskirts of the Hyderabad, Telangana

PTI

Shivraj launches PRAGATI to empower agri-entrepreneurs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Union Minister of Agriculture & Farmers Welfare Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Tuesday launched PRAGATI, a landmark multi-stakeholder initiative that aims to empower 20,000 agri-entrepreneurs and directly support 20 lakh smallholder farmers across India.

The initiative brings together PepsiCo Foundation, SBI Foundation (SBIF), Gates Foundation, IDH, Heifer International, Environmental Defense Fund (EDF), Global Agri Entrepreneurship Academy, Sustainable Agriculture Foundation International Association (SAFIA), Agri Entrepreneur Growth Foundation (AEGF), and Transform Rural India Foundation (TRIF) to build a nationwide ecosystem of agri-entrepreneurs.

Built on a network of over 26,000 agri-entrepreneurs supporting 2.6 million farmers, PRAGATI will add 20,000 new agri-entrepreneurs across Madhya Pradesh, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Assam, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Maharashtra and Rajasthan. The initiative will promote regenerative agriculture through advisory services, mechanisation, soil health, finance, insurance, market linkages and 20,000 entrepreneur-led kiosks,



targeting a 30 per cent increase in farmer incomes, 15–20 per cent higher crop yields, adoption of regenerative agriculture by 20 per cent of participating farmers, and financial inclusion for 50 per cent of associated farmers. Speaking at the launch, Chouhan said the vision of Viksit Bharat cannot be achieved without a developed agricultural sector and prosperous villages. “Our focus is not only on increasing production but also on reducing cultivation costs, enhancing farmers’ incomes, promoting crop diversification and making agriculture more profitable,” he said.

Monica Bauer, Senior Vice President, Global Social Impact, PepsiCo, and President, PepsiCo Foundation, said farmers are at the heart of our business, and strengthening their livelihoods is key to building resilient food systems. “Through PRAGATI, we aim to expand farmers’ access to the tools and knowledge needed for more sustainable agriculture,” he added. Swapan Dhan, MD & CEO, SBI Foundation, said, “PRAGATI brings together institutions with diverse expertise to empower local change-makers who will drive farmer prosperity, climate resilience and financial inclusion across India.” Hisham Mundol, Chief Advisor – India, Environmental Defense Fund, was also present on the occasion.

PM Modi celebrates India-Indonesia ties

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Tuesday praised Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto as a “true friend of India” while expressing gratitude for the warm welcome he received during his State visit to Indonesia.

Addressing members of the Indian community in Jakarta, PM Modi said he was deeply touched by the affection shown by Indonesians, adding that the strong cultural and historical ties between the two nations continue to flourish.

“I sincerely thank President Prabowo for his kind words and support. He is a true friend of India,” the Prime Minister said, noting that the warmth extended to him throughout the visit reflected the deep goodwill Indonesians hold for India.

Referring to the popularity of Indian cinema in Indonesia, Modi mentioned the



Bollywood film Kuch Kuch Hota Hai, saying it has a special place among local audiences. Using the film’s title as a light-hearted analogy, he remarked that cooperation between India and Indonesia results in “much more” than just kuch kuch, underlining the vast potential of the bilateral partnership.

Worker at Badrinath temple suspended over donation theft

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jyotirmath

The four-member committee formed by the Badrinath-Kedarnath Temple Committee (BKTC) to probe allegations of misappropriation of donations made to Badrinath Dham has begun its investigation in the matter.

BKTC chairman Hemant Dwivedi said that initial probe by the committee has prima facie confirmed irregularities, after which the employee in the centre of the allegations- Pramod Nautiyal has been suspended with immediate effect.

He said that the BKTC follows a policy of zero toler-



ance for corruption or irregularities, adding that the guilty will not be spared under any circumstances. The BKTC chief executive

officer Sohan Singh Rangad said that on Tuesday evening, the inquiry committee checked the clarification submitted by accused personal

assistant Pramod Nautiyal which was found to be doubtful. He was suspended with immediate effect and attached to the BKTC’s Jyotirmath office.

Following a letter written by Bhairav Sena to the CEO levelling allegations of misappropriation of donations to the temple, the BKTC chairman ordered formation of an internal investigation committee after the letter went viral on social media. Stating that the findings of the inquiry committee will be made public, he has stressed that strict action will be taken as per the law against anyone found guilty in the investigation.

Delhi LG Sandhu welcomes Kanchi Shankaracharya at India Foundation event

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu welcomed His Holiness Shankaracharya Shri Shankara Vijayendra Saraswati Swamigal of the Sri Kanchi Kamakoti Peetham while presiding over an India Foundation programme at the India Habitat Centre.

Sandhu described the Peetham as a “living civilisational institution” that has preserved India’s spiritual, educational and charitable



traditions for over 2,500 years. Sandhu, who presided over the programme at the Stein Auditorium in the pres-

ence of India Foundation President Ram Madhav, said it was a privilege to host one of India’s oldest living spiri-

tual traditions in the national capital and commended the India Foundation for bringing together policymak-

ers, diplomats and scholars.

Describing the Sri Kanchi Kamakoti Peetham as a living civilisational institution established by Jagadguru Adi Shankaracharya at Kanchipuram, the LG said it has maintained an unbroken lineage of 71 Acharyas while preserving three core pillars: Veda, Vidya and Vaidya.

He said the institution has played a significant role in preserving Vedic scholarship, promoting education through integrated pathshalas and higher educational institutions, and

providing healthcare through a network of charitable medical facilities across the country.

Sandhu also praised the Peetham’s outreach in the North-East and Jammu and Kashmir, saying its initiatives have contributed to strengthening national integration. He further highlighted its efforts in preserving India’s cultural heritage through manuscript digitisation and the revival of traditional temple architecture.

The LG said Delhi, as the nation’s capital and a meeting

point of diverse traditions and communities, continues to draw inspiration from institutions such as the Sri Kanchi Kamakoti Peetham in the country’s journey towards a Viksit Bharat.

Concluding his address, Sandhu said the timeless values nurtured by the Peetham would continue to guide the nation’s progress with wisdom and harmony. He offered his respects to the Shankaracharya and requested His Holiness to bless the gathering with his benedictory address.

BrahMos, Astra head to Indonesia

The two countries also agreed to expand cooperation between their Coast Guards to strengthen maritime safety and security in the Indian Ocean.

The leaders further decided to jointly develop the strategically located Sabang Port, overlooking the Strait of Malacca and situated close to India’s Great Nicobar infrastructure project, a move expected to enhance maritime connectivity and strategic cooperation.

In another significant outcome, India and Indonesia signed an agreement to strengthen supply chain resilience in critical minerals and steel. Indian companies will invest in manufacturing stainless steel, nickel and rare-earth permanent magnets in Indonesia, sectors seen as vital for clean energy technologies and advanced manufacturing.

“In today’s world, supply chain resilience in technology has become critically important. We have concluded an important agreement to strengthen supply chain resilience in critical minerals and steel,” Modi said.

The two countries also agreed to integrate India’s Unified Payments Interface (UPI) with Indonesia’s payment system, a move expected to facilitate trade, tourism and business transactions.

Among the other agreements were pacts covering medicines, food security, telecommunications, outer space, research and innovation, education and cultural exchanges.

Announcing a major educational initiative, Modi said the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Bangalore will establish a campus in Indonesia, further strengthening academic cooperation.

The two sides also agreed to deepen collaboration in the space sector through joint research, technology sharing and capacity building.

On global issues, Modi reiterated India’s emphasis on dialogue and diplomacy in addressing international conflicts. “In this period of global turbulence, India believes that the role of dialogue and diplomacy has become more important than ever before,” he said, while reaffirming India’s support for a two-state solution to the Palestine issue and lasting peace in West Asia.

Highlighting the deep civilisational links between the two nations, Modi announced that India and Indonesia would jointly commemorate the centenary of Rabindranath Tagore’s historic visit to Indonesia by observing the Tagore-

Dewantara Year of Cultural and Educational Diplomacy, honouring the shared intellectual legacy of Tagore and Indonesia’s first Education Minister, Ki Hajar Dewantara.

The agreements signed on Tuesday signal a broad-based expansion of India-Indonesia ties, with defence, maritime security, critical minerals and strategic connectivity emerging as the key pillars of the growing partnership.

Gadkari dares E20 critics, claims no vehicle...

The Ministry of Road Transport and Highways has proposed amendments to vehicle emission rules to widen the scope for higher ethanol blends and alternative fuels, paving the way for flex-fuel and pure bio-fuel vehicles across all vehicle categories.

The draft changes to the Central Motor Vehicles Rules, 1989 aim to provide for wider use of fuels, such as E85 (85 per cent ethanol with petrol) and E100 (which would allow vehicles to run on nearly pure ethanol), as well as B100 bio-diesel and hydrogen-CNG combinations.

CBI files RCFL chargesheet

The agency said its investigation showed that the funds borrowed by RCFL were diverted through intermediary and conduit entities to various Reliance ADA Group companies, in violation of the terms and conditions governing such borrowings, thereby causing wrongful loss to the lending banks and corresponding wrongful gain to the accused persons and related entities. “It may be recalled that the CBI had registered the case based on complaints received from Bank of Maharashtra and other PSU banks of the consortium. The total loss caused to 13 public sector banks is ₹4,097 crore,” the spokesperson said.

The CBI has kept the investigation open into the alleged role of directors, entities and public servants involved in causing wrongful loss to the public sector banks and is likely to file supplementary chargesheets. The agency had earlier arrested former vice chairman of Reliance Capital Ltd Amitabh Jhunjhunwala, former CEO of RCFL Devang Pravin Mody, and former CFO of Reliance Capital Ltd Amit Bapna. Jhunjhunwala and Mody are presently in judicial custody, while Bapna is in CBI custody, the spokesperson said. The officials said probe into the role of Jhunjhunwala and Bapna is still going on.

FROM PAGE - 1

The CBI has registered seven FIRs against Reliance Communications Ltd (RCom), RHFL, RCFL and Reliance Telecom Ltd (RTL) on the basis of complaints received from various public sector banks and the LIC.

As Ram temple trust targets overhaul, Rai...

The Trust has announced plans to improve its administrative and financial systems. This includes possibly appointing a Chief Executive Officer and reviewing how donations are managed. A small committee will suggest changes to help prevent future problems.

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, which manages the construction and running of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, has been in the national spotlight since the temple was consecrated. Swami Govind Dev Giri asked devotees and the public not to believe rumours, to check records themselves, and to trust the judicial process. “Theft is theft,” he said, emphasising that those responsible must face justice and that the controversy should not weaken the faith of Ram bhakts.

As the trust prepares for its next meeting, its main goal is to restore strong governance and ensure the temple remains a symbol of unity, devotion, and transparent management.

HC upholds death for 38 in Ahmedabad serial...

The remaining 11 received life imprisonment. The convicts challenged both the conviction and the sentence before the High Court.

The High Court fully upheld the trial court’s findings after reviewing evidence, including call records, forensic reports, witness statements, CCTV footage and confessions. The judges said the prosecution had proven the conspiracy, the execution, and each accused person’s role beyond a reasonable doubt. The court called the verdict one of the strongest and most historic in India’s fight against terrorism, sending a clear message of “zero mercy” to those who target civilians.

On July 26, 2008, 21 bombs exploded in crowded markets, buses, and hospitals across Ahmedabad in just 70 minutes. The attacks, carried out by members of the banned group Indian Mujahideen (IM), killed 56 people and injured over 200. Bombs were meticulously planned, using timer devices and targeting civilian areas to maximise casualties and

Runway scare at Mumbai airport

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

A serious runway conflict was narrowly averted at Mumbai’s Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport on late evening Tuesday, when a Delhi-bound Air India (AI) flight was instructed to abort its takeoff as another AI flight was landing on the same runway.

According to airport sources, the AI aircraft was cleared for departure to Delhi when the AI flight, arriving from Kochi, approached for landing on the same active runway. On instructions from Air Traffic Control (ATC), the Air India crew immediately discontinued the takeoff roll and returned safely to the bay.

In an official statement, AI confirmed the incident involving flight AI816 and emphasised that safety protocols were followed.

This marks the second reported ground incident involving AI in less than a month. Earlier, an AI and an IndiGo aircraft came face-to-face on the ground at Ahmedabad airport, triggering safety concerns.

A joint investigation by aviation authorities has been initiated to determine the exact sequence of events and identify any lapses in runway management or communication at Mumbai airport.

in other states, where some BLOs deployed during similar voter revision exercises complained of excessive work pressure, and some also died by suicide.

Sharma, who commutes daily from Aligarh to Delhi, said the long working hours have taken a physical toll. “It’s a part of our jobs, but still it is quite taxing. Let’s see if the exercise is completed by July 29. It’s a difficult month,” he said.

Five dead in Kerala landslide at tunnel site

In an earlier statement, the district administration said a total of 18 persons were affected by the disaster. Of them, three were killed, 10 are undergoing treatment at Meppadi WIMS Hospital, and the search is on for five others who are still missing. Officials said those living in nearby areas were being evacuated.

A senior Government official told reporters that there were no workers at the site and that those feared trapped under the mud were engineers and security staff. “If work had been going on there, it would have been a bigger tragedy,” she said. A private bus reportedly used to ferry workers, which was parked at the site, was pushed into the nearby river by the landslide and was lying half-submerged as water flowed through it.

Sniffer dogs of the state police have been deployed at the site to trace those trapped under the thick mud, the statement said. It also said facilities had been made available at the Mundakkai Forest Station and the Chooralmala church hall to shift locals, including members of tribal communities, stranded on both sides of the bridge.

“It is an unfortunate incident. Rescue efforts are under way,” Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan said. He added that the necessary rescue forces were reaching the area and that police as well as fire and rescue personnel had already been deployed at the site. Additionally, a defence team was on standby in Thrissur and could be deployed at the site if required, the CM said. All necessary systems for search and rescue would be put in place as soon as possible, he assured.

Kerala Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala and Agriculture Minister T Siddique said the incident at the Kalladi tunnel project site was not a natural landslide but a “man-made” one caused by the unscientific dumping of excavated earth. “This is not a natural landslide. It is a man-made one. It occurred due to the unscientific dumping of excavated earth,” Siddique told reporters.

IIM Bangalore to set up campus in Indonesia, says PM Modi

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India and Indonesia on Tuesday signed a series of agreements to deepen cooperation in technology, education, startups and space, with Prime Minister Narendra Modi announcing that the Indian Institute of Management Bangalore (IIM Bangalore) will establish a branch campus at Singhasari Special Economic Zone (SEZ) in Indonesia.

The announcement came after bilateral talks between Prime Minister Modi and Indonesian President Prabowo Subianto during the Prime Minister's official visit to Jakarta. The two leaders reaffirmed their commitment to expanding collaboration in emerging technologies while creating greater opportunities for the youth of both countries.

Addressing a joint press conference, Modi said India and Indonesia would leverage their demographic strengths by strengthening cooperation in artificial intelligence (AI), telecommunications and digital public infrastructure.

"The 21st century is driven by technology. Both India and Indonesia are nations brimming with youthful energy, and our youth possess a natural aptitude for technology," the Prime Minister said.

He said the two sides had signed a "significant agreement" to enhance technological cooperation in AI, telecommunications and digital public infrastructure, while also agreeing to deepen collaboration between startups in the two countries.

A key outcome of the visit was the decision to establish an overseas campus of IIM



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with Indonesia's President Prabowo Subianto during an Indian community event, in Jakarta, Indonesia

Bangalore in Indonesia. "We are going to establish a campus of India's prestigious management institute, IIM Bangalore, in Indonesia. This will greatly benefit the youth across the entire ASEAN region," Modi said.

The proposed campus at Singhasari SEZ is expected to strengthen India's educational engagement with Southeast Asia and provide world-class management education to students from Indonesia and across the ASEAN region.

Welcoming the announcement, Pan-IIT Chairman Prabhath Kumar said the decision reflects India's emergence as a trusted global knowledge and innovation partner. "The announcement on setting up the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Bangalore branch campus at Singhasari SEZ, Indonesia, by Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi reflects India's emergence as a trusted global knowledge and innovation partner. These initiatives will strengthen research, entrepreneurship, talent development and academic collaboration across continents," Prabhath Kumar said in

a statement.

He noted that the Indian Institutes of Technology already have a strong and active presence across ASEAN through the Government of India's ASEAN PhD Fellowship Programme (APFP), which enables talented students from ASEAN member countries to pursue doctoral studies at India's premier technological institutions. "PanIIT welcomes this growing international footprint of India's premier institutions under the leadership of Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi," Kumar added.

India and Indonesia also agreed to deepen cooperation in the space sector through joint research, technology sharing and capacity building. "We have shared a trusted, decades-long partnership in the space sector. Building upon this, key decisions regarding joint research, technology sharing and capacity building have been taken today," Modi said. The Prime Minister also announced that both countries would share best practices in sustainable agriculture and agro-tech-

nology as part of efforts to broaden cooperation across key sectors.

Earlier in the day, Modi received a ceremonial welcome in Jakarta, where President Prabowo accorded him a Guard of Honour, accompanied by horse-mounted escorts and traditional cultural performances. The two leaders greeted each other warmly before holding delegation-level talks. Ahead of the visit, Modi had said his tour of Indonesia, followed by Australia and New Zealand, would reinforce India's Act East Policy, MAHASAGAR Vision and commitment to a free, open and inclusive Indo-Pacific.

During his visit, the Prime Minister is also scheduled to interact with members of the Indian diaspora and accompany President Prabowo to the UNESCO World Heritage-listed Prambanan Temple Complex in Yogyakarta, symbolising the deep civilisational ties between India and Indonesia. The Indonesia visit marks the first leg of Modi's three-nation tour, after which he will travel to Australia and New Zealand.

Ram temple cash spent on iPhone, car, confesses accused Avinash Shukla

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

■ New Delhi/Ayodhya

In a major development in the Ram Temple donation embezzlement case, Avinash Shukla has admitted to spending nearly ₹19 lakh of the stolen money on family, friends, and personal luxuries. This included buying his girlfriend an expensive iPhone. While being questioned at Ayodhya's Reserve Police Lines, Shukla confessed to taking a large amount of cash from the donation boxes at the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Temple.

Sources said Shukla spent about ₹6 lakh on his brother's wedding, gave ₹5-6 lakh to another brother, and bought a car worth around ₹3.5 lakh. Police have already recovered the car.

He also transferred ₹2.5 lakh to a friend, who, according to some reports, is his girlfriend, and gave her a high-end iPhone. Smaller amounts went to other relatives and associates. Shukla is believed to have kept the largest share among the accused, about ₹20 lakh in



total. Police recovered ₹20.39 lakh in cash, \$1,121, gold and silver jewellery, and an SUV from him. Investigators have questioned his brothers and are tracking bank transfers, land deals in a sibling's name, and other assets bought with the stolen money.

The case involves eight staff members accused of regularly stealing cash from hundi boxes during the temple's donation counting. Shukla and the others

reportedly checked CCTV camera locations, monitored staff movements, and planned exit routes before hiding cash in washrooms and retrieving it in small amounts. Shukla's detailed spending has given investigators new leads to track the flow of money. Police are now working to recover funds sent to various people and to determine whether other accused members also spent the money on luxuries.

These revelations have put more focus on how the temple manages donations. The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust has accepted the resignations of key officials during the investigation, while a Special Investigation Team continues to review accounts and procedures. Shukla's confession is a major development in this sensitive case, raising concerns about how devotee offerings are handled.

Ayodhya Police officials are expected to question the other accused further as they work to recover the remaining stolen money and uncover the full extent of the conspiracy.

Ram temple donations safe, trust assures public

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Ayodhya

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust on Tuesday stated that it holds more than 30 kg of gold-like items and 1,518 kg of silver-like items, along with other valuables donated by devotees. The announcement comes amid allegations of embezzlement of donations at the temple.

Its Treasurer, Mahant Govind Dev Giri, said that all 2,926 valuable articles donated to the temple were "safe" and that their records were maintained. He gave the details after the Trust on Monday displayed several offerings to the temple, like a gold 'Ramcharitmanas' and a diamond-studded necklace, before the media.

A silver 'charan paduka' and a silver 'Kakbhushundi' artefact, which some social media posts claimed were missing or unaccounted for, were also displayed to the media. The Trust stated that the valuables include gold, silver, and diamond-studded ornaments, artefacts, crowns, necklaces, 'charan



paduka', silver bricks, and other offerings donated by devotees since the consecration of the Ram temple. He stated that each donated article is recorded in the inventory with donor details, date of donation, and other relevant information. Referring to the silver Kakbhushundi artefact donated by Anita Bharadwaj, Giri confirmed that items subject to speculation remain secure in the temple's custody. Giri reported that the Trust received 16.765 kg of gold-like items up to March 31, 2024, 10.445 kg in 2024-25, and 5.050 kg in 2025-26, totalling 32.259 kg as of March 31, 2026. The Trust's silver holdings include both original silver articles and 849.272 kg of refined silver processed under

government supervision.

Presenting the Trust's inventory, Giri stated it holds 1,518.925 kg of silver and silver-like items, including 849.272 kg of refined silver and 32.259 kg of gold-like items as of March 31, 2026. He stated that all donated articles are recorded and undergo annual physical verification by an independent chartered accountant firm.

Giri added that silver articles sent for refining are processed through the Government of India Mint, with photographs, weight records, and purity certificates maintained. Every donor receives a receipt. He requested that anyone with evidence of irregularities submit it to the Special Investigation Team (SIT) rather than make unverified allegations. At its meeting on Monday, the Trust decided to strengthen its administrative and financial systems in response to the controversy regarding the alleged embezzlement of donations. Trust documents show that a chief executive officer (CEO) will be appointed to oversee administration and improve institutional functioning.

ED raids Kolkata firms over suspected TMC funds

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

■ Kolkata/New Delhi

On Tuesday, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) searched several locations in Kolkata over claims that suspect funds were routed through bank accounts tied to the Trinamool Congress (TMC). Officials said the early-morning operation covered about five sites in the city.

Officials said initial findings indicate that more than Rs 150 crore may have passed through aviation and travel companies. The investigation is centred on Carewell Aviation, a charter plane company in Kolkata, its directors, and an alleged electoral trust. ED teams are checking documents and financial records at sites on Central Avenue and in Rajarhat-New Town.

This action by the central agency comes as the TMC faces internal conflict over its finances. Last month, Kolkata Police froze debit operations on three party bank accounts after complaints from rebel MLAs who wanted an investigation into the funds' origins. These accounts reportedly hold about Rs 440 crore and make up a large part of the party's finances. The freeze has led to a legal



dispute. On July 2, the Calcutta High Court, while hearing a petition from the Mamata Banerjee-led TMC group challenging the freeze, told the private bank involved to reveal the exact amount in the accounts.

The political impact is not limited to West Bengal. Sources say Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla is likely to decide on whether to disqualify rebel TMC MPs before the Monsoon session of Parliament starts on July 20. This comes after the main party called for action against the defectors.

Reports say the ED is also looking into how chartered flights used by senior TMC leaders were funded, expanding the investigation beyond just bank accounts. There are claims that payments for these flights connected to Carewell Aviation may have

come from questionable sources, such as alleged cut money and protection rackets. TMC MLA Ritabrata Banerjee is said to have raised these concerns in a complaint.

The ED, which investigates cases under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), is working to trace the full banking trail of these transactions. Officials said more information will be shared after the searches end. So far, no arrests have been made.

The ED's action has made things harder for the TMC, which faces internal divisions and scrutiny from central agencies. The party's finances are still a key issue in its ongoing power struggle. Many people are waiting to see what the searches uncover and what actions the ED or courts will take next.

Rwandans and friends of Rwanda mark Kwibohora32 in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The High Commission of the Republic of Rwanda in India celebrated the 32nd Anniversary of Rwanda Liberation Day (Kwibohora32) in the national Capital on Monday, highlighting Rwanda's journey of resilience, national renewal, and expanding international cooperation.

Minister of State for External Affairs and Textiles Pabitra Margherita was the chief guest on the occasion. In his speech, he commended Rwanda's exceptional efforts towards reconciliation following the tragic events of the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. He also praised the strong and growing partnership between Rwanda and India, and recognised Rwanda as an inspirational development model.

According to a Press release, the celebration brought together approximately 1,000 distinguished guests, including officials from the Government of India; members of the diplomatic corps comprising Heads of Mission, Diplomats and Defence Attachés representing 140 countries; the delegation from Rwanda's Ministry of Defence currently in New Delhi to attend the 2nd Rwanda – India Joint Defence Cooperation Committee (JDCC); business leaders; scholars; media professionals; civil society representatives; friends of Rwanda; and members of the Rwandan community residing in



Minister of State for External Affairs and Textiles Pabitra Margherita exchange greetings with High Commissioner of Rwanda to India Jacqueline Mukangira in the national Capital on Monday

India. The programme featured remarks on business and investment opportunities in Rwanda by Indian investors in Rwanda, Freddy Vinay and Saurabh Singhal, as well as Romit Shah, a friend of Rwanda.

The speakers highlighted Rwanda's favourable business environment and investment opportunities, underscoring the country as an attractive destination for international investors. In her remarks,

Jacqueline Mukangira, High Commissioner of Rwanda to India, reflected on Rwanda's history, characterised by colonial divisions, discriminatory governance, and the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi. She paid tribute to the men and women of the Rwandan Patriotic Army (RPA), whose sacrifices restored peace, unity and national dignity.

Mukangira mentioned that the liberation victory of July 4, 1994,

marked a defining moment in restoring Rwanda's sovereignty and laying the foundations for national reconstruction. She commended the leadership of Paul Kagame, President of the Republic of Rwanda, who not only led the liberation struggle but also guided the nation towards a new path of progress and transformation following Rwanda's Liberation.

The High Commissioner further highlighted Rwanda's 32 years of progress, supported by figures reflecting significant achievements in economic development, security and good governance, and social sectors. She also showcased Rwanda's investment and tourism potential, encouraging Indians to expand their investments in the country.

She expressed appreciation to Rwanda's international partners, with particular recognition given to India for its continued contribution to Rwanda's development journey. She underscored the expanding cooperation between Rwanda and India across areas including education, information and communication technology, trade, investment and defence, while reaffirming Rwanda's commitment to peace, justice and stronger global partnerships. The ceremony also celebrated the rich cultural heritage of both nations through performances by Rwandan students and an Indian cultural troupe from Haryana.

Trouble erupts widely in PoK: From flour bills to freedom calls

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

■ New Delhi/Srinagar

Pakistan-occupied Kashmir is facing its worst unrest in years. Markets are closed, roads are blocked, and security forces are stationed throughout Muzaffarabad, Rawalakot, Mirpur, Bhimber, and Kotli. What started as frustration over electricity and flour prices has now become a wider challenge to Islamabad's authority.

In early June of this year, the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC), which includes traders, students, lawyers, and civil society members, called for a region-wide strike. They demanded subsidised flour and electricity, an end to power cuts, the release of detained activists, and political reforms.

The Tensions rose when authorities banned JAAC



under anti-terror laws and arrested several leaders, which sparked even more protests. Thousands of people took to the streets. At Neelum Bridge in Muzaffarabad, clashes became deadly. Reports say 11 people died, including seven civilians and four police officers, and dozens were injured. Rangers reportedly opened fire, leaving at least 8 people in critical condition. Tear gas, baton charges, internet shutdowns, and a communication black-

out followed. JAAC responded by calling for peaceful marches with white flags, urging 50,000 people per district to join.

Protesters say rising prices were only the beginning. Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir (PoJK) has faced economic stagnation for years. There is little industry, few jobs, and the region relies on federal subsidies. Roads, hospitals, and schools are still underdeveloped. Meanwhile, hydropower projects supply electricity to

Pakistan's national grid, but locals still face 12-16-hour power cuts and high tariffs.

Residents in Rawalakot highlighted a contradiction: PoJK produces about 5,000 MW of electricity but receives only about 500 MW for local use. They also claim that forests, minerals, and rivers are exploited without any reinvestment in the region.

The region's unclear constitutional status makes things worse. Since PoJK is not a full province, major development and budget decisions are made in Islamabad rather than by local representatives. This has led to feelings of political marginalisation, which activists say drives every protest.

This time, the protests feel different. In addition to demanding rights, some protesters have been seen waving Indian flags and

calling for a merger with India. JAAC leaders and other activists have also publicly asked India for food and medicine, saying there are shortages during the shutdown.

India's Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) condemned what it described as "severe police brutality" and called for the world to pay attention to human rights in PoK. Over 50 United Kingdom (UK) MPs also wrote to their Foreign Secretary about the crackdown and the communication blackout. The administration says the measures are to maintain law and order. Officials have indicated a willingness to discuss "some issues" but have not rolled back the JAAC. With local elections set for July 27, 2026, the situation is even more tense. The ban on JAAC has not stopped the protests; instead, it has spread them out. Student groups such as

the Jammu and Kashmir National Students' Federation have held rallies demanding "freedom from Pakistan," while traders keep pushing for economic changes.

Security analysts say three fault lines are now exposed: "economic survival, political representation, and identity". For years, dissent in PoJK was managed with subsidies and limited autonomy. This time, subsidies aren't enough, and autonomy is the demand, making the thesis clear. The situation is still changing. If Islamabad only responds with security measures, the protests could grow. Right now, PoJK's 4.39 million people are seeing if ongoing, peaceful protests can bring real change. The outcome will affect not only daily life in the region but also how Pakistan talks about Kashmir.

TMC infighting to clear BJP path for 3 RS seats

SAUGARSEN GUPTA

■ Kolkata

With the Opposition Trinamool Congress a divided house, Bengal's ruling BJP is confident of winning all three Rajya Sabha seats that go to the polls on July 24.

With about 65 out of the 80 TMC MLAs breaking away from former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's control to form a separate group, there is hardly any chance of the principal Opposition party putting up a united fight to clinch at least one seat, experts believe.

On the other hand, the ruling BJP, with 208 members in the State Assembly, is confident of winning all three seats. "Numbers are with us... one of our candidates will get 70, and the remaining two will get 69 votes ... and if there is



cross-voting then we may expect to get many more votes... TMC and Mamata Banerjee's Kalighat faction is a lost case... it does not stand a remote chance," said a BJP MLA from Kolkata. The nomination formally started on Tuesday. The three seats fell vacant with three TMC MPs, Sukhendu Shekhar Roy, Sushmita Dev and Prakash Chik Baraik, resigning their posts soon after the saffron party came to power with a thumping victory on May 4.

States Focus



BIHAR: BJP FIELDS ABHISHEK KUMAR FOR BANKIPUR BYPOLL

The BJP on Tuesday announced its candidate for the Bankipur Assembly bypoll in Bihar, fielding Abhishek Kumar from the seat. The Bankipur Assembly by-election will be held on July 30, and the votes polled will be counted on August 3. The vacancy arose following the resignation of BJP national president Nitin Nabin as an MLA from the seat in Bihar. Nabin was sworn in as a Rajya Sabha member. Kumar has been named as the BJP candidate from the seat for bypolls with the approval of the party's Central Election Committee (CEC), according to a notification issued by BJP national general secretary Arun Singh. Jan Suraj Party founder Prashant Kishor is contesting from the Bankipur Assembly seat that had elected Nabin five times in a row.

(PTI)



RAM TEMPLE ROW IS THEFT OF FAITH: HIMACHAL CM SUKHU

Himachal Pradesh Chief Minister Sukhvir Singh Sukhu stated on Tuesday that the controversy surrounding donations for the Ram temple involved not only the theft of funds but also the theft of the faith held by millions of devotees across the country.

During his visit to a Ram temple in Shimla, where he offered prayers and participated in 'kirtan', the chief minister emphasised that "Hindu culture teaches respect for all religions, and true followers of Lord Ram do not engage in politics in his name." Sukhu mentioned that state cabinet members had also prayed at the Ram Mandir, hoping that those responsible for misusing temple donations would find their way to righteousness. He noted that individuals collecting donations or engaging in politics in the name of Lord Ram and religion should do so with honesty and integrity. He said that while the Central Government had announced a half-day holiday for the Pran Pratishtha (consecration) ceremony of Ram Lalla, the Himachal Pradesh Government had declared a full-day public holiday. Sukhu stated that the credit for initiating the process for the construction of the Ram Mandir primarily belongs to former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi, under whose leadership the locks of the Ram Janmabhoomi site were opened.

(PTI)

Indonesia award for PM slap on Islamophobia narrative: BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Tuesday said Indonesia's highest civilian honour for Prime Minister Narendra Modi is a "resounding slap" on the Opposition for spreading the "Islamophobia narrative". The latest honour is a strong endorsement of India's diplomacy under Modi, the party asserted.

The remarks came after Prime Minister Modi on Tuesday was conferred with Indonesia's highest civilian honour, the 'Bintang Adipurna of the Republic of Indonesia'.

BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla said the latest recognition reflects growing global trust in Modi's leadership and India's rising stature on the world stage.

"Today is a difficult day for Modi baiters, diplomacy doubters and Islamophobia insurgents," he said in a video statement.

Referring to Indonesia as the country with the highest Muslim population, he said



BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla

the honour also demolishes allegations that Modi and his Government are "anti-Muslim".

"But there is yet another significant aspect of this national civilian honour that has been given to him. It has been conferred by Indonesia, which has the highest Muslim population.

"And this is not the first award he is getting from a Muslim nation. Saudi Arabia, Palestine, Maldives, United Arab Emirates, Bahrain, Egypt and Oman — all Muslim nations — have given the highest civilian honour to

Prime Minister Modi," he said. Poonawalla alleged that the honours conferred by Muslim-majority countries expose the Opposition's "Islamophobia narrative".

There goes the Islamophobia narrative, crashing down. Are Prime Minister Modi and his Government anti-Muslim? And despite that, these Governments are giving him the highest civilian honour? Obviously not," he said.

"So today, those who have been doubting our diplomacy and those who have been insurgents of the

Islamophobia narrative have got a resounding slap from the highest civilian honour being given to Prime Minister Modi," Poonawalla added.

The BJP spokesperson said India's diplomacy under Modi has earned the confidence of countries and helped India emerge as a bridge in a divided world.

"Be it the Western camp or the Eastern camp, be it Russia or Ukraine, be it Israel or Palestine, all of them trust Modi, and India has emerged as a bridge between a divided world," Poonawalla said.

Poonawalla claimed Modi has received well over 30 international civilian honours, more than all previous prime ministers put together.

"He has received well over 30 such civilian honours. If you put all the other prime ministers together — Nehru ji, Indira ji, Rajiv ji, Manmohan Singh ji and others — they do not add up to even half of that. That, in itself, is an indication of how the world trusts Prime Minister Modi," he said.

NCERT amends Class 8 textbook after SC directive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Months after it stoked a controversy for allegedly defaming the judiciary, the NCERT has released a revised Class 8 Social Science textbook dropping the disputed portions.

The controversial portions along with references to judicial backlog and two major court verdicts have been dropped while fresh material on Public Interest Litigation (PIL), tribunals and alternative dispute resolution mechanisms has been added in the revised textbook.

The opening "Big Questions" section at the start of the chapter has also seen a change. Instead of asking students why an independent judiciary is necessary, as the withdrawn textbook did, the revised chapter asks why justice is important for a "just and harmonious society".

Gone entirely is the section on "Challenges Faced by the Judicial System", which had detailed the



"massive backlog" of cases and blamed it on a shortage of judges, cumbersome procedures and weak infrastructure.

Also excised is the section titled "Corruption in the judiciary", which had cited former Chief Justice of India B R Gavai as acknowledging instances of "corruption and misconduct" within the judicial system.

In February, a controversy broke out over the National Council of Educational Research and Training's (NCERT) Class 8

Social Science textbook, which included a section on "Corruption in the judiciary" in a chapter.

After the Supreme Court's intervention, the physical and digital copies of the textbook were withdrawn and the NCERT issued an apology.

The top court imposed a "complete blanket ban" on any further publication, reprinting or digital dissemination of the said textbook, saying it contained "offending" content on corruption in the judiciary.

The revised textbook states in its acknowledgements that it has been published pursuant to the review process undertaken "in compliance with the directions of the Hon'ble Supreme Court of India" in suo motu writ petition (civil) no. 1/2026.

It adds that Chapter 4, "The Role of the Judiciary in Society", was "rewritten" by an expert committee constituted by the Union Ministry of Education following the directions of the apex court through an order dated March 16.

Telangana CM orders setup of digital governance panel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy on Tuesday directed officials to constitute a committee to strengthen 'digital governance' in the State.

Reddy, who held a meeting with officials, said the committee, comprising officials, should submit its report in 100 days. He sought details of the implementation of 'digital governance' and instructed officials to formulate plans for digital governance and draft relevant legislation, a release said.

The CM emphasised that the administration should move towards full-scale digitisation. The main objective of the State Government is to



Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy

provide better services to the public and ensure that welfare schemes reach beneficiaries directly through digital governance, it said.

The chief minister, who held a review of the problems being faced by contract and outsourcing employees, enquired about the digitisation of data concerning contract and outsourcing staff.

He told officials to digitise all the data and ensure that salaries to contract and outsourcing staff are paid on the first day of every month.

Reddy said strict action must be taken against agencies that are not paying salaries promptly to contract and outsourcing employees even after the release of funds by the Government.

Bengaluru street vendors call for strike over ongoing eviction drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The street vendors' associations have called for a massive protest and total shutdown of their activities in the city on Wednesday against the ongoing eviction drive being carried out in Bengaluru.

The associations have accused the state government of "violating" the Street Vendors (Protection of Livelihood and Regulation of Street Vending) Act, 2014.

"On July 8, we have called for a massive protest, there will be a bandh... Street vending in all the city's major markets will cease. We appeal to street vendors who are not part of any association to join us," Advocate and activist associated with street vendors,



Vinay Srinivasa, said.

Speaking to reporters, he said this fight is just the beginning. "If the Government fails to respond, there will be a call for a statewide protest."

"A minimum of five to six thousand people are likely to gather for the protest on June 8 (at Freedom Park in Bengaluru)," he added.

Will not allow communalisation of education: Kerala minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kozhikode (Kerala)

Kerala Minister Roji M John on Tuesday said the State Government would not allow any attempt to "communalise" the education sector and would strongly oppose such moves.

Responding to a question from a student during an interaction organised by the Calicut University Union, the state higher education minister said there would be no compromise on protecting the secular and democratic character of educational institutions.

"We will not allow any attempt to communalise the education sector at any level. Educational institutions must impart not only knowledge but also values such as sec-



Kerala Minister Roji M John

ularism and democracy," he said. "Campuses should remain democratic and secular spaces. We will strongly resist any attempt to introduce communal ideas or influences into them," he added.

John had earlier alleged that attempts were being made to "saffronise" the higher education sector after Kerala Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar appointed persons of his choice to the governing bodies of universities, including to the posts of vice-chancellors.

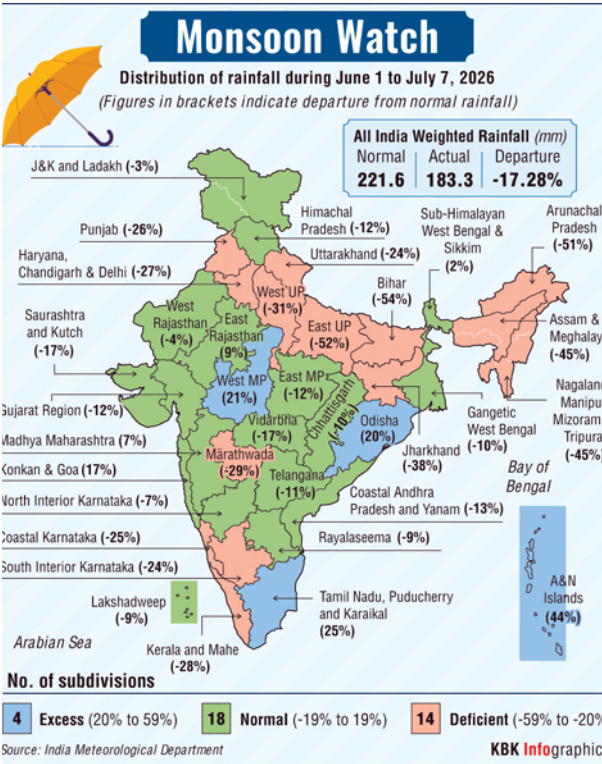
Climate change altering behaviour of Indian monsoon: Experts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

El Niño, the recurrent weather pattern that drives up global temperatures, and climate change cannot be viewed independently, as one is delaying the rains and the other intensifying them, according to climate experts.

A rapidly strengthening El Niño in the Pacific delayed the onset of the monsoon and kept rainfall subdued through June, leaving India with a 40 per cent rainfall deficit by the end of the month. Yet, within days, the scenario changed dramatically. As the monsoon entered an active phase by the end of June, Mumbai and large parts of India's West Coast were battered by exceptionally intense rainfall.

Experts say the new reality is that climate change is fundamentally altering the behaviour of the Indian monsoon.



"Monsoon is presently in an active phase, with several weather systems prevailing across the country. There was a depression over Odisha and a cyclonic circulation over Maharashtra, keeping the western and eastern arms of the monsoon active," said Mahesh Palawat, Vice President - Meteorology and Climate Change, Skymet Weather.

"Along with this, continuous moisture feed from the Arabian Sea led to continuous regeneration of clouds over Maharashtra in the last three to four days, leading to heavy rainfall," Palawat said.

Raghu Murtugudde, Emeritus Professor, University of Maryland and retired professor, IIT-Mumbai, explained that Mumbai saw a delayed onset of monsoon, which is partly explainable by El Niño. "But the global warming pattern of warm Western Asia and shifted Arabian Sea winds have kicked in as expected. Lots of winds as

well, which is part of the larger heavy rain over the core monsoon zone. Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal are both feeding heavy rain in the interior. El Niño just cannot be separated from global warming anymore.

"Both the Arabian Sea and the Bay of Bengal are active, and a low-pressure system is also starting from the Bay of Bengal. When this happens, and both sides fire up, the core monsoon zone gets heavy rain and that moisture supply also goes over Mumbai. Western Ghats force air to climb, so Mumbai gets lots of rain," Murtugudde said.

While three-digit rainfall in Mumbai and places along the West Coast are common during the monsoon season, meteorologists suggest that there has been a significant rise in such deluge-like spells during July and August across Maharashtra, Gujarat, South Rajasthan and Southwest Madhya Pradesh.

Mizoram's Natural History Museum notified as designated repository

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Environment Ministry has notified the Natural History Museum (NHM) in Mizoram as a designated repository, making it the 21st such repository in the country, officials said on Tuesday.

Designated repositories constitute an important component of India's biodiversity governance framework by preserving authenticated biological specimens accessed under the Biological Diversity Act, 2002.

"Based on the recommendation of the National Biodiversity Authority and after due examination of the proposal, the Central Government notified the institution as a designated repository on June 19, 2026," a senior ministry official said.

"With this notification, NHM becomes India's 21st



Designated Repository, further strengthening the country's biodiversity conservation and scientific infrastructure," the official said. The NHM will maintain voucher specimens of select flora, including pteridophytes and macrofungi, and fauna such as reptiles, amphibians, fishes, moths, beetles and butterflies, according to the official.

"It will also serve as the designated depository for

type specimens of newly discovered species from the region. These authenticated collections will strengthen species identification, traceability and scientific research while safeguarding India's biological resources for long-term conservation.

"They will also support future ecological restoration in the event of habitat loss, natural disasters or species decline," the official said.

Leverage youth power to eliminate TB from India: Nadda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Health Minister JP Nadda on Tuesday called for harnessing the power of India's youth to turn the TB Mukht Bharat Abhiyaan into a nationwide people's movement. Chairing a high-level inter-ministerial meeting with Union Minister for Youth Affairs and Sports and Labour and Employment Mansukh Mandaviya and Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Seth, he urged greater participation of volunteers, educational institutions, workplaces and defence personnel in the country's tuberculosis elimination drive. Nadda stressed that eliminating tuberculosis requires a "whole-of-government and whole-of-society" approach. Referring to Prime Minister

Narendra Modi's recent remarks during a PRAGATI review meeting, Nadda said the active participation of young people and institutions would be critical in accelerating awareness, early detection, treatment adherence and patient support. "The power of India's youth must be leveraged to make the TB Mukht Bharat Abhiyaan a nationwide people's movement," Nadda said, according to an official statement. He asked the Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports to expand the engagement of MY Bharat volunteers and National Cadet Corps (NCC) cadets in the campaign by strengthening the existing TB Mukht Bharat Toli model, mobilising volunteers for screening camps and intensifying awareness programmes in schools, colleges



and communities. The health minister also sought greater involvement of the Ministry of Defence in community awareness campaigns, household contact education, nutrition support drives for TB patients and integration of TB awareness activities into NCC training camps, Republic Day and Independence Day events, adventure camps and rural outreach programmes. Mandaviya proposed greater institutional convergence by involving medical colleges more extensively in the campaign, noting that the country has nearly six lakh undergraduate and around two lakh postgraduate medical students who could contribute to TB elimination efforts. He also suggested engaging officers under the Pratibha Setu programme in District TB

Coordination Committees to improve planning, implementation and monitoring at the district level. He called for bringing the Ministry of Education on board to widen participation through educational institutions. According to the Government, more than 28 crore vulnerable individuals have been screened under the TB Mukht Bharat Abhiyaan since its launch in December 2024. The screening has resulted in the notification of over 39 lakh TB patients, including 12.93 lakh asymptomatic patients identified through active case finding using chest X-rays, enabling earlier diagnosis and treatment. The Government said over 5.7 lakh Ni-kshay Mitras have registered under the initiative and distributed 38.9 lakh nutrition

baskets to TB patients, while more than 20 lakh patients have received individualised support under the programme's differentiated care approach. The meeting also discussed expanding workplace-based TB interventions by integrating screening into occupational health practices, particularly in high-risk sectors such as mining, construction, textiles and transport, and among migrant workers. It was decided to mobilise employers, trade unions and labour welfare institutions, including the Employees' State Insurance Corporation (ESIC) and the Directorate General Factory Advice Service and Labour Institutes (DGFASLI), to facilitate workplace screening, support treatment adherence and improve patient care, the statement said.

Assam seeks deeper Japan ties in semiconductors, clean energy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Monday said the State is keen to play a greater role in deepening the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership, with a focus on semiconductors, clean energy and Japanese language training. In a post on X, Sarma said he met Japanese Ambassador to India, Ono Keiichi, at his official residence in the national Capital, where the envoy hosted him for Cha-no-yu, the traditional Japanese tea ceremony. "I am grateful to H.E. Mr Ono Keiichi, Ambassador of Japan to India, for hosting me at his residence in New Delhi for Cha-no-yu, the traditional Japanese tea ceremony," the Chief Minister wrote. Sarma said the two sides held a 'productive exchange' on emerging areas of cooperation and discussed the outcomes of the recently concluded India-Japan Summit, particularly the opportunities it offers Assam in semiconductor research, clean energy and Japanese language training. The Chief Minister said he reaffirmed Assam's commit-



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma interacting with Japanese ambassador to India Ono Keiichi in New Delhi

PTI

ment to contributing meaningfully to the growing strategic partnership between India and Japan. The meeting comes amid expanding engagement between Assam and Japan across sectors such as industry, technology, skill development and infra-

structure. The State has been actively seeking Japanese investments and technical collaboration, especially in high-technology manufacturing, renewable energy and human resource development, as part of its broader push to attract global investment.

CPI(M) slams Union Government over proposed NFSA amendment

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Tuesday strongly opposed the Union Government's proposed amendment to the National Food Security Act (NFSA), accusing the Centre of attempting to dilute and weaken the landmark legislation. The Left party demanded the immediate withdrawal of the proposed bill, which seeks to alter the entitlement criteria under the Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) from a household-based system to a per capita system. Under the proposed changes, the foodgrain allocation would shift to 7 kg per person per month while capping the overall monthly ration at 35 kg per household. In a press statement issued from the CPI(M) Central Committee Office, the party argued that



the restructuring offers absolutely no benefit to larger households while substantially reducing the legal food entitlements of smaller families. "The amendment will disproportionately affect the poorest and most vulnerable sections of society, including elderly couples, widows, persons with disabilities, tribal families, landless agricultural labourers, and small nuclear families whose food security depends entirely on the AAY," the Polit Bureau stated. The party also flagged a regional disparity, noting that the amendment would

penalise southern states that have successfully implemented family planning programmes. "These states will suffer a significant reduction in their overall foodgrain allocations despite their achievements in population stabilisation," the statement added. Criticising the Modi Government for failing to update the NFSA beneficiary lists — which are still based on the outdated 2011 Census data — the CPI(M) highlighted that millions of eligible people remain excluded from the food safety net. The party maintained that instead of addressing the long-pending demand to expand coverage based on current population figures, the Centre has chosen to introduce an "anti-poor" measure that further reduces the food entitlements of the marginalised.

Maharashtra to review inclusion of 555 villages in Sahyadri tiger reserve

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Maharashtra Government will review the proposed inclusion of 555 villages in the expansion of the Sahyadri Tiger Reserve and make every effort to exclude those places that do not fall in the corridor after consulting local public representatives, a State minister told the Legislative Assembly in Mumbai.



ship. "We will certainly try to remove as many villages as possible from the proposed corridor if they are not part of the tiger movement area," he said. Seeking to dispel fears over the proposed eco-sensitive zone, Naik said it would not affect normal activities, such as farming, construction of houses, schools, hospitals or other routine development works. Restrictions would mainly apply to activities, such as mining, chemical industries and other environmentally hazardous projects, he said.

Puri temple urges PM, President to stop ISKCON's Rath Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

The Gajapati Maharaja and chairman of Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee (SJTMC), Dibyasingha Deb, has written to President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking their intervention to stop ISKCON from holding untimely 'Snan Yatra' and Rath Yatra of Lord Jagannath across the globe by deviating from the age-old tradition and hurting the religious sentiments of millions of devotees. Deb, the titular king of Puri, said, "Despite



several requests, ISKCON have been deviating from the norms in sacred scriptures and century-old tradition while conducting festi-

vals of Lord Jagannath." The Shree Jagannath Temple Managing Committee (SJTMC) is the highest policy-making body

of the 12th-century shrine in Odisha's Puri. In a letter to the President and Prime Minister on July 4, Deb said, "I wish to submit here that over the last almost two decades, consistent efforts on the part of Shree Jagannath Temple Administration (Puri) to resolve this vital issue, as well as public statements in that regard issued by the Odisha Government from time to time, have failed to stop the untimely Shree Jagannath Yatras performed by ISKCON in countries outside India." Deb, who is also considered as the first servitor of

Lord Jagannath further said that under the aforesaid circumstances and in order to preserve the sanctity of the glorious tradition of Lord Jagannath around the world and in deference to the religious sentiments of countless devotees in India and abroad, he once again appealed to the Prime Minister to initiate appropriate steps so as to stop the performance of untimely snana-yatra and rath yatra being organised by ISKCON in violation of sacred scriptures and tradition. Earlier, Deb had written a letter to Prime Minister and President Murmu.

Nagaland to convene special Assembly session for FNTA law

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kohima

The Nagaland Cabinet decided to convene a special session of the Assembly to enact a law for the proposed Frontier Nagaland Territorial Authority (FNTA), while seeking the Centre's approval for conferring legislative powers on the body. The Cabinet, which held an emergency meeting with members of the Eastern Nagaland Legislators' Union

(ENLU) and senior officials on Monday, also resolved to urge the Centre to enhance the proposed development package for the region from ₹5,000 crore to ₹10,000 crore. The decisions were announced in a statement issued by the Home Department amid concern over delays in implementing the Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) signed on February 5 among the Centre, the Nagaland Government and the Eastern Nagaland People's Organisation (ENPO)



for the creation of the FNTA. The decisions were taken as the ENPO announced a public rally and shutdown in the eastern districts on July 10 over the delay in the implementation of the accord. The Government said the proposed legislation would incorporate provisions to confer legislative powers on the FNTA over transferred subjects and departments in the districts under its jurisdiction, subject to consultation with and approval of the Home Affairs in confor-

mity with the Constitution. It said the State had earlier drafted and introduced the FNTA Bill during the Budget session, but its passage was deferred after the MHA informed the government that constitutional issues relating to granting legislative powers to the authority were still under examination. The cabinet also reiterated that the safeguards under Article 371(A) were "sacred and sacrosanct" and would not be diluted or altered.

Rain takes break in Mumbai; services return to normal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

After two days of relentless downpours that battered Mumbai, the rains eased on Tuesday, offering residents a welcome respite as local train services and road transport returned to normal. Two minor boys drowned, while two women suffered injuries as cement sheets collapsed at a garden in Mumbai during heavy rains and winds during the last 24 hours, officials said on Tuesday. Across the city, civic authorities reported 428 incidents of trees and branches crashing down and 28 complaints of wall and house collapses, underscoring the scale of disruption on Monday during heavy showers. Railway officials said one of the three lines damaged by landslides in the Bhor Ghat section on the Mumbai-Pune route is expected to be restored by Tuesday



A man at Marine Drive during high tide amid rainfall in Mumbai

PTI

night, a welcome sign of relief after the disruption brought train services to a standstill on Monday. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) has issued an

'orange' alert, warning of intermittent showers with heavy to very heavy rainfall at isolated spots, along with gusty winds reaching 60-70 kmph.

All Government, private and civic-run schools and colleges in Mumbai remained closed on Tuesday as a precautionary measure, officials said. Heavy showers brought Mumbai and neighbouring districts to a near standstill on Monday. Many roads were submerged, trees were uprooted, and several incidents of wall and billboard collapses were reported. The Virar-Vasai section in the neighbouring Palghar district had been inundated since Monday morning, though the water level gradually receded after the intensity of rainfall reduced by evening. The first local train departed from Virar for Churchgate in south Mumbai at 3.57 am on Tuesday, a Western Railway spokesperson said. Suburban services on all four corridors of the Central Railway were operating with

some delays. The Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation said it received 428 complaints of tree and branch falls, including 111 in the city, 126 in the eastern suburbs and 191 in the western suburbs. It also recorded 28 incidents of partial wall or house collapses during the same period. Two boys, aged 17 and 14, drowned in flood waters in Malad and Govandi areas on Monday evening, it said. Two women were injured after cement sheets from an adjoining structure collapsed while they were practising yoga at a private garden in the Lokhandwala area in Andheri. They were admitted to the hospital and reported to be in stable condition, the BMC said. Twenty-four complaints of short circuits were also reported from different parts of Mumbai, though there were no injuries, it added.

13 blackbucks found dead in MP well

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Shajapur

Thirteen blackbucks and a stray dog have been found dead in a farm well in Madhya Pradesh's Shajapur district, prompting forest authorities to launch a probe into the matter, an official said on Tuesday. Farm owner Rajesh Patidar's family noticed a foul smell on Sunday, following which they found the decomposing carcasses in the well at the field, located in Khardaun Kalan village of Kalapipal tehsil, 80 km from the district headquarters, Divisional Forest Officer (DFO) Hemlata Shah said. Upon receiving information, teams from the



Representative Photo

forest department, police, and administration reached the spot. Carcasses of 13 blackbucks — four male and nine female — and a stray dog were retrieved, officials said. After a panchnama and autopsy, the carcasses were disposed of on Monday, Shah said.



Editor's
TAKE

‘Act East’ finds its
firmest foothold

The success of PM Modi’s Indonesia visit will ultimately be measured by how effectively the agreements are translated into tangible outcomes

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi landed at Jakarta’s Halim air base on July 6, 2026, escorted in by Indonesian fighter jets and received personally by President Prabowo Subianto, it launched the first leg of a six-day, three-nation Indo-Pacific tour – Jakarta, then Melbourne, then Auckland. It is Modi’s fourth trip to Indonesia. The trip is loaded with an unusually concrete agenda: missiles, minerals, and a port.

The friendship long predates the deal-making. Indian traders carried Hinduism and Buddhism across the archipelago some two millennia ago – a debt Modi repays in person at Yogyakarta’s Prambanan temple, where the two governments are set to announce joint restoration work. In the twentieth century, Nehru’s India backed Sukarno’s independence struggle against Dutch rule.

What began as anti-colonial solidarity and non-alignment at Bandung in 1955 was recast for economics by the Look East policy of 1991 and its more assertive successor, Act East, in 2014 – with Indonesia, straddling the Strait of Malacca through which roughly three-fifths of India’s seaborne trade passes, cast as that policy’s most consequential Southeast Asian partner.This visit is built to cash that geography in.

On defence, Indonesia – already BrahMos’s second export customer after the Philippines – is said to be finalising a second missile battery worth some \$300 million, alongside reported interest in India’s Astra air-to-air missile following its combat debut in Operation Sindoor. Talks also cover an Indonesian liaison officer at India’s maritime-monitoring hub near Delhi and training berths at India’s defence academies.

On critical minerals, India is angling for a foothold in Indonesia’s nickel reserves, the world’s largest, through manufacturing tie-ups in nickel, steel and rare-earth magnets meant to loosen China’s grip on EV supply chains. On connectivity, the two sides are expected to advance joint development of Sabang port, which overlooks the Malacca strait barely 150 kilometres from India’s own Great Nicobar project, alongside a UPI-QRIS payments link and MoUs on health, space and food security.

Coming days after Modi hosted Japan’s Sanae Takaichi in Delhi, the Jakarta stop reads less like an isolated bilateral call than a node in a deliberate mesh of Indo-Pacific partnerships meant, without anyone saying so outright, to balance China’s expanding navy. That is Act East’s most ambitious iteration yet – trading palm-oil transactionalism for co-production of missiles and minerals. But ambition and delivery aren’t the same thing: the BrahMos battery has taken years to move from “advanced talks” toward signature, the Astra and nickel arrangements remain sourced to unnamed officials rather than paper, and India’s own ambassador had already conceded some outcomes could still slip.That caveat is worth keeping close.

Jakarta gives Act East its most serious hardware test yet. Whether it becomes proof of concept or another well-photographed handshake will show only once the batteries, the chips and the port machinery actually move.

Restoring trust in India’s examination system

The successful conduct of the rescheduled NEET-2026 examination offered India a moment of relief after weeks of uncertainty triggered by a devastating paper leak. Yet the crisis, followed by the CBSE Class XII evaluation controversy and the tragic coaching centre fire in Lucknow, has exposed deeper structural flaws that extend far beyond administrative lapses.



JS
RAJPUT

India heaved a great sigh of relief in the evening June 21 of 2026 as the media splashed reports of the successful conduct of the rescheduled NEET-2026 exam. Its earlier cancellation on account of the paper leak had cast a pall of widespread gloom not only on the young aspirants and their families but throughout the nation. It cast serious aspersions on our examination management systems, institutions and the expertise generated over several decades. The community of teachers felt greatly let down as details of the modus operandi used by the mafia and the anti-social elements emerged. The needle of suspicion moved swiftly to the paper setters, to teachers, academics and educators. The coaching centres were obviously there as the usual suspects. The union education minister has lately called it a great betrayal and one fully endorses his assessment. When a paper-setter in an examination of any level stoops to the level of leaking the paper, becoming a shameful part and parcel of the mafia involved in corrupting the education and examination system, the nation must get alerted, and ponder over the inadequacies in preparing and recruiting its teachers at every stage. The system in spite of its vast magnitude just can't afford to have even a single teacher bereft of moral and ethical conduct.

Consequently, India must also seriously audit its systems of teacher preparation, recruitment and procedures of ascertaining their continuous academic advancement and professional growth along with the critical contours of personality development. Teachers are supposed to nurture moral, ethical and humanistic values in their wards. They are supposed to scrupulously adhere to an exemplary work culture which is quietly internalised by their students. Every teacher is a partner in preparing the future of India. They are the role models with whom the child interacts as the child transitions to school. Others come only at a later stage.

As the nation was slowly coming out of the anguish and anxiety inflicted by the postponement of the NEET exam, the CBSE announced its Class XII results, and that created an unprecedented situation of gloom and despair. For the first time, the CBSE opted for the digital marking system popularly known as OSM (On-Screen Marking). It chose Class XII for it, a stage that determines the individual-specific future course of studies that the learner would like to pursue. The CBSE claims to have taken all the necessary steps to prepare its own system, and train its evaluators to perform their job efficiently. The techni-



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FOR IT

The author is an educationist,
a Padma Shri awardee, and
works in religious amity and
social cohesion

bereaved families; every sensitive soul mourns with them.

This probably does not include the mafia, and also the parents who encourage purchase of 'leaked papers', spend vulgar amounts, and commit the sin of throwing away millions of other young people and their families in immeasurable agony and pain.

When even a single suicide takes place consequent upon ant-social and immoral machinations of rogue elements, the entire nation must stand up to ensure that it's not repeated again. In a humane world, everyone who believes in "Sarve Bhavantu Sukhinah" has a role to perform. The social system must take a serious note, expose them as the culprits who damage lives, kill young aspirations, and commit heinous social sacrilege.

Apart from putting all our expectations of strict action against the mafia solely on government action, which have been mostly inadequate, lethargic and inefficient, time has come when institutions, teachers and academics, and non-political social activists also accept their role in bringing back the moral order in the world of education.

It is common knowledge that when it comes to the preparation of a child in the family for examinations like CBSE, NEET, JEE and others, it is the entire family that gears up to assist and inspire. No disturbance or distractions could be permitted. Think of the anxiety and hope of the parents of a brilliant child, educated in a government school, from a family with scant earnings how life transforming could be the success in such examinations.

The challenge before the nation is to restore the reputation of its school and higher education organisations in their competence and capability to maintain the purity of the system of examinations and assessment at each stage. The uncertainty, anxiety and the tension must not be permitted to retard the enthusiasm and self-confidence of even a single child getting ready to compete. The community of teachers must come forward as one unit to keep the miscreants out.

The NEP-2020 has prominently assured the nation "The teacher shall be at the centre of the fundamental reforms in education system." It commits to making teachers "as the most respected and essential members of our society". The teachers must feel empowered and enabled to perform their duty effectively." The present position of teachers is well known to the system and society. It would require Herculean efforts to bring it to the appropriate level indicated above. There is no escape but to strive hard as the system has to be reformed and transformed effectively.

PIC TALK



A commuter wades through a waterlogged road amid rain, at Nalasopara in Palghar, Maharashtra. PHOTO: PTI



AJIT KUMAR
BISHNOI

2ND OPINION

It is sad for me to see people around where I live falling sick in old age and getting restricted to their bedrooms served by servants. All the pleasures of life have gone except watching serials endlessly. It is somehow passing time waiting for the inevitable death. Has God left us so helpless?

The answer is a big No with a capital N. What kind of system has God set for us? There are two kinds of acts we can do, which are spiritual and material. Most people, including these rich and powerful limit themselves to material acts now and have done so in the past.

These acts have long fruition periods. Generally, what we have done in the past lives bring fruits in this life, and what we do in the present life bring fruits in future lives. Spiritual acts are different. They come to fruition



almost immediately.

The following examples should convince you. Swami Vivekananda turned a devotee at a young age. He desired to attend the Parliament of Religions to be help in Chicago in 1893. Everything was arranged by God. Not only was he allowed to speak there, but when he spoke he thrilled the delegates to such an extent that they could not stop cheering. Swamiji had been empowered by God to speak.

Goswami Tulsiadas was an orphan. What did he do, which changed everything? He became a devotee. He

was so overcome with emotion when he was writing the epic Ramcharitmanas that he thanked his worshipable Lord Ramachandra from his heart for empowering him to write such a spiritual text. If his love was overflowing, Meerabai's love knew no bounds. She was given a choice between stopping worshipping her Giridhar Gopal and getting punished by drinking poison. We all know what she chose. And we also know what her Giridhar Gopal did? He made the poison harmless.

I can go on with these famous examples, but I have plenty of personal experiences as well to convince me about God's unlimited 'kripa' (mercy) on His devotees. I am an engineer by education. I am a businessman by profession. So what has my Lord empowered me to do? To write spiritual texts. Is it believable? To my credit, I had desired writing and I took shelter of God.

What are we waiting for? God is waiting not for one but all of us. He has so much to give. Isn't God the owner of everything we see or don't even see? Nothing is lost. What God has asked us to do in a spiritual text like the Bhagavad-Gita is entirely practical. Why lament about the present and fear the worst? Aren't we parts of God (15.7) connected eternally with Him? We may ignore Him, but His door is always open for us. Walk in and begin experiencing what God has promised: "I will provide what you need, and protect what you have." (9.22) This includes health in old age. Ask me?

The writer is a spiritual teacher

Get empowered now not later

AMERICA'S 250TH ANNIVERSARY:
A LEGACY UNDER STRAIN

As the United States marks the 250th anniversary of its independence, the aura and global stature traditionally associated with the American presidency appear to be diminishing.

President Donald Trump's often theatrical style has overshadowed the dignity that earlier occupants of the White House projected on the world stage.

At the same time, the changing geopolitical landscape has weakened Washington's ability to shape international affairs as decisively as it once did, reflecting a gradual erosion of the influence enjoyed by previous American administrations.

Yet, despite these challenges, the United States continues to

embody the enduring promise of the "American Dream." It remains a destination for talent, innovation and opportunity, attracting people from across the globe in search of a better future.

The nation's remarkable journey over two and a half centuries, founded on the principles of liberty, equality and democratic governance, is an achievement worthy of admiration.

While America's global dominance may be evolving, its constitutional ideals and capacity for renewal continue to inspire millions, making its 250th anniversary both a moment of reflection and an affirmation of its enduring legacy.

MURALI M. MALLAREDDY | VISAKHAPATNAM

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Dilip Kumar's charisma lives on

July 7 marks the fifth death anniversary of Dilip Kumar, one of Indian cinema's greatest legends and arguably its first true method actor. His natural, understated style transformed acting in Hindi films and became the benchmark for generations of performers. From Rajendra Kumar to Amitabh Bachchan and Shah Rukh Khan, many leading actors have acknowledged or reflected the subtle influence of the "Dilip Kumar school" of acting. Whether portraying the tragic Devdas, the rebellious prince in Mughal-e-Azam, the unforgettable double role in Ram Aur Shyam, or the rustic hero of Ganga Jamuna, he disappeared completely into every character.

His performances in classics like Madhumati, Leader, Shaheed, Shakti, Mashaal and Vidhata remain master-classes in screen acting. Even songs such as "Suhana Safar" and "Dil Tadap Tadap Ke" came alive through his expressive performances.

Though celebrated as the "Tragedy King," he excelled equally in comic and mature roles. Criticism never deterred him; he responded only through excellence. Dilip Kumar may no longer be with us, but his timeless artistry continues to inspire actors and cinema lovers across generations.

SUNIL OKHADE | INDORE

Speculation over Amit Shah's elevation

Speculation that Union Home Minister Amit Shah may be appointed Deputy Prime Minister has gathered momentum in political circles. If it materialises, the move would evoke memories of LK Advani serving in that role during Atal Bihari Vajpayee's government. However, such a designation may be largely symbolic, as Amit Shah is already widely regarded as Prime Minister Narendra Modi's closest political associate and principal strategist.

His influence extends across both the government and the BJP's organisational structure, where he is seen as playing a decisive role with the Prime Minister's full confidence.

If elevated, the move would likely be viewed as recognition of his contribution to the party's growth and governance, particularly after steering the BJP through the challenging political landscape following the 2024 general election. A cabinet reshuffle, if undertaken, may also be designed with an eye on the forthcoming Assembly elections and the 2029 Lok Sabha polls, rewarding key performers while reallocating responsibilities. Whatever the outcome, Amit Shah is expected to remain the central pillar of the government's political and electoral strategy.

YASHASWI BAIRAGI | UJJAIN

More resilient power grid is need of the hour

India is expected to face one of the world's biggest power challenges during the anticipated El Niño period from July 2026 to June 2027. According to the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA), weaker wind and hydropower generation, coupled with soaring electricity demand for cooling, could create a power deficit of nearly 18 terawatt hours. The additional cooling demand alone may reach 10 TWh, roughly one-fourth of Delhi's annual electricity consumption.

The report warns that the resulting supply gap could force greater dependence on coal-fired power plants, leading to an estimated 17 million tonnes of additional carbon dioxide emissions. Having already experienced one of its hottest summers, with electricity demand touching a record 270 GW, India faces the prospect of even greater pressure on its power grid, water resources and agriculture if a strong El Niño develops. Rather than using peak demand as justification for expanding coal capacity, policymakers should accelerate investments in battery storage, grid modernisation and renewable energy integration. Solar power, which already meets nearly a quarter of India's daytime electricity demand and is less vulnerable to El Niño than wind or hydropower, offers the most reliable pathway towards a resilient energy future.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

America celebrates the 250 years of freedom

At 250 years, the United States appears less like a completed political project and more like a continuing argument that has never settled its own meaning, where universal ideals and uneven outcomes persist within the same institutional framework and shape one another over time



NILANTHA
ILANGAMUWA

What has happened to Thomas Paine remains unresolved, and that uncertainty matters when trying to understand the United States at its present stage. The United States of America yesterday (July 4) marked its 250th birthday, a moment when one of the world's leading liberal democracies appeared less as a coherent model and more as a divided system, a family business struggling to awaken from its long slumber. How the United States has acted against itself in recent years raises the question of whether it is still accurate to describe it as a single coherent nation-state in the conventional sense, or whether it is better understood as an idea that repeatedly turns inward and contradicts itself. As Wang Huning, Xi Jinping's leading political theorist, wrote in 1991, "Americans accept only equality of conditions, not equality of results. Once equality of conditions is established, then comes the realm of liberty." Whether one agrees with this interpretation or not, it captures a recurring tension in the American experiment: a belief in formal equality coexisting with persistent inequality of outcome.

The United States has always been more than a set of territorial and governmental structures. It is an idea that attracts interpretation, projection and reinvention, drawing together disparate intellectual traditions into a single, contested narrative of purpose. Despite sustained criticism, it remains one of the most successful political constructions in modern history, precisely because it is not fixed. In 1783, while British troops were still being evacuated after defeat in the Revolutionary War, Ezra Stiles claimed that Americans had devised the "most perfect" principles of government anywhere, predicting that the population would exceed 300 million within "two or three hundred years". In 1804, following the Louisiana Purchase, David Ramsay argued that the republic "can never be too large" and would eventually span the continent from the Atlantic to the Pacific. In the political imagination of Thomas Paine and Thomas Jefferson, the United States was a beacon of republican government against monarchy and tyranny. Even in 1862, amid civil war, Abraham Lincoln still described it as "the last, best hope of earth". Yet from the beginning, expansion and idealism were inseparable from fracture, contradiction, and conflict between universal language and particular power.

The life and posthumous fate of Thomas Paine illustrates this tension with unusual clarity. Paine gave the revolutionary project its most accessible moral language, insisting that sovereignty belonged to citizens rather than kings, and that authority required consent rather than inheritance. Yet his later life ended in obscurity, his reputation diminished in a society increasingly suspicious of his radicalism. His remains were later disinterred by William Cobbett and transported to England, only to be lost to history, fragmented into uncertain claims and incomplete records. That physical dispersal mirrors the dispersal of the revolutionary certainty he represented. What followed Paine was not the stabilisation of a philosophical project, but its transformation into a governing system expanding across territory, economy and military capacity, constantly negotiating between founding principles and practical power.

This tension is embedded in the structure of the state itself. The United States developed as a system in which competing interpretations of the same constitutional text became engines of political struggle. Federalists and anti-Federalists, abolitionists and slaveholders, isolationists and expansionists all claimed fidelity to the founding framework while drawing incompatible conclusions from it. As territorial expansion accelerated, liberty and dispossession coexisted within the same national vocabulary. As industrialisation advanced, contractual freedom coexisted with forms of dependency that contradicted its premise. The modern state, including what later became described as the military-industrial complex, did not emerge as an external distortion of the founding idea, but as one of its internal expressions. Its strength lay not in ideological consistency, but in its capacity to absorb contradiction and remain operational across changing historical conditions. By the twentieth century, this elasticity had become both an advantage and a burden. The Cold War presented the United States as a universal model of liberty against external tyranny, yet this framing intensified internal contradictions rather than resolving them. Military interventions, proxy conflicts and intelligence operations expanded alongside declared commitments to democracy and self-determination. The result was not a



simple case of hypocrisy, but a structural duality: the simultaneous production of democratic ideals and the support of undemocratic outcomes under the logic of strategic necessity. Over time, this contradiction ceased to appear exceptional and became normalised within political language itself, absorbed into the routine functioning of policy and public discourse.

Within this long historical arc, contemporary polarisation can be read less as rupture than as revelation. Donald Trump, in this context, is not an anomaly outside the American tradition but a concentrated expression of its internal contradictions. The argument that he represents either a decisive break or a total corruption of the system misses the deeper continuity of American political life, which has always oscillated between moral idealism and pragmatic force, between universal language and selective application. The increasing intensity of political conflict reflects not sudden decline, but the difficulty of sustaining older narratives of unity under contemporary conditions.

The more fundamental question is whether the United States ever existed outside the tension it now displays so openly. Historical scholarship repeatedly returns to the same paradox: that a constitutional order capable of expanding rights also contained mechanisms of exclusion; that a political experiment inspiring global imitation was built alongside structures of inequality it struggled to overcome. The so-called hypocrisy of American liberty is not an incidental flaw, but a recurring condition of its development. It is visible in Indigenous dispossession, in the entanglement of slavery with economic growth, and in later global projections of power justified through the language of security and democracy. It is also visible in counter-traditions that repeatedly forced reinterpretation: abolitionism, civil rights movements, labour organisation and reform politics, each attempting to re-anchor founding language against the realities of practice.

To describe the United States as an idea rather than a country is therefore partially accurate, but incomplete. It is an idea that has always required institutions, enforcement and coercive capacity to exist in material form. It is also an idea that has never been stable, continuously rewritten by successive generations who inherit it under different material conditions. The military-industrial system, the administrative state, the intelligence apparatus and the electoral framework are not deviations from the founding idea, but mechanisms through which it scales itself across time and global reach. The consequence is paradoxical: a system powerful enough to preserve continuity, yet structured in such a way that disagreement over meaning becomes permanent rather than resolvable.

At 250 years, the United States appears less like a completed political project and more like a continuing argument that has never settled its own meaning, where universal ideals and uneven outcomes persist within the same institutional framework and shape one another over time. Its history shows that reform and resistance are permanently entangled, since efforts to extend equality repeatedly collide with structures designed to preserve stability, hierarchy and continuity, producing cycles in which change often arrives as adjustment rather than rupture. In modern conditions of extreme wealth concentration and intensified political polarisation, this tension becomes sharper, as formal equality coexists with highly uneven distributions of influence and power, all expressed through the same inherited language of rights and opportunity.

In this context, a 927-page financial disclosure attributed to President Donald Trump, describing extensive income streams from cryptocurrency holdings, property interests and royalty arrangements, is interpreted not simply as personal accumulation but as a symbol of a broader systemic paradox, where economic scale and political legitimacy increasingly overlap in ways that are difficult to disentangle. The result is a governing order that depends simultaneously on adaptation and preservation, where legitimacy requires change but continuity requires restraint, leaving the country defined less by resolution than by the ongoing friction between what it promises and what it produces.

The writer is a columnist based in Colombo

Even Caesar did not send a lie to the Senate



DEVENDER
SINGH ASWAL

The ensuing Monsoon Session of Parliament is bound to be turbulent, as the Congress seeks privilege proceedings against Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, alleging that he misled Parliament over Operation Sindoor about the six soldiers who laid their lives in the line of duty. The Speaker, Lok Sabha may seek the comments of the Minister or refer it to the Committee on Privileges for enquiry and report. The Speaker has the inherent power to close a matter if satisfied with the explanation tendered. The veracity or otherwise of the allegation will be ascertained after due procedural enquiry. However, the central question is what consequences would visit if a minister deliberately misleads the Parliament.

The veracity of statements made in the legislature by the members, including ministers, is a fundamental postulate of a deliberative democracy. Ordinarily, it is presumed that the statements made or answers given in Parliament by ministers are sacrosanct, unless proved otherwise. Parliament can function efficiently and effectively as the supreme deliberative body of the nation, if accurate and complete information is furnished to it. The Council of Ministers is accountable to the Parliament and the information that they give to Parliament must be correct and complete, without which the doctrine of accountability would become a myth. Accountability of the executive to the legislature is the linchpin of our parliamentary democracy and therefore, it is incumbent upon the ministers to furnish correct and complete and timely information to Parliament and its Committees.

Truth, honesty and integrity are quite integral to the proper and effective functioning of Parliament. Not only the ministers and the members, even the witnesses deposing before parliamentary committees are deemed to be under oath to speak truth, and complete truth. It is invariably made known to the witnesses that the deposition which they shall make, shall be true, that nothing will be concealed and that, no part of their testimony shall be false. Suppression of truth, giving convoluted answers or to mislead Parliament or its committees constitutes breach of privilege. Therefore, greater responsibility is cast on a minister sworn to bear true faith and allegiance to the Constitution and to discharge his duties faithfully and conscientiously as a Minister for the Union.

An inaccuracy or chance mistake may inadvertently creep in the statements made or replies given by a minister in Parliament. The Rules of Procedure and Directions of Parliament provide that in case any inaccuracy or mistake is detected in any answer given or statement made by a Minister, the same shall be pointed out as soon as it is detected and the mistake rectified with the permission of the Speaker. There are many instances of the Ministers making the correcting statements, especially of the answers given to questions. But making a misleading statement deliberately or concealing information from Parliament, constitutes breach of privilege, unless the Minister invokes the plea of national interest. But making a false or deliberately misleading statement is grossly unethical, against sacrosanct parliamentary conventions and unpardonable. Untruthful or misleading statements undermine parliamentary democracy.

'Satyae Meva Jayatae' and 'Yato dharmata tato Jaya' are the foremost ideals of India's great civilisational heritage. Many consider India as the Mother of Democracy, and justifiably, with reference to Vedic texts and post Vedic literature. The Indian civilisational texts of great antiquity lay immense stress on truth and righteousness. There are inscriptions in the old Parliament Building taken from the Mahabharata and the Manusmriti reminding that members of the Assembly must speak with righteousness, and the righteousness must be based on truth, and truth is not truth, if it leads to deceit. Further, one must not enter either an assembly hall, or he must speak there with all the righteousness, for one who does not speak or one who speaks falsely, does himself in the sin involve equally.

Even in the republics of Ancient Greece and Rome, truth was considered as the cornerstone of the rule of law, justice and public trust. Honest speeches were viewed as necessity of informed decision making. In the eponymous play of Shakespeare, when the wife of Julius Caesar beseeches and entreats him not to attend the Senate as she fears for his safety and asks him to send a message to the Senate that 'he is sick', Caesar questions, 'Shall Caesar send a lie?' to the Senate. He declines to say that he 'cannot come today' to the Senate' as that would be false, and prefers to say 'I will not come today'. Eventually, instead of sending a lie, he prefers to go to the Senate.

There is no Indian instance of a Minister resigning on the ground of misleading the Parliament, though many ministers have resigned earlier on ground of corruption. In the United Kingdom, there are many instances where ministers resigned for misleading the Parliament, once it was so established. In the British parliamentary usage, officials rather use the term 'mislead' instead of 'lied', because the charge of 'lying' is much serious, as it requires to meet more rigorous test. In the year 2023, Boris Johnson resigned as an MP after learning he faced sanctions. Earlier, he had resigned as PM in 2022 after wide public pressure.

The Privilege Committee of the House of Commons had found that he had deliberately misled Parliament over statements related to Party gate. In 2018, the Home Secretary resigned, admitting that she unintentionally misled the House over immigration removal targets. Yet another historical example is of John Profumo, Secretary of State for War who resigned from Govt. and Parliament in 1963 as he had misled the House of Commons first denying that he had scandalous relations with someone but later admitted that his statement was untrue. These instances show that the convention of resignation for misleading the Parliament deliberately is political as well as procedural. The resignations were forced by sensitivity to public pressure, pressure from within the party and the outcry by the media. However, it has become an entrenched and salutary parliamentary convention in UK that if a minister deliberately misleads the Parliament, he will lose his ministry as well as his membership of Parliament.

There is no doubt that the Ministry of Defence will place the full and accurate facts before the Parliament to remove all the misgivings as it is inconceivable that the Hon'ble Defence Minister, a veteran Parliamentarian of long standing, of fair image and deeply immersed in parliamentary and constitutional conventions, would think even remotely to mislead the Parliament, undermining the supreme sacrifice of our gallant soldiers. Let the facts speak for themselves once the matter comes on the floor of the House.

The author is ex Additional Secretary, Lok Sabha & a member of the Supreme Court Bar Association.



Collaborative effort can make the difference between life and death



SWAPNA
MAJUMDAR

Four in ten children are underweight in Madhya Pradesh, according to the latest National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6). Parvati Bhabhar, a resident of Ratlam's Ghodakedha village in Madhya Pradesh, is relieved her son is no longer one of them. However, she knows that he had a

lucky escape. Had she not registered with Sneha, an initiative to improve health and nutrition of women and children, implemented by the Centre for Health Education, Training and Nutrition Awareness (CHETNA), a non profit, she would have remained ignorant about her anaemia and its impact on her underweight newborn. Neither would she have known how to turn their health conditions around.

Parvati had returned to work as a daily wage labourer soon after giving birth, just as she had done in the cases of her previous two children, without paying much attention to either her own nutrition or that of her third child. She had neither time nor the energy, as she always felt tired, for exclusive breastfeeding for his first six

months, an imperative for his well being and growth, particularly as he was an underweight baby.

One of the reasons identified by NFHS for the increase in the percentage of underweight children in MP from 33 per cent to 39.7 per cent is the weak focus on the first 1000 days beginning from pregnancy to the child's second birthday, vital to the both physical and cognitive development. Further, NFHS-6 found that exclusive breastfeeding for the first six months had fallen to 56.4 per cent compared to 74 per cent (NFHS-5) and only 12 per cent of children aged six to 23 months received a minimum acceptable diet.

Fortunately for Parvati and her son, CHETNA was conducting a survey on nutritional anaemia in her village as a part of their Sneha initiative focussing improving maternal and child nutrition in the first 1000 days from conception to a child's second birthday in 25 villages in Ratlam district. While assessing the health and nutrition of pregnant, lactating and newly married women as well as children in the 0-2 age group, they found Parvati anaemic with her haemoglobin at just 9.5g/dL and her one-year-old son showing early signs of malnutrition, weighing just 6.8 kg. Evidence indicates that infants born to anaemic



mothers often have lower iron stores at birth. According to NFHS-6 only 39.6 per cent of women took iron-folic acid tablets for 180 days or more during pregnancy indicating inadequate maternal nutrition. Maternal malnutrition and poor breastfeeding practices contribute to adverse pregnancy outcomes and have lasting effects on a child's growth and cognitive development. But focussed attention can make a difference as shown by CHETNA. Using its four decades of

experience on working on health and nutrition of women and adolescents. CHETNA was able to develop strategies to improve both Parvati and her child's health using targeted interventions in collaboration with the local frontline health workers (AWWs, ASHAs and ANMs) and sustained follow up efforts by its committed Sneha team.

One of the reasons why the programme has been able to reach out and impact so many women and their young children is because it has smartly used multi-pronged strategies that have demonstrated effectiveness in CHETNA's earlier nutritional interventions.

These include early identification of nutritional risks and, timely monitoring including arranging for blood transfusions and follow up of pregnant women, lactating mothers, and children under two years of age. Organising regular health check-up and growth monitoring camps for children less than two years to enable early detection of growth faltering and anaemia risk helped facilitate timely referrals, iron supplementation, and nutrition counselling, contributing to the prevention of anaemia during early childhood.

By conducting structured home visits and group meetings to promote early antenatal care registration, adherence to iron folic acid supple-

mentation, they were able to make families, especially women and their mothers-in-law, aware of good breastfeeding practices, appropriate complementary feeding, and dietary diversity.

Importantly, the rapport built enabled counselling and integration of gender-sensitive messaging to address traditional practices of women eating last and the least. To support improved nutrition at home, CHETNA distributed nutrition kits to mothers.

These kits included dates, ghee pouches, peanuts, and drumstick leaves. Mothers were also given demonstrations and iron-rich recipes using these ingredients to improve nutrition.

The good news is that Parvati and her child are not the only ones to benefit. Over 375 pregnant women and 1000 lactating mothers with children in the 0-2 age group registered under the Sneha programme are learning about their nutritional anaemia and how they can improve their health and that of their young children with simple behavioural and dietary changes and, better feeding practices.

Many of the women are, like Parvati, no longer anaemic and their children have shown steady weight gain and growth, underlining how a collaborative effort can make the difference between life and death.

The writer is journalist writing on development and gender



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Order Order

SC to hear plea on Asian Games dressage selection



The Supreme Court on Tuesday agreed to hear on July 9 a plea challenging the Delhi High Court's refusal to interfere with the non-selection of riders Anush Agarwalla and Sudipti Hajela in India's dressage team for the upcoming Asian Games in Japan.

A partial working day bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and Sheel Nagu said it would hear the matter on Thursday after a counsel submitted that the selection is scheduled to be held on July 15.

The bench directed that the matter be listed before the appropriate bench.

On July 6, the high court refused to interfere with the non-selection of Agarwalla and Hajela, upholding a previous ruling made by a single judge, which denied relief to the duo. Both riders are gold medal winners from the Asian Games 2022 and filed petitions against the selection decisions made by the Equestrian Federation of India (EFI).

Dismissing the riders' appeals, the high court had said that while it did not find any infirmity with the preparation of the list of probables, the EFI had failed to duly comply with certain clauses of the selection criteria.

It, however, opined that a fresh trial was not possible at this stage and exercised "restraint" in the larger interest of sports and to avoid any adverse impact on the country's prospects at the Asian Games.

"Having regard to the deadline of July 15, 2026, it is logistically impractical to conduct a further competition within the time frame available, particularly since the riders and horses are located at different places across the globe and transporting horses from different locations to a common venue for conducting a competition amongst all six probables would not be possible in such a short span of time," the high court had said.

It added that, "We are constrained to refrain from interfering with the impugned judgment."

The court nonetheless asked the EFI to strictly comply with the selection criteria. (PTI)

Allahabad HC sets aside 1989 dowry death conviction

The Allahabad High Court has set aside a 1989 conviction of three people in a dowry death case, observing that a viscera report cannot be relied upon to secure conviction if the report was never specifically put before the accused during their examination.

A two-judge bench of Justices Siddhartha Varma and Jai Krishna Upadhyay said merely questioning an accused with regard to poison being administered to the deceased would be insufficient if the primary scientific evidence – the viscera report – is withheld from them.

The court allowed an appeal filed by a man, his father and his brother challenging their conviction in 1989 for poisoning a woman to death over dowry demands in 1986.

The prosecution had relied upon the viscera report which indicated the presence of the pesticide "zinc phosphide" (highly toxic rodenticides) in the deceased's stomach, portion of intestine, kidneys, and spleen.

However, during the trial, when the statements of the accused were recorded under Section 313 CrPC, the trial court failed to confront them with this specific report.

Allowing the appeal, the court observed, "What is more, we find that neither the viscera nor the report with regard to it had been ever placed before the accused persons when their statements were being recorded under Section 313 of CrPC. Even though questions were put with regard to poison being administered, no question was put with regard to the viscera and its report." (PTI)

Two get three-year RI for fake certificates in Govt job

A Latur court has sentenced two men to three years' rigorous imprisonment for trying to secure a Government job by submitting forged disability certificates and cheating the Government.

Chief Judicial Magistrate MN Chavan convicted the two accused, Shriram Dnyaneshwar Patil and Dnyaneshwar Vasantrao Dodatalle, on July 4 and also imposed a fine of ₹10,000 each on them. The Shivajinagar police had registered a case against the two accused on February 23, 2008, based on a complaint filed by then block development officer of the panchayat samiti. During the investigation, it was found that the accused had submitted forged disability certificates along with their applications to mislead the authorities and obtain an appointment as gram sevaks.

The police subsequently filed a chargesheet before the court. The court relied on the testimonies of the complainant, two Zilla Parishad officials, the then civil surgeon, and the investigation officer. (PTI)



SC rules right to walk precedes right to move on wheels



SUMAN JYOTI KHAITAN



SURABHI CHHABRA

The persistent absence of demarcated and pedestrian-friendly footpaths has long posed serious safety and accessibility challenges for pedestrians in both urban areas and rural areas, forcing them to share road space with vehicular traffic. Recognising the gravity of the issue, the Hon'ble Supreme Court has recently intervened through its latest ruling, underscoring the urgent need to ensure safe and accessible pedestrian infrastructure.

In a recent landmark judgment, [Maniyar Iliyaz @ Shaik Riyaz & Anr. v. P. Ayyappan & Ors., (2026 INSC 647), the Hon'ble Supreme Court has declared that the right to walk on demarcated footpath is a fundamental right under Part III of the Constitution of India.

The ruling came after a tragic accident where a five-year-old boy was hit and killed by a tanker

while walking to school with his father. The road they were walking on had no footpath or pedestrian crossing. While the Hon'ble Court made sure the grieving family received proper compensation, it also focused on the "recognition of the simplest of the simple human activity- "Walking".

The Hon'ble Court observed that the Fundamental Right to Walk is the primary right of movement under Article 19(1)(d), and that this right precedes the right to move on wheels. This right must extend to guaranteeing access to safe and well demarcated footpath. As the Hon'ble Court further observed – "The citizen's fundamental right to walk on a demarcated footpath is primary and shall have priority over movement by motorised vehicles."

Upon further emphasising on the issue, the Hon'ble Court held that it is the duty of urban development authorities, municipal corporations, municipalities and panchayats to demarcate, construct, maintain and safeguard footpaths and other necessary pedestrian infrastructure. The cit-



izens are entitled to invoke constitutional and legal remedies against duty bearers for restitution and compensation in case their right to walk on demarcated footpaths is violated.

Since the Fundamental Right to Walk is not recognised in the Motor Vehicles Act, 1988, the Hon'ble Court took deliberative measures and directed the Registry to send a copy of the said

judgment to the Ministries of Housing and Urban Affairs, Rural Development, Road Transport and Highways in order to contemplate on the necessity to initiate the necessary legal framework.

The present Judgment by the Hon'ble Supreme Court reinforces a practical reality, wherein, safe roads require attention not only to vehicles and traffic management, but also to the everyday

needs of those who travel on foot. This is not the first time that the Hon'ble Court has highlighted the importance of public spaces, including footpaths. Earlier, in Olga Tellis v. Bombay Municipal Corporation (1986 AIR 180), the Hon'ble Court recognised right to livelihood as an integral part of right to life under Article 21 of the Constitution and observed that pavement dwellers cannot be evicted arbitrarily or without following a just, fair, and reasonable procedure.

However, the Hon'ble Court also made it clear that pavement dwellers do not have a fundamental right to occupy pavements or public streets and that public spaces must remain available for their intended public use.

The present Judgment reflects an evolution in the Hon'ble Court's approach to public spaces, including footpaths, and elevates pedestrian's rights to access demarcated footpaths to the status of a fundamental right.

Suman Jyoti Khaitan is founder & CEO and Surabhi Chhabra is senior associate in Suman Khaitan & Co. (Khaitan & Partners)

LPG fire: Court directs BPCL, insurance firm to pay ₹7.60 lakh compensation to kin of deceased woman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Bharat Petroleum Corporation and United India Insurance have been directed by a consumer court to jointly pay more than ₹7.60 lakh in compensation to the family of a woman for negligence and service deficiency, more than 11 years after she died in an LPG cylinder leak fire.

The Additional District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission in Nagpur, in an order passed on July 2, rejected BPCL's argument that the complaint was lodged about four years after the incident.

It also pointed out that the insurance company closed the claim, citing a lack of documents, rather than actively processing it. The incident occurred on December 23, 2014, after a woman, a resident of Jaytala Road (Nagpur), opened the cap of a newly delivered LPG cylinder.

The gas leaked and caught fire due to a lit lamp in the kitchen, resulting in 54 per cent burn injuries to the woman



and 12 per cent burns to her husband, as per the complaint. She succumbed to her injuries on March 3, 2015, during medical treatment.

The complainants, including the victim's husband and her three daughters, claimed that the gas company was legally responsible for verifying the cylinder before supplying it. They alleged that the incident and the death were a fallout of BPCL's failure to fulfil its duty.

The complainants further stated that the household furniture, jewellery, clothes, and other items were destroyed by the blaze. BPCL and its local office denied the allegations, suggesting that the accident

might have occurred due to the incorrect connection of the gas cylinder. The cylinder was supplied only after proper inspection, they had said.

The BPCL argued that the presence of an intact seal on the supplied cylinder indicates that the necessary inspection was carried out.

The company sought dismissal of the complaint, citing a delay of about four years in filing the complaint, arguing that it was an extreme delay beyond the statutory limitation period. However, the commission rejected their contention.

It noted that even after repeated follow-ups, the complainants were not provided

with the necessary and clear information on whom to submit the insurance claim to and the correct process to follow. The information was made available by BPCL for the very first time while the matter was pending before the commission, the consumer panel said.

Considering all the circumstances, the commission was of the opinion that the complaint couldn't be dismissed merely on the grounds of limitation.

On the role of United India Insurance, the panel pointed out that the insurance company closed the claim citing a lack of documents, which it should have processed actively.

"Even if the insurance company took the defence that necessary documents were not provided, it was their duty to demand the required documents and take requisite steps to settle the claim. It is clear from the record that they did not take any effective action in this regard," the commission said.

Court defers Faisal Khan's anticipatory bail hearing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

A Patna court deferred the hearing on educator Faisal Khan's anticipatory bail plea in connection with the coaching institute firing case till Wednesday.

The case relates to a firing incident that occurred in early June after the coaching institute of Faisal Khan, better known as 'Khan Sir', was allegedly vandalised in Patna by a group of miscreants. His security guards are accused of opening fire during the incident.

The court also deferred the hearing on bail applications of the two security guards of Khan Sir who are in judicial custody.

"Today, discussions were held on all the issues, including the gun licences of the guards. An issue regarding criminal antecedents arose, following an application filed by an opposition party. The court has asked for documents from both sides, after which the next hearing will be held tomorrow,"



Khan Global Coaching Institute legal advisor Rajat Singh told reporters.

He said that licence of the gun of one of Khan Sir's guards had lapsed two months ago, but usually a time of six months is provided to renew the same.

"The licence can be renewed within six months of lapse. This is a bailable offence and is unlikely to obstruct the course of bail," Singh said.

The legal advisor said the guards had received licence for Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, and Bihar alongside a travelling licence that allows them to travel across States.

SC pulls up DMK, says court can't regulate Tamil Nadu CM's visits

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay is not an accused in the Karur stampede case and the court cannot regulate his visits, the Supreme Court on Tuesday said as it pulled up the DMK for its plea questioning the visit and alleging that ministers were influencing witnesses in the matter.

A partial working day bench of Justices KV Viswanathan and Alok Aradhe refused to entertain the DMK's plea and asked how can the court regulate the visit of the executive head. Vijay is scheduled to meet families of the stampede victims on July 10.

"The chief minister is not an accused in the FIRs registered in the case. Today, to make this

court a political fora...how is that possible?" Justice Viswanathan told senior advocate Ranjit Kumar, appearing for DMK secretary RS Bharati.

Kumar submitted that the TVK ministers were making public statements which were creating a narrative regarding the stampede case in violation of the last year's judgment where the apex court transferred the investigation to the CBI. Justice Viswanathan then asked, "You want the chief minister's visit to be regulated by the Supreme Court and fix his itinerary? How can this be done?"

Kumar submitted that the DMK may be filing a contempt petition against TN minister Aadhav Arjuna over some comments made by him regarding the case and for



deliberately violating the directions imposed by the apex court last year. He added that the party was seeking to restrain comments being made by the chief minister and other state ministers regarding the merits of the case.

Justice Viswanathan asked Kumar, "So you want us to impose an injunction on free

speech? You counter their speech with your speech. How can a political rival implead themselves in a matter where the Supreme Court has transferred the matter to the CBI."

Kumar replied, "No, I am not. My prayer is that, pending completion of the CBI investigation, there shall be no public statements removing criminal

liability, speaking to political opponents, or commenting on the merits of the pending investigation in a manner likely to prejudice or interfere with a fair and independent investigation."

He said the party wants free speech to be used with more responsibility.

Justice Viswanathan then questioned Kumar as to how the distribution of ₹10 lakh ex-gratia compensation and orders of compassionate appointment for the family members of the stampede victims, which was already announced, will affect the investigation in the case.

Vijay is scheduled to meet the families of the stampede victims on July 10.

The court told Kumar that the DMK may wish to with-

draw its plea and avail any other remedy under law or else the court will dismiss it.

Kumar agreed to withdraw the plea with liberty to approach any other forum and urged the court to give them the option to raise the matter before the committee headed by Justice (retired) Ajay Rastogi, which has been constituted by the apex court to monitor the investigation.

The top court dismissed the plea as withdrawn.

The DMK secretary had filed the plea seeking to restrain the Tamil Nadu chief minister, minister Aadhav Arjuna and other accused people from making public statements on the case and to regulate their interaction with victims' families during the pendency of the CBI probe.

Delhi HC orders restoration of CJP's X handle

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday ordered unblocking of the Cockroach Janta Party's X handle, which was withheld in May.

Justice Swarana Kanta Sharma passed the judgement on a petition filed by Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke against the Centre's blocking order. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta submitted that the CJP's social media handle was blocked to avoid "chaos" among students and parents ahead of the June 21 NEET re-test.

"Since NEET is already over, the primary concern is no longer of any relevance. In these circumstances, the order is revoked. The petition is allowed," Justice Sharma



ordered. The original X handle of the CJP, which started as a satirical digital outfit on May 15 following a controversy over Chief Justice of India Surya Kant's remarks, was withheld in India on May 21. Soon after, the group resurfaced with a new handle, 'Cockroach is Back', which presently has over 2,27,000 followers.

The movement has drawn attention for its unconventional symbolism and digital mobilisation strategy, with supporters describing the "cockroach" identity as a form of protest.

The CJP says it wants to build an independent youth-driven movement to amplify the concerns of the youth and hold the Government accountable. It has launched a campaign demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over alleged systemic failures in the education sector and the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak.

HC rejects Athar Khan's bail plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday refused to grant bail to Athar Khan in a case under the anti-terror law UAPA concerning the "larger conspiracy" behind the February 2020 riots in the city's northeastern parts.

Observing that the accused was not entitled to bail, a bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Madhu Jain dismissed Athar's appeal challenging the trial court's January 29 order that denied him relief in the case.

Athar, a former call centre employee, is accused of being one of the main organisers of the protest at Chand Bagh in northeast Delhi and allegedly delivering inflammatory speeches



there. According to the Delhi Police Special Cell, Athar allegedly participated in secret meetings, in which he said that the "time has come to burn Delhi" and coordinated the destruction of CCTV cameras.

Khan was booked under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) for being one of the "masterminds" of the February 2020 riots that had left 53 people dead and more than 700

injured. The violence erupted during protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA), 2019, and the National Register of Citizens (NRC).

Activists Sharjeel Imam, Khalid Saifi and Umar Khalid, among others, were also booked for their alleged involvement in the larger conspiracy case, which is being investigated by the Delhi Police's Special Cell.

MILIND SHAH
Founder & CEO, WISHTEL

Since ancient times, India has been known as an educational hub and an intellectual superpower. From the study of the Vedas to ancient global universities such as Nalanda and Takshashila, India's educational evolution has long been celebrated worldwide. With more than 65 per cent of its citizens under 35, India is home to the world's largest youth population, making it clear that the country has an immense talent pool in the making. However, preparing millions of students for a globally competitive workforce requires more than quality education — it demands universal digital access. More than just book-based and cultural learning, it requires integrating modern, technology-driven education with India's rich educational heritage.

Today, digital connectivity is no longer a convenience; it is the foundation upon which India's future talent pipeline is being built. Recognising this shift, India has embraced digital transformation across schools, the workforce, banking, and the broader ecosystem through initiatives such as Digital India.

A decade ago, textbooks and physical classrooms were the primary sources of learning for students. Today, AI platforms such as ChatGPT, virtual lectures, online content, and digital libraries have become key resources for clearing competitive examinations and building professional careers long before students graduate. Whether you are studying in Assam or in a small town in Maharashtra, digital access determines the number of opportunities available to you.

According to the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation's 2025 Telecom Survey, 85.5 per cent of Indian households own at least one smartphone, while 86.3 per cent have internet access at home. Among young people aged 15 to 29, smartphone ownership has

reached near-universal levels. It is now evident that digital access has become central to this generation.

This expansion has democratised learning. The Government initiative DIKSHA (Digital Infrastructure for Knowledge Sharing), established in 2017, is another example of India's commitment to strengthening its future talent pipeline. Recently designated as India's 'One Nation, One Digital Platform' for school education, DIKSHA demonstrates how digital public infrastructure can reduce educational inequalities by making high-quality learning resources available regardless of geography. Yet, the story is not entirely one of success.

India's ambition to become a global knowledge economy continues to face challenges due to the persistent digital divide, which significantly hampers the country's progress towards achieving its goals.

According to the 2025 Digital Report by DataReportal, approximately 806 million people in India have access to the internet, with internet penetration now exceeding 55 per cent of the country's population. While this represents significant progress, it also highlights the fact that hundreds of millions of Indians remain offline. Bridging this gap will be critical to ensuring

that India develops a future-ready workforce capable of driving economic growth and innovation.

Looking ahead, digital access is evolving far beyond what we once imagined. Multilingual AI tutors, virtual reality laboratories, blockchain-based academic credentials, and industry-integrated digital apprenticeships are poised to redefine education. Additionally, as 5G becomes more widely available, affordable smart devices and improved broadband connectivity in rural areas will accelerate this transformation.

Although this momentum continues to grow,

text, images and videos, students must learn to verify sources of information, distinguish between authentic and synthesised media, respect copyright, and understand the ethical dimensions of AI-generated material. This is not merely a technology lesson, but a lesson in citizenship.

Another significant shift AI brings is personalised learning. Every classroom consists of students who learn differently, progress at varying speeds and possess different strengths. AI-powered learning tools can help teachers identify knowledge gaps, customise instruction and provide timely support. This enables educators to spend more time mentoring and nurturing higher-order thinking rather than on repetitive administrative tasks. AI should not replace teachers; it should empower them to become even more effective educators.

One of the greatest benefits of AI literacy is its ability to prepare students for future jobs that have not yet been invented. Every major technological revolution has created roles that could never have been predicted in advance. Future professions will require adaptability, lifelong learning and readiness to work with new technologies. Students in schools where AI literacy is introduced today are not merely being taught a new subject - they are being prepared for a constantly changing world.

The discussion, therefore, should not be about whether schools should introduce AI literacy. Instead, the more pressing question is whether we can afford not to. In the next ten years, AI literacy will be as essential as digital literacy has been over the past two decades.

Preparing students for an AI-driven future begins not in universities or workplaces, but in classrooms. The schools that embrace AI literacy today will be the ones shaping the thinkers, creators and leaders of tomorrow.

India still needs affordable computing devices to strengthen its talent pipeline for the future. Alongside infrastructure development, the country must also enhance digital literacy, teacher training, cybersecurity awareness, and access to affordable devices to ensure its future workforce is truly job-ready. A student from a rural area may not be able to afford a high-end device. Still, if suitable devices are available at reasonable prices, digital access will no

longer remain a barrier to talent. With a home-grown brand like WISHTEL, affordability need no longer be a challenge.

India has already built one of the world's most impressive digital ecosystems. The next challenge and opportunity is ensuring that every citizen has the means to access it.



AI pressure on school curricula

JASPREET BINDRA
Co-founder, AI & Beyond

Over the years, the success of educational institutions has been measured by their ability to help children memorise facts and figures, perform calculations and excel in examinations. But today's reality is evolving faster than at any other period in history. No longer confined to scientific laboratories and technology companies, AI has already found its way into all industries and professions, and is increasingly found in classrooms. This leaves no doubt that the time has come for AI literacy to stop being an optional skill, available only to engineering students and technology enthusiasts.

AI literacy is a concept that is often misunderstood. Learning it does not mean making everyone proficient in programming and machine learning. Rather, it

means understanding how the technology works, how it is applied, what its limitations are, and how to harness its power to think smarter, learn faster and solve problems more efficiently.

The upcoming generation will enter professions in which AI will be an integral part of decision-making. Lawyers will need to use AI in their research. Doctors will rely on AI to assist in diagnosing patients. Every professional, including designers, marketers, architects, teachers, and entrepreneurs will have to interact with intelligent systems. In this context, the future competitive edge does not lie in competing against AI, but in learning to work alongside it.

It is for this very reason that schools cannot afford to view AI merely as a hobbyist subject. AI literacy must be integrated into the curriculum as part of mainstream education, rather than

being treated as an additional subject limited to computer science. Learners should understand AI and its impact on history through misinformation, on economics through automation, on science through its assistance in research, and on creativity through literary and artistic works.

Just as essential is the development of human skills that AI cannot replace. Creativity, empathy, ethics, curiosity and critical thinking are all even more important in a world shaped by AI. A student who knows how to ask questions, assess the output produced by an AI tool, identify bias and think independently will fare far better than one who knows how to operate an AI application.

Educators also have an obligation to build digital discernment. With generative AI now capable of creating convincing

and highlights that employers struggle to find candidates with industry-ready competencies despite the country's large talent pool.

Recruiters across the globe believe that degrees have become the starting point, not the deciding factor, in recruitment.

- **The World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report 2025** highlights that 39 per cent of employers globally expect core job skills to change by 2030, driven primarily by AI, automation, and digital transformation. Nearly 63 per cent of employers identify skills gaps as the biggest barrier to business transformation, making talent availability a strategic concern rather than merely an HR issue.

- Around 30 per cent of Indian employers are shifting towards skills-based hiring, reducing dependence on degree requirements and emphasising demonstrated competencies, portfolios, and certifications.

- Global recruiters increasingly assess candidates through business simulations, case challenges, internships, and project portfolios instead of relying solely on academic scores.

Student skill gaps

Recruiters often stress that fresh grad-

uates underperform in five critical dimensions:

- **Communication and Presentability:** Many graduates possess technical knowledge but struggle to articulate ideas clearly. Recruiters identify presentation skills, business writing, negotiation, and client interaction as among the most critical deficiencies. In the AI era, communication has become a competitive advantage because routine technical tasks are increasingly automated.

- **Critical Thinking and Problem-Solving:** Organisations seek employees who can analyse ambiguity rather than execute instructions. Case-based interviews increasingly test structured thinking instead of textbook knowledge. Employers value curiosity, analytical reasoning, and evidence-based decision-making.

- **AI and Digital Readiness:** Today, AI literacy has become essential across industries, not only in technology companies. India currently faces a shortage of AI-ready professionals, with demand significantly exceeding supply, and projections indicate that the gap will continue to widen without rapid upskilling.

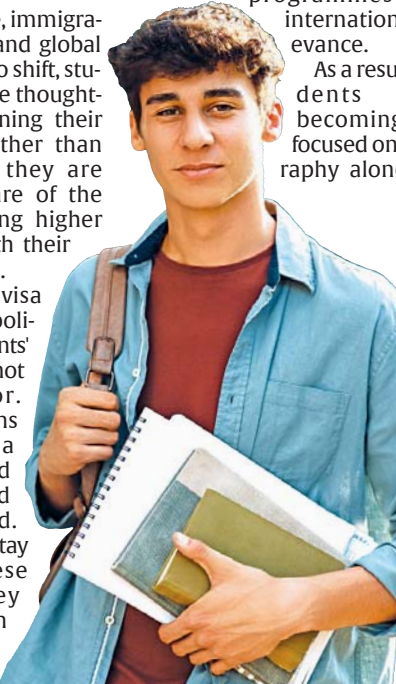
- **Learning Agility and Business Acumen:**

Recruiters often observe that graduates understand theories but fail to connect them with business outcomes. Skills such as commercial awareness, customer orientation, financial literacy, and market understanding distinguish high-performing candidates during campus recruitment.

Bridging the campus-to-corporate gap
To begin with, let us focus on certain unique advantages that can help bridge the campus-to-corporate gap:

- India ranks 13th globally in the QS World Future Skills Index 2027, reflecting growing preparedness for AI-driven economies.
- Indian graduates demonstrate 46.1 per cent employability for AI and Machine Learning roles, among the highest across technical domains.
- The rapid expansion of Global Capability Centres (GCCs), digital enterprises, fintech, healthcare technology, manufacturing, and green industries is creating significant opportunities for graduates equipped with multidisciplinary skills.

To remain relevant, HEIs should move beyond curriculum completion to focus on skills and competency development



Are Indian students reconsidering global education plans?

ANANT BENGANI

Director & Co-Founder, Zell Education

For generations, studying abroad has been seen as a gateway to global opportunities. However, in today's rapidly evolving landscape of visa regulations, shifting job markets, and evolving educational choices, students are becoming more thoughtful about how they plan their international education journey.

Studying abroad remains a dream for many college-going students in India, owing to its association with global exposure, quality education, and better career opportunities. However, the way students are pursuing this dream is changing. Instead of simply asking which country offers the best education, students are increasingly asking a more important question: How will this decision shape my career?

As visa norms evolve, immigration policies change, and global job markets continue to shift, students are taking a more thoughtful approach to planning their higher education. Rather than being discouraged, they are becoming more aware of the importance of aligning higher education choices with their long-term career goals.

While changes in visa and post-study work policies can influence students' decisions, they should not be the only factor. Immigration regulations are influenced by a nation's economic and labour requirements and are regularly revised. While students should stay informed about these developments, they should also focus on factors that are within their control.

Choosing a programme that offers industry-relevant learning, internships, and practical exposure can have a far greater impact on long-term employability than temporary policy changes. Ultimately, the purpose of higher education should be to build skills and prepare students for meaningful careers, rather than focusing solely on international mobility.

Students today are broadening the way they evaluate higher education opportunities. In addition to traditional study destinations, many are exploring emerging education hubs that offer quality education, specialised programmes, and growing career opportunities. Meanwhile, the higher education system in India has seen tremendous growth, with stronger industry partnerships, skill-based courses, and programmes with international relevance.

As a result, students are becoming less focused on geography alone and

more focused on finding the learning environment that best aligns with their aspirations. This shift is gradually moving towards finding the right learning environment that aligns with their interests, career goals, and financial considerations. Whether they choose to study in India or overseas, the objective remains the same: building a strong foundation for long-term career success.

Institutions Must Enable Career-Focused Choices

As education choices become more complex, institutions have a greater responsibility to support students with credible and transparent guidance. Career counselling should go beyond admissions guidance and help students understand industry trends, emerging job roles, evolving skill requirements, and the long-term value of different academic pathways.

Equally important is encouraging students to develop transferable skills such as communication, analytical thinking, problem-solving, adaptability, and digital proficiency. These competencies are increasingly valued across industries and often play a defining role in career success, regardless of where a student studies.

Higher education has never been just about earning a degree; it is about preparing for the future. In an uncertain world, the most successful students will be those who make informed decisions based on career outcomes rather than short-term trends. Studying abroad will continue to be a valuable opportunity for many, but its true value lies in how effectively it prepares learners for a rapidly evolving global workforce. That is the mindset students should adopt as they plan the next step in their academic and professional journey.

EMPLOYABILITY GAP: What recruiters expect from today's graduates

PROF. (DR.) TAPAN KUMAR NAYAK
Director, Jaipuria School of Business

Higher Educational Institutions (HEIs) in India produce one of the world's largest pools of graduates every year, yet the industry-academia gap continues to raise questions about workplace readiness. The campus-to-corporate gap, often referred to as the academia-industry skills gap, is no longer about technical knowledge alone; it is increasingly about agility, adaptability, communication, business acumen, digital fluency, and the ability to work with and alongside Artificial Intelligence (AI). As organisations move towards skills-first hiring, HEIs must rethink how they prepare students for the future of work and enhance their employability.

Graduate employability in India: A few realities

India has one of the youngest workforces globally, with nearly 65 per cent of its population below the age of 35, providing an unprecedented demographic advantage. However, only 42.6 per cent of Indian graduates are considered employable, according to the Mercer Mettl India's Graduate Skill Index 2025.

The CII India Skills Report 2025 places overall employability at 54.81 per cent



NATO unveils massive new arms deals

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Ankara

President Donald Trump arrived in Ankara Tuesday afternoon for the NATO summit, as the transatlantic military alliance was announcing billions in arms deals in an attempt to appease the mercurial US leader.

Trump was expected to head first to the presidential compound of Turkish leader Recep Tayyip Erdogan, a close ally who is hosting this year's gathering. Just before Air Force One touched down in Ankara, NATO showcased a series of military projects worth billions of dollars — an investment that the alliance's secretary-general, Mark Rutte, called "money well spent."

An energised Rutte was



speaking to Government ministers and defence industry officials at a forum billed as NATO's "big reveal," to the thrum of techno music and a slick video display.

NATO as an organisation

does not own any weapons - these are the property of the 32 member countries - but it does have a fleet of 14 AWACS early warning radar surveillance planes that are about 50 years old, along with some

newer surveillance drones.

A deal to replace the aging planes was announced Tuesday. Swedish manufacturer Saab will be supplying up to 10 new GlobalEye surveillance aircraft for a 10-nation consortium, Swedish Prime Minister Ulf Kristersson announced.

"It's a moment of great pride," he said, noting that the twin-engine aircraft would be "made within the alliance for all the alliance."

Some of the projects will be paid for with funds from a system of cheap loans for defense purposes set up by the European Union, comprising up to \$170 billion raised on capital markets.

"We need to ensure that we are translating our economic might into military capabili-

ties, putting the cash to work from defence plans to drones, from money to missiles and interceptors," Rutte said.

Trump has branded NATO a "paper tiger" that would cease to function without American arms and leadership. At the forum on Tuesday, Michael Duffy, a US undersecretary of defence, said "the reality is that we need production increases across the board."

"We will be looking to increase our exports to those who are looking to buy our equipment, and we'll also be looking to partner with the expansion of production capacity here in Europe," he said.

Representatives from 15 nations shook hands and patted shoulders on a vast podium under the NATO logo

as they announced a multinational effort to buy air-to-air refueling and transport planes from Airbus. Then Rutte announced a four-country effort to purchase as many as five new Triton surveillance drones to add to NATO's small fleet.

"It is genuinely made in NATO, and creating jobs on both sides of the Atlantic," he said. Rutte told reporters on the eve of the military alliance's two-day summit in Turkey that "we will announce tens of billions in new contracts that will provide the crucial kit we need to deter and defend."

However, at Tuesday's event, no dollar figures were given and the display included some projects long since agreed.

French court clears Marine Le Pen to run in 2027 election



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

A Paris appeals court cleared the way on Tuesday for popular far-right leader Marine Le Pen to possibly run for the French presidency next year but said she must wear an electronic bracelet, which she has said is a no-go. The verdict declared Le Pen guilty of embezzlement but softened the ban on her holding elected office, putting the ball in her court.

She must now decide whether campaigning in 2027 with a monitoring bracelet as part of her sentence to be served at home is possible.

The verdict appears to be a partial victory for Le Pen.

It reduced her ban on elected office – from five years handed down last year -- to 45 months, two-thirds of which are suspended. It also cut her prison sentence from

four years to three, two of which are suspended.

Still, the remaining year of prison time, to be served at home with an electronic bracelet, remains a potential hurdle and it's not immediately clear whether she feels she can campaign with that condition.

Le Pen, 57, may share her thoughts later Tuesday, in an evening television interview.

She had appealed a March 2025 conviction that found her and other members of her National Rally party guilty of misusing European Parliament funds by paying party staff with money intended for EU

parliamentary assistants between 2004 and 2016.

The lower court sentenced her to prison time, suspended pending the ruling from the appeal court, and imposed a five-year ban on holding elected office.

Explosions hit Damascus during Macron visit, at least 18 injured

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Damascus

Explosions rocked Syria's Capital on Tuesday and injured at least 18 people as France's president met with his counterpart in a landmark visit to the country rebuilding from years of civil war, Syria's Interior Ministry said.

It was the second attack in Damascus in a week and a setback for President Ahmad al-Sharaa as he welcomed the first major Western leader to visit since the ouster of longtime dictator Bashar



Assad by insurgent groups in late 2024. Syria's new rulers have wrestled with outbreaks of violence as they assert control, but the capital

had been been largely peaceful. French President Emmanuel Macron was in the presidential palace when the explosions hap-

pened. An official from the Elysee Palace said he was safe and the meeting with al-Sharaa continued, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss Macron's security.

"Nothing can smother the aspiration of Syrian women and men to live in a fully sovereign, safe, pluralistic, and united Syria," Macron said on X hours later. "This morning I met Syria in all its diversity. I saw dignity, courage and determination." Later, al-Sharaa and Macron announced

they have agreed to reappoint ambassadors after more than a decade, marking a major restoration of diplomatic ties. "Our meeting marks a historical milestone," al-Sharaa said. France had closed its embassy in 2012 but symbolically reopened it in early 2025.

Macron, who played a major role in pushing Europe and the United States to drop most sanctions that were imposed on Syria under Assad, was in Syria before heading to Ankara, Turkey, later Tuesday for a NATO summit.

US-Israel relationship at risk, warns Democrat candidate

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Washington

Rahm Emanuel, a potential Democratic presidential candidate and longtime defender of Israel, will denounce Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in Tel Aviv this week and deliver a bracing message that the country's relationship with the United States is "at a crossroads."

"It cannot stand or survive as it has been," Emanuel will say at Tel Aviv University on Wednesday, according to remarks obtained by The Associated Press. "To maintain the strength of our ties, we need significant changes and a new direction."

The speech, coming from a stalwart of Democrats' centrist wing, is another demonstration of how far their party has shifted away from its historic support of Israel.

About 58 per cent of Democrats

say the US is "too supportive" of the Israelis, according to a new survey by The Associated Press-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research, up from 45per cent in January 2024.

Roughly half of Democrats believe that Israel has committed genocide against Palestinians during the war in Gaza, an accusation that's been levelled by some human rights organisations and vehemently denied by Israel and the US Government. Emanuel's proposals will include sanctions on Israelis who attack Palestinian civilians and property along with companies and banks that support settlements considered illegal by most of the international community. He also wants to end US subsidies to Israel's defence budget, arguing the country "should be able to buy American arms under the same financial terms, the same restric-



Rahm Emanuel

tions, and the same requirements as every other trusted ally that abides by our laws." In addition, Emanuel will blame Netanyahu for driving Israel to a "dead end," emboldened by poor decisions from American leaders.

"For too long, American policy

toward Israel operated under the assumption that the best thing Washington could do for Jerusalem was to blindly and silently stand behind your Government, without conditions, without demands, and without consequences when we dis-

agreed," he will say. "That has been our mistake. Unconditional support has produced a prime minister who has presumed that his strategic interests would incur no cost if he ignored America's concerns."

There's little precedent for an American with presidential ambitions to travel to another country, much less one as fraught as Israel, to deliver such a stinging rebuke of its political leadership. Centrist figures like Emanuel have been more reluctant than Democrats' progressive base to question long-time US support for Israel in recent years. His remarks could prompt a similarly fiery response from Netanyahu, who famously once called Emanuel, who had ambitions of being the first Jewish speaker of the US House, a "self-hating Jew."

Netanyahu faces his own battle for reelection in October, and

the veteran leader may try to use a confrontation with Emanuel for political gain by appearing to stand strong in the face of international criticism.

But for possible Democratic presidential contenders gauging how to address the fallout from Israel's war in Gaza and Netanyahu's perceived tilt toward the Republican Party, led by President Donald Trump, the speech represents an especially frontal strategy.

The war has disrupted political coalitions in both major political parties in the US, with younger voters recoiling at Israel's approach to the conflict pressing American leaders to take a tougher stand. The issue has roiled some Democratic congressional primaries this year and could continue to be a dividing line in the contest for the party's presidential nomination in 2028.

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OPEN e-TENDER NOTICE

For and on behalf of the President of India, the undersigned invites E-Tenders for the following works up to 15.30 hrs on Dt: 31.07.2026:

Sl. No. 1, Name of the Work: Tender Notice No. & Date: SCR-BZA-SNT-E11-OT-26-27, Dt. 06.07.2026. Vijayawada Division: Signal and telecom Department: S&T works in connection with 1. Provision of MSDAC for Dual detection to existing track circuits on Road 1,4,6 (Goods loop.1) and UP (Rd.2) & DN (Rd.3) main lines at Rajahmundry station of Vijayawada division. 2. Provision of MSDAC for Dual detection to existing track circuits on Road 1,5,6,7 and Bridge Nos. 4A & 4 at Vijayawada station of Vijayawada Division. 3. Provision for additional Trip Inspection facilities for electric locomotives at PTS/BZA of Vijayawada Division.. **Tender Value Rs-Ps:** Rs.7,76,05,519.08ps, **EMD Rs.:** 15,52,100.00 only through online or bid security, **CTB Rs.:** Nil, **Completion period:** 06 Months

Sl. No. 2, Name of the Work: Tender Notice No. & Date: SCR-BZA-SNT-E12-OT-26-27, Dt. 06.07.2026. Annual Repair Contract for repairs of 05 watt VHF sets of kenwood make 100 Nos. and Sanchar Make 100 nos for one year period in BZA Division.. **Tender Value Rs-Ps:** Rs.2,87,746, **EMD Rs.:** Rs.5,800.00, **CTB Rs.:** Nil, **Completion period:** 12 Months.

Date of Closing and Timing: Time 15.30 hrs, Date: 31.07.2026

1. Tender conditions / other particular such as the details of name of work in full, the similar nature of the above works, eligibility criteria etc. are available in the Tender document published website at "www.ireps.gov.in."

2. The prospective tenderers are advised to visit website "www.ireps.gov.in" before the date of tender closing to note any changes / corrigenda for any tender.

Divisional Railway Manager (S&T)/ Vijayawada

OPEN e-TENDER NOTICE NO. E-03-CPOH-RYP-2026, Dt.06.07.2026.

For and on behalf of the President of India, the undersigned invites E-Tender for the following work up to 31.07.2026, 15:00 hours and the date mentioned against:

Sl. No. 1, Tender No.: E-03-CPOH-RYP-2026, **Name of work:** Crimping and Replacement of damaged Hydraulic hoses to track machines at CPOH/RYP (62 Machines) for 2026-27 and 2027-28, **Period of completion:** 24 Months, **Tender Value (₹):** 2,20,84,782.50, **EMD (₹):** 4,41,700.00, **Date of Closing:** 31.07.2026

1. Tender conditions/ other particulars such as the details of Name of work in full, the similar nature of the above works, eligibility criteria etc., are available in the Tender documents published in website at "www.ireps.gov.in".

2. The prospective tenderers are advised to visit website "www.ireps.gov.in" before the date of tender closing to note any changes/corrigenda for any tender.

3. The Tender Notice also displayed in the Notice Board located in the office of Dy. Chief Engineer, CPOH, S.C. Railway, Rayanapadu.

4. The Railway reserves the right to cancel the tender without assigning any reason therefor.

Visit our site at "www.ireps.gov.in"

Deputy Chief Engineer/CPOH/ SCoR-A065 Rayanapadu

For further tender conditions/ details and for downloading the tender documents, please visit the website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in>.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
e-Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer/Traction Distribution, DRM's Office, State Entry Road, New Delhi for & on behalf of President of India, invites open e-tender for the under noted work:

Name of work with its location	Part-B(II): Provision and application of composite high voltage insulated coating under girder bridges in DUK section inconnection with Strengthening of existing TRD assets in DUK section.
Approx. Cost of work	Rs.50,48,687.47/-
Earnest Money Deposit	Rs.1,01,000/-
E-Tender Bid Online Submission period	16.07.2026 (00.00 Hrs.) to 30.07.2026 (15.00 Hrs.)
E-Tender Bid Submission End Date & E-Tender Open Date & Time	30.07.2026 (15.00 hrs)
Fund Allocation	RRSK (PH-36)
Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in

E-Tender No.: 20-TRD-NDLS-2026-27 Dated: 07.07.2026

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NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE

Invitation of Tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)

Sr.DMM, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the president of India invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items.

Sr. No.	Tender No	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing date
1.	93256117A	Synchronized Electrical Operated Screw Jack (Set of 05 jacks) as per specification attached.	04 Set	03-08-2026

Note: -1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained.

Sr.DMM/NS/LP/93256117A/2026 Date: - 07.07.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE

Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement system.

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
1	77269051 RGC	RUNNING CONTRACT FOR PRESTRESSED CONCRETE SLEEPERS FOR 1 IN 12, 60KG TURNOUT (SLEEPER NO.65 TO 83) DRG. NO: T-4218	200 SET	27.07.26
2	77269052 RGC	RUNNING CONTRACT FOR PROCUREMENT OF PRESTRESSED CONCRETE SLEEPERS FOR 1 IN 12, 60 KG TURNOUT (SLEEPER NO.66 TO 69) DRG. NO: T-4218	500 SET	31.07.26
3	19262711	ROLLER BEARING RB 5020	519 NOS	31.07.26
4	19260703	SET OF LOCK NUT F.S. ALL STEEL	200 SET	03.08.26
5	19260602	AXLE BOX BEARING	339 SET	03.08.26
6	77269053 RGC	RUNNING CONTRACT FOR PROCUREMENT OF PRESTRESSED CONCRETE SLEEPERS FOR 1 IN 12, 60 KG TURNOUT (SLEEPER NO.41 TO 54) TO RDSO DRG. T-4865	100 SET	03.08.26
7	08265165	6 QUAD CABLE 1.4MM	47 KM	04.08.26
8	16264269	SPIN-ON FUEL FILTER,	2007 NOS	06.08.26
9	04250057B	TRANSFORMER OIL FOR THREE PHASE	32813 LTR	10.08.26

Note:1). Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained.

Tender Notice No. 24/2026-2027 Dated: 06/07/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

9 cops killed in terrorist attack in Pak

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

At least nine policemen were killed in a terrorist attack at a police post in Pakistan's Balochistan province, officials said on Tuesday.

The incident took place on Monday night at the police post in Ziarat district's Mangi Dam area.

Ziarat Deputy Commissioner Abdul Qudoos Achakzai confirmed that nine policemen were killed and further added that five remain missing. Dawn newspaper reported. Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif condemned the attack and paid tribute to those killed, state broadcaster PTV reported.

Additional personnel have been dispatched to the area, and an operation to recover the missing police officials is underway, Achakzai said. Those killed included the station house officers of Mangi and Kawas police stations, and Anti-Terrorist Force in-charge Head Constable Saifullah, Balochistan chief minister's aide Shahid Rind said in a statement.



Meanwhile, in a separate statement, Rind said that 15 terrorists of the Tehreek-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) were killed in the clearance operation initiated following the attack. TTP, a militant group, is designated as a terrorist organisation by the United Nations.

3 tankers hit in latest skirmishes in Strait of Hormuz



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Dubai

Three tankers were struck by projectiles Tuesday in the Strait of Hormuz, the British military said, in the latest attacks targeting vessels moving through the narrow mouth of the Persian Gulf.

The new assaults threatened to choke off the flow of traffic in the strait just as countries hoped to restore normal shipping practices and ease the global economic strain of the war between the US and Iran.

One of the tankers was travelling off the coast of Oman and caught fire, according to the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations centre. Iranian state television said the liquefied natural gas tanker came under attack after ignoring warnings but did not directly claim the assault. Two other tankers were also hit, including one that was struck by a drone. It was not immediately clear where they were at the time of the attacks.

Both of those ships sustained some damage, but no one was injured, the mar-

itime agency said. At least one of the vessels continued on its way, the maritime agency said. Tehran, which has repeatedly declared that only its approved route through the strait is safe, is suspected of attacking other ships that have used another route close to the Omani shore.

The US is eager to press ahead with negotiations with Iran aimed at fully reopening the strait, rolling back Tehran's disputed nuclear program and reaching a permanent end to the war launched February 28.

Previous attacks in the strait have sparked retaliatory strikes by the US Iran then attacked Gulf Arab states.

In peacetime, a fifth of all traded oil and natural gas passed through the channel.

Meanwhile, talks between Iran and the US appeared to be on hold until after the burial of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed at the beginning of the war. Mourners at his funeral have called for the death of US President Donald Trump.

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Govt extends NPS choice to autonomous bodies

The Government on Tuesday said it has extended two additional investment choices under the National Pension System (NPS) to employees of central autonomous bodies covered under the retirement scheme. The Government had earlier introduced additional investment choices, namely the Aggressive Life Cycle Fund (LC-75) and Balanced Life Cycle Fund (BLC), for the Central Government employees covered under NPS. These investment options have now also been extended to NPS subscribers employed in central autonomous bodies (CABs).

In a statement, the Finance Ministry said the expenditure department has extended the applicability of the Department of Financial Services notification dated November 13, 2025, to CAB employees covered under NPS. Aggressive Life Cycle Fund (LC-75), now named as LC-75-High, is an investment option with equity exposure of up to 75 per cent, designed for subscribers seeking higher growth potential over the long term. Balanced Life Cycle Fund (BLC) is now the Aggressive Life Cycle Fund. (PTI)

Embraer secures DGCA nod for three jets

Brazilian aerospace major Embraer, which has ambitious plans for the Indian market, has received aviation regulator DGCA's type certification for its three commercial jets.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has granted type certification for E195-E2, E190 and E195, Embraer said in a release on Tuesday. Embraer's E175 jet, operated by regional carrier Star Air, is already type certified by the regulator. "We welcome the type certification of Embraer's aircraft and thank the DGCA for its thorough assessment. With remarkable performance, economics, and passenger comfort, Embraer's E-jets are set to reshape regional aviation in India and support the Indian government's UDAN vision," Embraer's Senior Vice President Sales & Marketing, Head of Region Asia Pacific for Commercial Aviation, Raul Villaron said. The type certification is an approval by the DGCA for the overall design and airworthiness of an aircraft. (PTI)

VP calls for time-bound approvals, clear targets to boost cotton productivity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vice-President CP Radhakrishnan on Tuesday called for time-bound approvals and clear targets to boost cotton productivity in India. Radhakrishnan conveyed this to Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan when the latter met him to brief on the Mission for Cotton Productivity, its key components and implementation

strategy. Lauding the Mission's holistic approach to strengthen India's cotton ecosystem, the Vice-President "called for time-bound approval mechanisms to speed up innovation and ensure timely adoption of new technologies," the agriculture ministry said in a statement. Stressing the need to improve per-acre cotton yield, Radhakrishnan asked for clear and measurable targets to enhance productivity and close the gap with

The Pioneer



NEW DELHI | WEDNESDAY | JULY 8, 2026

India's ethanol strategy should win public trust

KARUNA GOPAL VARTAKAVI

In early July 2026, just a few days ago, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas convened a press conference in New Delhi with leaders from Energy Industry. Their message was loud and clear — India's petrol now contains 20% ethanol nationwide, the target has been met five years ahead of the original 2030 deadline, and vehicle owners have nothing to worry about. Ethanol is not a new or experimental automotive fuel. It has been called "fuel of the future". Ethanol's exceptionally high-octane number (approximately 108 RON) has made it a preferred fuel component for high-performance internal combustion engines. Ethanol has historically been used in several sports cars. But the social media was aflash with a very different message. Videos claiming E20 fuel corrodes engines, attracts insects to fuel caps and requires copious quantities of water to produce had been circulating for months, some of them viewed hundreds of thousands of times. India has executed one of the more consequential fuel-policy shifts of the decade, but unfortunately many do not trust it. This piece of mine tries to separate what is verified and why public should be open to see that truth ignoring the content that

went viral on social media. **What the Programme Actually Is** The Ethanol Blended Petrol (EBP) Programme did not begin with E20 nor did it begin recently. Pilot blending at 5% started at three locations in 2001, spread across nine states and four union territories in 2003. The programme's real acceleration dates to a revised National Policy on Biofuels in 2018, which reset the 20% target to 2030. By December 2025, public sector oil marketing companies had reached the 20% blending mark nationwide — feedstock now drawn from a widening mix of sugarcane juice and molasses, surplus rice released by the Food Corporation of India and increasingly maize. This is not framed by the Government purely as an industrial or agricultural policy. It sits explicitly within India's climate commitments too — ethanol blending is a decarbonisation lever supporting the country's Nationally Determined Contributions under the Paris Agreement and its 2070 net-zero target. Roughly 930 lakh metric tonnes of avoided CO₂ emissions and crude oil substitution of more than 310 lakh metric tonnes can be attributed to this program. **TRANSITION — Phased, Consultative, Science-Led** The Government's defence of the rollout is that it has not been sudden. A joint IOCL-ARAI-SIAM (Indian Oil Corporation Ltd — Automotive Research Association of India — Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers) study in 2010 examined the effects of E10 on existing vehicles, running

mileage accumulation of 20,000 km on two-wheelers and 40,000 km on four-wheelers, with interim testing every 5,000-10,000 km. That study found hydrocarbon and carbon monoxide emissions falling by roughly 20% with E10, with no drivability or startability issues. Another more consequential study followed soon, when the government tasked ARAI — working with IOCL, IIP-Dehradun and SIAM — with assessing "material compatibility and emission performance" for E20. That study reported carbon monoxide emissions falling by around 50% in two-wheelers and 30% in four-wheelers, and unburnt hydrocarbon emissions down roughly 20% across both categories, with no significant issues across most compatibility parameters — the one downside being that certain rubber parts and gaskets in older vehicles might need earlier replacement than under non-blended fuel. At the recent press conference, industry gave this research a commercial angle. Toyota Kirloskar's Vikram Gulati stressed that vehicle

testing and certification in India is governed by internationally standardised protocols under UNECE. Maruti Suzuki's Rahul Bharti offered a "statement of confidence" — of 2.84 crore vehicles serviced by Maruti in FY2025-26, more than 1.5 crore were over three years old and therefore not E20-certified — and the company reported no field-level incidents of corrosion, wear or component damage attributable to E20 among them. Hero MotoCorp's Ashutosh Varma made a similar claim for two-wheelers based on service data analysis. Internationally, the US runs E10 as its standard blend, with E15 expanding under federal backing and flex-fuel vehicles capable of E85. Brazil mandates E27 today, moving toward roughly 35% with more than 80% of new Brazilian passenger vehicles built as flex-fuel. Canada, Japan and Thailand run E10, and several European countries blend ethanol as a matter of course. On this reading, India's E20 is catching up to an established global norm, not experimenting ahead of one.

Sitharaman eyes 25% global toy market share

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Citing the toy industry's vast growth potential, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Tuesday said Indian manufacturers should aspire to capture at least a one-fourth of the global toy market share, which is estimated to reach \$179 billion by 2032. India exports toys to 153 countries and their value reached \$186 million in 2025-26, while imports have come down drastically by 71 per cent during 2019-26, she said in her address at the International toy exhibition here. India's toy market is projected to reach \$five billion by 2034, while the global toy market is projected to reach \$179 billion by 2032, she said. "We are still aiming at only (\$) five billion by 2034. I think we are capable of doing a lot better. We have immense potential to

capture; at least aim for one quarter of it (\$179 billion). That's a big number, no doubt. But we should aim at higher. Our aspiration must be far greater to capture a significantly larger share of the expanding global market," the minister said. Sitharaman said toy imports were earlier concentrated from one country, which was dumping a lot of their cheap goods that had

safety issues and were not healthy for children. She also asked the industry to focus on scale and branding. "Manufacturing is important, but branding creates value. Enduring value is only when your brand can be identified. Aankh band karke kharid lo (Buy it without a second thought), that kind of a branding confidence should come," she said.

Citing the example of French sports retailer Decathlon, she said: "I was impressed to see how they spend time for quality, and also for branding". Sporting goods market has been seeing a lot of innovation, and they bring it into their stalls, she said. "That's the kind of thing I'm asking." The Government has taken a series of measures to boost manufacturing of toys and reduce import dependence from countries like China. The Government has rolled out mandatory quality control norms and increased import duties from 20 per cent to 60 per cent. It developed a comprehensive National Action Plan for Toys in 2020 to boost local manufacturing and incentivise toy and handicraft manufacturers to make India the next global hub of toys.

BUSINESS13

The Water-Intensity Controversy

A separate and more agriculture-rooted critique concerns what ethanol is made from. Sugarcane and paddy are both water-intensive crops in a country with acute water stress in several regions, and viral claims have circulated a figure — roughly 10,000 litres of water per litre of ethanol — that the Ministry has explicitly rejected as baseless. The Government argues that paddy and sugarcane are grown mainly for food security, with only surplus stocks used for ethanol, so their water use should not be fully attributed to ethanol production. **The Geopolitical Urgency Layer** The most important piece in this whole ethanol gambit is the geopolitical angle. The timing of this year's push cannot be separated from the wider energy environment. West Asian Crisis reintroduced volatility into Middle Eastern crude supply routes — a live reminder of the vulnerability that comes with import dependence. India imports the large majority of its crude oil, and disruptions of this kind translate quickly into price and supply pressure at the pump. The Government's energy-security figures are pitched directly at this pressure-foreign exchange savings exceeding \$1.9 lakh crore and crude oil substitution of more than 310 lakh metric tonnes since 2015 attributed to the ethanol program. E20 is not simply an environmental initiative running on its own schedule — it is being actively positioned as a hedge that happened to be ready just as global crude markets became

less predictable again. **The Misinformation Layer** The pattern worth noting is that a scientifically grounded policy is being communicated in a way that leaves gaps for both genuine grievance and fabricated claims to occupy the same space. A vehicle owner with a legitimate question about a three-year-old car's gasket compatibility encounters the same information ecosystem as someone sharing a fake video of separated petrol and diesel. When the loudest official response bundles both categories together as "misinformation," it risks looking dismissive of the first group even while correctly debunking the second — and that in turn feeds the trust deficit rather than closing it. **Way Forward** India's ethanol blending programme has produced measurable, verifiable outcomes: a five-year acceleration on target, real emissions reductions, real crude substitution, and a credible hedge against Middle Eastern supply shocks at a moment those shocks have returned. Clearing the fog around E20 will require more than another round of press releases or conferences. A few concrete steps like independent, longitudinal verification, a genuine feasibility study on fuel choice, continued transparent feedstock transition, a standing fact-check mechanism separate from ministry messaging will go a long way in making citizens ride the high-octane road of trust.

The writer is a global thought leader and a futurist served on the Board of Engineers India Ltd (Union Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas)

Rupee rises 48 paise to close at 94.95 against US dollar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The rupee appreciated 48 paise to close at 94.95 (provisional) against the US dollar on Tuesday, on improved global risk sentiments as higher traffic flows through the Strait of Hormuz reduced supply uncertainties. Forex traders said market sentiment was also buoyed after Saudi Arabia slashed August crude oil prices for Asia by \$11 per barrel. Moreover, softness in Brent oil prices will ease inflationary pressures for India, the world's third-largest oil importer, market analysts said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 95.33 and traded in the range of 94.94-95.37 in intraday trade. At the end of Tuesday's trading session, the rupee was quoted at 94.95 (provisional), higher by 48 paise over its previous close. On Monday, the rupee depreciated 25 paise to close at 95.43 against the US dollar. "The Indian rupee gained sharply today on improved global risk sentiments and a weak dollar. Softness in crude oil prices too supported the rupee as it is likely to ease inflationary pressure. Disappointing ISM services PMI too supported the rupee," said Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan. Choudhary further noted that "improved global risk sentiments on improved traffic in the Strait of Hormuz

also supported the rupee. However, hedging demand from importers may cap sharp upside. "Traders may take cues from weekly employment change data from the US. USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of 94.60 to 95.30." Meanwhile, the dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading at 100.96, up 0.11 per cent. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, was trading higher by 1.19 per cent at \$72.85 per barrel in futures trade. On the domestic equity market front, Sensex declined 104.35 points to settle at 78,180.72, while the Nifty fell 31.65 points to close at 24,398.70. Foreign institutional investors purchased equities worth ₹243.03 crore on a net basis on Monday, according to exchange data.

Stock markets snap 4-day rally amid profit booking; Trent tumbles over 12%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark stock indices Sensex and Nifty closed lower on Tuesday due to last-minute profit-taking after a four-day rally and weak Asian trends. Paring its early gains, the 30-share BSE Sensex declined by 104.35 points, or 0.13 per cent, to close at 24,398.70. During the day, it climbed 379.85 points, or 0.48 per cent, to 78,664.92. The 50-share NSE Nifty dipped 31.65 points, or 0.13 per cent, to end at 24,398.70. Sensex and Nifty had rallied more than 2 per cent in the last four sessions to hit more than two-month high levels on Monday. Among Sensex shares, Trent emerged as the top loser, tum-

bling 12.42 per cent after its June quarter revenue growth missed market expectations. Adani Ports, Bharat Electronics, Larsen & Toubro, Reliance Industries and ICICI Bank were also among the laggards. Gains in IT shares, however, capped losses in key indices. HCL Tech led the gains, rising by 3.08 per cent ahead of the announcement of financial results. Tech Mahindra, Infosys, and Tata Consultancy Services also advanced. TCS will announce the quarterly results on Thursday, marking the start of earnings season for Indian IT players. Among others Titan jumped 2.62 per cent after the company reported a 41 per cent growth in its revenue for the June quarter

of FY27, driven by strong performances across its jewellery, watches and eyewear segments. Eternal rose by 2.12 per cent. "Profit booking emerged in the latter half of the session as weakness across Asian markets and investor caution ahead of the US Fed minutes weighed on sentiment. However, IT stocks continued to lend support, extending gains ahead of the June-quarter earnings season as the sector recovered from recent corrections," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said. The BSE SmallCap Select index declined 1.08 per cent and MidCap Select index dipped 0.15 per cent. Sectorally, Capital Goods dropped 1.73 per cent, followed by

Realty lost 1.61 per cent, Industrials (1.49 per cent), Power (1.12 per cent), Metal (1.04 per cent), Commodities (0.90 per cent) and Hospitals (0.90 per cent). Focused IT surged 2.25 per cent, IT jumped 2.12 per cent, Consumer Durables (0.65 per cent), MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (0.55 per cent) and Oil & Gas (0.09 per cent). A total of 2,633 stocks declined, while 1,599 advanced and 165 remained unchanged on the BSE. "Indian equities ended marginally lower, snapping a four-session winning streak, as weak cues from Asian markets and a renewed attack on an oil vessel in the Strait of Hormuz dampened investor sentiment," Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and

wealth tech firm, said. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 1.22 per cent to \$72.87 per barrel. In Asian markets, South Korea's Kospi tanked 4.91 per cent. Japan's Nikkei 225, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng also ended lower. Markets in Europe were trading on a mixed note. US markets ended higher on Monday. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) bought equities worth Rs 243.03 crore on Monday, according to exchange data. On Monday, the Sensex jumped 521.16 points, or 0.67 per cent, to settle at 78,285.07. The Nifty climbed 159.50 points, or 0.66 per cent, to end at 24,430.35.

The Northeast at the heart of India-Japan ties



SABIR NISHAT

The 16th India-Japan Annual Summit marks a new phase in bilateral ties, with economic security, advanced technology and human capital assuming centre stage. As the partnership deepens, Northeast India — particularly Assam - is emerging as a strategic bridge linking India's Act East Policy with Japan's Indo-Pacific vision.

From development partner to strategic ally

The just-concluded 16th India-Japan Annual Summit in New Delhi has reaffirmed what has become one of Asia's most consequential strategic partnerships. While earlier summits largely centred on development assistance, infrastructure and investment, this year's engagement reflected a relationship that has matured into a comprehensive partnership encompassing economic security, advanced technology, resilient supply chains, clean energy, defence cooperation, connectivity and human resource development. At a time when geopolitical uncertainties, technological competition and shifting economic realities are reshaping the Indo-Pacific, India and Japan have demonstrated that their partnership is no longer driven solely by economic interests but

increasingly anchored in shared strategic objectives and long-term trust. The summit also underscored a larger transformation taking place in the bilateral relationship. The India-Japan partnership has evolved steadily over the past decade from one focused primarily on Official Development Assistance and flagship infrastructure projects into a multidimensional collaboration that seeks to shape the emerging regional order. As both democracies navigate an increasingly uncertain international environment, they are investing in partnerships that enhance resilience, diversify supply chains and promote sustainable economic growth while preserving a rules-based Indo-Pacific.

This strategic convergence did not emerge overnight. Since the relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, New Delhi and Tokyo have institutionalised cooperation through regular summit meetings, ministerial dialogues and sector-specific mechanisms covering defence, trade, science and technology, digital innovation and maritime affairs. The Joint Vision for the Next Decade, adopted during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Tokyo last year, has further broadened the agenda by placing greater emphasis on emerging technologies, economic security and resilient industrial ecosystems.

Japan continues to be among India's most dependable development partners. Its financial and



technical assistance has helped transform India's infrastructure landscape through projects such as the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail Corridor, the Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor, Dedicated Freight Corridors, metro rail networks and urban transport systems.

Yet infrastructure alone no longer defines the relationship. The disruptions caused by the COVID-19 pandemic, geopolitical conflicts and increasing fragmentation of global supply chains have compelled countries to rethink economic interdependence. Cooperation in semiconductors, electronics manufacturing, critical minerals, battery technologies and advanced manufacturing therefore represents a natural evolution of bilateral engagement.

Technology has consequently emerged as perhaps the most dynamic pillar of the partnership. Japan's strengths in robotics, precision engineering, advanced

manufacturing and industrial innovation complement India's rapidly expanding digital economy, software capabilities and youthful talent pool. Collaboration in artificial intelligence, quantum technologies, cybersecurity, digital public infrastructure and semiconductor manufacturing is expected to define the next phase of India-Japan cooperation. Both countries understand that technological leadership will increasingly determine economic competitiveness and strategic influence in the twenty-first century.

Energy security is another area where converging interests are driving closer cooperation. Volatility in global energy markets has highlighted the importance of diversified and reliable energy partnerships. As India pursues its ambitious clean energy transition and Japan accelerates efforts towards carbon neutrality, both countries are expanding collaboration in liquefied natural gas,

renewable energy, green hydrogen, battery storage and other low-carbon technologies.

Their cooperation through the Quad, alongside Australia and the United States, further illustrates this broader convergence.

Amid these expanding strategic priorities, one region is assuming unprecedented importance in the India-Japan partnership: Northeast India. Once viewed largely through the prism of geography and security, the region is increasingly recognised as India's gateway to Southeast Asia and a critical bridge linking the Bay of Bengal with the wider Indo-Pacific. Its strategic location, abundant natural resources, growing connectivity and youthful population have transformed it into an integral component of India's Act East Policy as well as Japan's long-term engagement with the region.

Japan's engagement with the Northeast has expanded significantly since the establishment of the India-Japan Act East Forum in 2017. The forum has become an important mechanism for aligning India's Act East Policy with Japan's vision of a free and open Indo-Pacific, recognising that economic connectivity and regional development are inseparable from strategic stability.

Through the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA), Tokyo has emerged as one of the largest development partners in the region, financing highways in Meghalaya and Mizoram, the Dhubri-Phulbari bridge across the Brahmaputra, water supply and

urban infrastructure projects in Guwahati, and several connectivity initiatives designed to improve access to remote areas. Collectively, these investments reflect Japan's confidence in the Northeast as a region of opportunity rather than one defined by its historical challenges.

Assam is central to this transformation. As the economic engine of the Northeast, the State offers a combination of improving infrastructure, industrial land, natural resources and a rapidly evolving policy environment. The momentum generated by Advantage Assam 2.0 has further enhanced investor confidence by projecting the State as a destination for manufacturing, electronics, renewable energy, food processing and technology-driven industries.

The summit's momentum was quickly reflected in Assam's engagement with Japan. During his visit to New Delhi, Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the State is keen to play a greater role in deepening the India-Japan Special Strategic and Global Partnership, with a particular focus on semiconductors, clean energy and Japanese language training. Following a meeting with Ono Keiichi, Ambassador of Japan to India, which he described as productive, Sarma said the two leaders discussed emerging avenues of cooperation and reviewed the outcomes of the summit, particularly the opportunities it presents for Assam in these sectors.

The just-concluded summit

has therefore highlighted a broader shift in the India-Japan relationship. Connectivity today is no longer measured only by highways, bridges or railway corridors. It is increasingly defined by digital networks, innovation ecosystems, research partnerships, educational exchanges and the movement of skilled professionals. Economic cooperation is evolving from financial assistance towards co-development, co-innovation and joint value creation.

The challenge now is to convert the momentum generated by the summit into tangible outcomes. Infrastructure projects must be completed on schedule, educational partnerships expanded, industrial collaborations deepened and skill-development initiatives aligned with future workforce requirements. Governments alone cannot achieve these objectives. Universities, research institutions, industry bodies, start-ups and civil society must also become active stakeholders in strengthening this unique partnership.

In many ways, the next chapter of India-Japan relations will not be written only in New Delhi or Tokyo. It will also be shaped in Guwahati and across the Northeast, where new roads, industrial corridors, technology partnerships, educational exchanges and skilled young professionals are steadily redefining the region's place in Asia.

The writer is Deputy Director, Assam Information Centre, New Delhi. The views expressed are personal

Central Electricity Authority partners with BSES to organise All-India electrical safety awareness programme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Central Electricity Authority (CEA), Ministry of Power, Government of India, in association with BSES discoms, organised Electrical Safety Day 2026 in New Delhi recently. The programme brought together over 1,300 delegates from the power, safety, fire services, industry, RWAs and consumer groups. The event was live-streamed on YouTube and has so far generated over 76,000 views. This year's theme, "Today's Awareness, Tomorrow's Prevention: Let Us All Unite to Prevent Fire Hazards from Electrical Short Circuits", carried a clear message — electrical safety begins with awareness and every-day responsible behaviour. The pro-



gramme highlighted that many electrical fires can be prevented through timely inspection, proper maintenance, safe usage, quality equipment and responsible action.

Union Minister of Power and Housing & Urban Affairs Manohar Lal, and Minister of State for Power and New & Renewable Energy Shripad Yesso Naik, addressed the programme through video messages. They emphasised that electri-

cal safety must become part of everyday life and highlighted the importance of safety check-ups, proper earthing, avoiding overloading and using quality equipment.

The programme was graced by Ghanshyam Prasad, Chairperson, CEA. Also present were Sunil Kumar Jha, Directorate General-Fire Services, Civil Defence & Home Guards; CEA Members A Balan, Praveen Gupta, Hemant Jain and V K Singh; Amal Sinha, Director and Group CEO, BSES; Abhishek Ranjan, CEO, BRPL; and Santosh Kumar, COO, BYPL.

A key highlight was the launch of two safety publications — "Vidhut Suraksha Bodh", an electrical safety handbook for children, and "Electrical Fire Safety Book", a guide on preventing electrical fire hazards

and promoting safe use of electricity.

Eminent actor Ashutosh Rana participated in an engaging fireside chat that linked electrical safety with everyday life, discipline and responsibility. Drawing a distinction between Raksha and Suraksha, he said that while Raksha is protection after a crisis, Suraksha is the awareness and discipline that prevent a crisis from occurring. Using examples from ancient India and philosophy, he emphasised that power must always be accompanied by restraint, stability and responsibility. A Nukkad Natak on Safety Best Practices was staged, along with a thematic presentation titled "Fire Speaks – The Journey of Fire", to make electrical fire safety more relatable.

Amrita Vishwa Vidyapeetham trains 3,600 teachers in AI



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In line with the National Education Policy 2020 and AICTE's declaration of 2025 as the Year of Artificial Intelligence, Amrita Vishwa Vidyapeetham has trained and certified more than 3,600 school teachers across India through its flagship AI for Teachers workshop series.

Led by the university's Delhi NCR Faridabad campus, the programme was conducted through six online sessions across two editions. It saw strong participation from educators in private, public, and government schools nationwide.

The initiative aims to help teachers understand and use Artificial Intelligence responsibly in classrooms, supporting India's goal of building AI awareness in education.

Prof. Kamal Bijlani, Dean, School of Artificial Intelligence, said: "AI is not here to replace teachers; it is here to empower them. Through this initiative, Amrita is building a nationwide community of AI-enabled teachers."

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

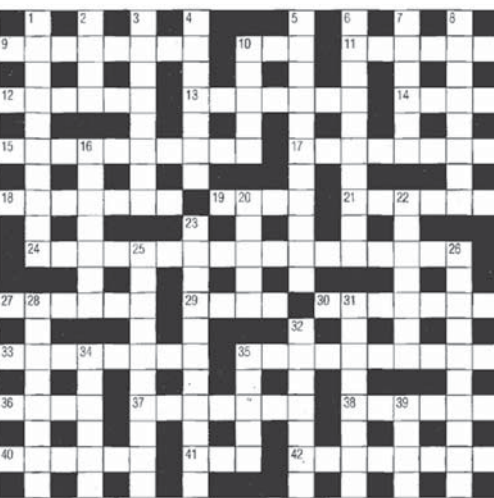
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (7.7.26)								
2	3	8	6	1	4	5	7	9
6	4	5	7	3	9	1	8	2
7	1	9	8	5	2	4	3	6
1	5	2	3	9	8	6	4	7
9	6	4	2	7	5	8	1	3
8	7	3	4	6	1	2	9	5
4	8	6	9	2	7	3	5	1
3	9	1	5	4	6	7	2	8
5	2	7	1	8	3	9	6	4

DOUBLE CROSSWORD WEDNESDAY | JULY 8, 2026



ACROSS

- 9 Refrain from including an Eastern ancestor (8)
10 There's nothing about accommodating the deer (3)
11 Meaning Scamp to take the ball right to 12 Not just cloudy? (6)
13 So get me one, I don't care which of you does! (7)
14 With the day almost over, it flies! (4)
15 Did it and was removed bodily (7,3)
17 Better pack the eggs in with the vegetable (8)
18 Would you put your faith in a builder who could do so? (7)
19 To tow back, charge (4)
21 Indict the copper in the case wrongfully

DOWN

- 1 Ringing from somewhere at the funfair
2 Getting a letter wrong in the second half of the alphabet (4)
3 Be told twice to voice your approval (4,4)
4 Continue to recruit, willy-nilly? (5,2)
5 That damned deliveryman? (5,6)
6 The scoutmaster's assistant? (4,2,4)
7 When the creature returns, gives it another dosing (6)
8 The clergyman is embraced by the holy priest (4)
10 Send the metronome back? (5)
16 Take back "misfortune" (7)
20 Scolds - and one deserves it (5)

- 24 Capitulates and gives the cake free
27 A rather rough sea, too (2,4)
29 Nonsense! A hard drinker knocks it back! (4)
30 Climbs, but when it gets cold, stops (7)
33 Got back there to assemble in a group
35 In favour of acquiring, but being absent-minded about (10)
36 There's a number on her back (4)
37 They know a lot about the cross Peter's forced to bear (7)
38 The character that put the "To Rent" sign outside? (6)
40 Calm down and pay (6)
41 Said I would take a look at (3)
42 Wrongly thought to have said "in mid-cut" (8)

- 22 In substance, quite satisfied (7)
23 Disguised, in its present form (4,7)
25 Worked on by a good cobbler? That's rich! (4-6)
26 Come to a sad conclusion (3,2,5)
28 Curtain drawn, take on a tour of (4,4)
31 Not pipped, as no really good players are competing? (8)
32 Will go on being soft in the head, you suppose (7)
34 Demands that one does it at once (6)
35 Might use a jemmy? (5)
39 Draws one into the set-up (4)32 The boys joke about the new head (4)
33 Still, there's satisfaction in getting it (4)

SOLUTION (7.7.26)																	
ACROSS									DOWN								
4, Lights	21, Look ahead	2, Do-NS	18, Post-a-L	20, Easel	1, M-or-ag	2, 16-1 OM	21, Low	3, Glue	12, Spoon	30, Adios	31, (Euro-)trash	32, Ca-n-g	33, Even	15, Yak (Kay)	16, L-ed	34, Elder	35, Rave-n-O-us
7, Old flame	24, Nuns	26, No-W	27, 14-CL	28, Ale-rt	29, domino	25, (ro-)Use-(a)	30, Adios	31, (Euro-)trash	32, Ca-n-g	33, Even	34, Elder	35, Rave-n-O-us	36, Bought-t	37, 14-CL	38, 12-CL	39, 12-CL	40, 12-CL
10, A-rose	27, 14-CL	28, Ale-rt	29, domino	30, Adios	31, (Euro-)trash	32, Ca-n-g	33, Even	34, Elder	35, Rave-n-O-us	36, Bought-t	37, 14-CL	38, 12-CL	39, 12-CL	40, 12-CL	41, 12-CL	42, 12-CL	43, 12-CL
13, Bell	29, East	30, Adios	31, (Euro-)trash	32, Ca-n-g	33, Even	34, Elder	35, Rave-n-O-us	36, Bought-t	37, 14-CL	38, 12-CL	39, 12-CL	40, 12-CL	41, 12-CL	42, 12-CL	43, 12-CL	44, 12-CL	45, 12-CL
14, Camp	32, Gal-E	33, Final	34, Final	35, Rave-n-O-us	36, Bought-t	37, 14-CL	38, 12-CL	39, 12-CL	40, 12-CL	41, 12-CL	42, 12-CL	43, 12-CL	44, 12-CL	45, 12-CL	46, 12-CL	47, 12-CL	48, 12-CL
15, Yale	33, Final	34, Final	35, Rave-n-O-us	36, Bought-t	37, 14-CL	38, 12-CL	39, 12-CL	40, 12-CL	41, 12-CL	42, 12-CL	43, 12-CL	44, 12-CL	45, 12-CL	46, 12-CL	47, 12-CL	48, 12-CL	49, 12-CL
16, Let	34, Final	35, Rave-n-O-us	36, Bought-t	37, 14-CL	38, 12-CL	39, 12-CL	40, 12-CL	41, 12-CL	42, 12-CL	43, 12-CL	44, 12-CL	45, 12-CL	46, 12-CL	47, 12-CL	48, 12-CL	49, 12-CL	50, 12-CL
17, O-pal	35, Rave-n-O-us	36, Bought-t	37, 14-CL	38, 12-CL	39, 12-CL	40, 12-CL	41, 12-CL	42, 12-CL	43, 12-CL	44, 12-CL	45, 12-CL	46, 12-CL	47, 12-CL	48, 12-CL	49, 12-CL	50, 12-CL	51, 12-CL
19, Veer	36, Bought-t	37, 14-CL	38, 12-CL	39, 12-CL	40, 12-CL	41, 12-CL	42, 12-CL	43, 12-CL	44, 12-CL	45, 12-CL	46, 12-CL	47, 12-CL	48, 12-CL	49, 12-CL	50, 12-CL	51, 12-CL	52, 12-CL

Scientific bamboo harvesting training marks start of community forest economy pilot

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhubaneswar

A scientific bamboo harvesting training programme was launched at Jakalundi village, marking the rollout of a unique community-centred bamboo management model that brings together forest conservation, women-led livelihoods, and sustainable local enterprise. The initiative is being implemented by the Malkangiri Forest Division, Kalimela Forest Range, in collaboration with local Gram Sabhas, the Maha Gram Sabha Kalimela, the Bharti Institute of Public Policy (BIPP) at the Indian School of Business (ISB), and the Kanam Raj Green Shakti Producer Company—a fully women-owned enterprise supported by the Department of Mission Shakti. The pilot is being run with support from the Odisha Bamboo Development Authority (OBDA). Professor Ashwini

Chhatre, Executive Director, Bharti Institute of Public Policy, Indian School of Business, said that this pilot represents a grounded model of forest-based transformation. "It links scientific harvesting, community governance, women's enterprise, and

market systems into one integrated approach. By placing Adivasi women and Gram Sabhas at the centre, Kalimela can demonstrate how forest economies can generate shared prosperity while maintaining ecological integrity," he added.

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Director of Research.

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Dated CHD :- 07/07/2026

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BRIEFLY

Rodri sorry after spat with former Man City teammate



Spain midfielder Rodri expressed regret at celebrating in the face of Bernardo Silva after his former Manchester City teammate missed a late chance to equalize for Portugal in their heavyweight World Cup match.

Silva had a chance to take the round-of-16 game - won 1-0 by Spain on Monday - to extra time but headed over the crossbar after six minutes of stoppage time.

As the Portugal playmaker lay on the ground with his head in his hands, Rodri walked up to Silva and clenched his fist in a taunting gesture. Silva stood up and confronted Rodri, brushing aside his arm and pointing in his face.

The two players have played together in City's midfield since 2019. Silva left this summer after running down his contract, and has since joined Real Madrid.

Rodri told reporters after the game that he'd said sorry to Silva.

"I made a mistake," the 2024 Ballon d'Or winner said, "because I celebrated when he had missed. I apologized to him immediately.

"But that's all, because of the trust we have."

While Portugal was headed home, Spain advanced to a meeting with Belgium in the quarterfinals. (AP)

Disappointing WC for Pulisic as US star is scoreless



United States forward Christian Pulisic could only watch from the bench as Belgium extinguished his team's World Cup bid, ending a tournament in which the American star was hobbled by injuries and largely ineffective.

The most accomplished U.S. striker, Pulisic was held scoreless in his second World Cup. He has 33 goals in 90 international appearances but has scored just once in eight World Cup games - against Iran in the group stage in 2022.

For the second time in this World Cup, Pulisic left a match in the second half with an injury, leaving Monday's 4-1 loss to Belgium after twisting his right ankle when he extended for a shot attempt and hit the boot of Belgium captain Youri Tielemans in the 52nd minute.

After spending a few moments lying on the pitch, Pulisic began favoring the foot and was replaced in the 59th by Sebastian Berhalter with the U.S. trailing 3-1.

Having to come out of the game was "difficult for me to deal with," he said. "I felt really good this summer with the guys and I thought my level was high," Pulisic said. "It's disappointing I didn't quite have the moments I was hoping to and to try to help us to get over this next step of beating a really good team." (AP)

Balogun return has little impact in US World Cup loss

ANDREW DESTIN ■ Seattle

Folarin Balogun's presence on the field for the United States against Belgium had a seismic impact on the world of soccer, but he ultimately played a forgettable role in the Americans' 4-1 loss in the World Cup round of 16 on Monday.

The 25-year-old striker, who had three goals in this World Cup, was shown a red card during the U.S. victory over Bosnia-Herzegovina, but FIFA lifted his suspension for Monday's match after US President Donald Trump intervened on Balogun's behalf.

FIFA's decision prompted soccer leaders to question the integrity of the World Cup, with European soccer body



UEFA saying FIFA "crossed a red line" and Belgium's soccer federation contesting Balogun's eligibility. "I accepted the decision when I was given the red card, and I accepted the decision when

Argentina beat Egypt 3-2, reach quarterfinals

MAURA CAREY ■ Atlanta

Lionel Messi did it yet again at this year's World Cup. The Argentina great scored once while inspiring his team to an improbable 3-2 victory over Egypt on Tuesday despite trailing by two goals with only 11 minutes to play.

The defending champions will next face either Switzerland or Colombia in quarterfinals on Saturday in Kansas City, Missouri.

Messi, who was in tears after the final whistle, scored his eighth goal of this year's tournament in the 83rd minute to level the score at 2-2. It was his record-extending 21st at the World Cup.

Enzo Fernandez scored the

winning goal in stoppage time to complete one of the great World Cup comebacks. Cristian Romero started the rally in the 79th minute.

Argentina had trailed 2-0 on goals from Yasser Ibrahim and Mostafa Zico. Messi also missed a chance in the first half when his penalty kick was saved by Egypt goalkeeper Mostafa Shobeir. He later hit the post when the score was 1-0.

Argentina is bidding to become the first team to win back-to-back titles since Brazil did so in 1958 and 1962. (AP)

Meanwhile, Lionel Messi scored his eighth goal of this year's World Cup on Tuesday against Egypt, extending his scoring streak to nine consec-



Argentina's Lionel Messi celebrates after scoring his side's second goal during the World Cup round of 16 soccer match between Argentina and Egypt in Atlanta

AP

utive games for Argentina and moving to the top of a tight Golden Boot race.

The 21st goal of Messi's World Cup career came in the 83rd minute off an assist from Gonzalo Montiel, leveling the game at 2-2 and making up for a saved penalty kick in the 19th minute. Messi's goal came only minutes after assisting on Argentina's first score of the game - a header from Cristian Romero in the 79th minute.

Yasser Ibrahim put Egypt ahead in the 15th minute with a header. Mostafa Zico scored Egypt's second goal in the 67th minute off an assist from Haissem Hassan.

Messi has now scored in a record nine consecutive World Cup matches dating

back to Argentina's title run in 2022. Tuesday's goal marked his 13th in that nine-game span.

In the race for his first Golden Boot, Messi entered Tuesday's match even with France's Kylian Mbappe and Norway's Erling Haaland at seven goals each. Mbappe held the tiebreaker with two assists. England's Harry Kane is also in the running with six goals. The goal also gave Messi a two-goal lead over Mbappe on the all-time World Cup goal leaderboard.

Messi finished second in the Golden Boot race behind Mbappe in 2022 with seven goals while leading Argentina to the title. He tied for third with four goals in 2014. (AP)

Mikel Merino's late goal sends Spain to WC quarterfinals

SCHUYLER DIXON

■ Arlington (Texas, USA)

Mikel Merino was still on the bench in the final minutes of regulation, with Spain coach Luis de la Fuente worried about hanging on to his substitutes as long as possible because of looming extra time.

The Arsenal forward made all that fretting moot. Merino scored in the first minute of second-half stoppage time, and Spain beat Portugal 1-0 on Monday to end the World Cup career of superstar Cristiano Ronaldo.

Merino had just been knocked down, and a foul was called. While Portugal's Bernardo Silva argued, Merino played the ball back

in, ran toward the goal and easily beat goalkeeper Diogo Costa after a series of passes capped by Ferran Torres' nifty ball through the middle.

"He's one of the best in his position worldwide, and he has given us a fantastic result and a fantastic goal," de la Fuente said through a translator. "I want to express the importance of substitutes that came in later in the game. Not just today, but the contribution in other games has been enormous."

Spain, which has a 35-game unbeaten streak, advanced to the quarterfinals for the first time since winning its only World Cup title in 2010. La Roja will play Belgium, a 4-1 winner over



the United States, on Friday in Inglewood, California.

Ronaldo was trying to get Portugal to the quarterfinals in a second consecutive tournament for the first time.

Instead, the career on soccer's biggest stage is over for the all-time leader in international goals (146) and appearances (233).

Merino didn't enter until

the 85th minute, and his heads-up play showed some of the versatility that helped Arsenal win its first Premier League title in more than 20 years this spring. The World Cup was in doubt for Merino, who turned 30 during the tournament, after right foot surgery cut short his Arsenal season. In the biggest moment of the year for Spain, there he was with fresh legs, finishing with his left foot into the left corner of the net. After emerging from a group hug with his teammates, Merino made a circle around the flag in a corner before letting out a guttural scream while clenching both fists.

That's how his father, Miguel Merino, celebrated

more than three decades ago during his club career in Spain. And his son first emulated it after a late goal to beat host Germany to send Spain to the semifinals of the European championship two years ago. This was Mikel Merino's first World Cup goal, and 11th for the national team.

"What better way to celebrate," Merino said. "You remember all the good and the bad, and there have been difficult moments for me this year." The latest meeting of Iberian Peninsula rivals that first played in a friendly in Madrid 105 years ago was quite the contrast to their most recent World Cup match. (AP)

Integrity of WC questioned as Trump, FIFA defend actions around suspension of Balogun

GRAHAM DUNBAR ■ Geneva

Soccer leaders questioned the World Cup's integrity on a chaotic and unprecedented day in the event's modern history Monday.

The furor centered on a phone call that President Donald Trump made last week to FIFA head Gianni Infantino to make the case that US striker Folarin Balogun should not have been suspended for matchup with Belgium because of a red card in a game last week. FIFA lifted the suspension and cleared Balogun to play.

The decision appeared to be the first time since 1962 that punishment for a World Cup offense was suspended in the tournament, increasing scrutiny on Infantino's control of FIFA and his close association with Trump.

European soccer body UEFA said FIFA "crossed a red line" and called Sunday's decision by FIFA's disciplinary committee "unprecedented, incomprehensible and unjustifiable." Infantino denied having a role in the decision. Trump called it a "horrible" call and took credit for getting FIFA to review the foul, but said he did not demand an outcome.

The Belgian Football Association said it informed the US Soccer Federation it was contesting Balogun's eligibility. But FIFA's appeals committee dismissed Belgium's legal challenge less than eight hours before scheduled kickoff. The appellate panel said Belgium had no standing to challenge the decision. Balogun's red card was assessed by Brazilian referee Raphael Claus for



stepping on an opponent's ankle last Wednesday during the Americans' 2-0 win over Bosnia-Herzegovina, triggering an automatic one-game suspension. FIFA's disciplinary committee on Sunday provisionally lifted the suspension for one year and fined Balogun \$40,000, which the USSF can pay. UEFA vs. FIFA reignites: European soccer officials reacted with outrage. "When the certain-

ty of rules is no longer guaranteed by its guardians, the integrity of the game is at stake and the credibility of a competition is undermined," UEFA said in a statement.

"Sometimes rules are open to interpretation. In this case not," it said. "When the certainty of rules is no longer guaranteed by its guardians, the integrity of the game is at stake and the credibility of a competition is undermined."

Coaches speculated about the implications of the decision going forward.

"What about the next red card? What happens then?" Norway coach Stale Solbakken said. "Is there going to be some committee somewhere that is going to take that card away? It's a bad, bad, bad, bad, bad decision that will hurt the World Cup." FIFA's disciplinary committee defended its decision in a statement Monday.

"Reviewing the legal consequences of red cards in football is nothing new in the modern game," it said. "In the majority of top-tier leagues belonging to UEFA-affiliated member associations the overturning of red cards is a common disciplinary measure, yet this has never raised concerns about crossing any 'red line.'" Trump's

comments: Trump on Monday called the referee's decision a "horrible" call while admitting he was confused about the rules and punishment surrounding red cards. "I didn't think it was a foul," Trump said. "I thought it was two great athletes that crashed into each other and got entangled." He also acknowledged calling Infantino. "All I did was ask for a review," Trump said. "I didn't say, You have to do this." Infantino issued a statement saying: "FIFA's judicial bodies are independent. They operate autonomously." "I explained that there was an ongoing legal process involving FIFA's independent judicial bodies and that the case would be decided in due course by the competent bodies," he said of his conversation with Trump. (AP)

Spain sets WC record with 6th clean sheet in row, keeper Simon extends scoreless mark

STEPHEN HAWKINS

■ Arlington

Spain broke a World Cup record with its sixth consecutive clean sheet and goalkeeper Unai Simon extended his record shutout streak to 609 minutes after a 1-0 win over Portugal on Monday.

Spain broke its tie with Italy (1990) and Switzerland (2006-10) for the most consecutive World Cup matches not allowing a goal. Spain's streak began with a 0-0 draw in the round of 16 in 2022, when Morocco advanced after a penalty shootout. There was also a surprising scoreless draw against Cape Verde to open group play in



this tournament followed by four consecutive shutout victories to advance to the quarterfinals.

Simon surpassed the previous record of 517 consecutive scoreless minutes during

a 3-0 blanking of Austria to open the knockout round Thursday. Famed Italy goalkeeper Walter Zenga set the standard in 1990 with five consecutive clean sheets in his home World Cup. (AP)

Mbappe condemns Paraguayan senator over racist remarks after WC match

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ New York

France star Kylian Mbappe on Monday condemned a Paraguayan senator over racist remarks she made following Paraguay's loss to France in the round of 16 at the World Cup.

Mbappe called Celeste Amarilla, a senator from Paraguay's Liberal Radical Party, a "despicable woman" who was "unworthy" of serving in Paraguay's Congress. "Through your recklessness and your brazen racism, the entire world has already forgotten the journey and the historic effort that your players accomplished during this World Cup," Mbappe wrote on X. Amarilla

posted a series of racist comments on X after Mbappe converted the winning penalty in France's victory over Paraguay on Saturday, mocking the French captain's origins, upbringing, education and appearance. France advanced to the quarterfinals, where it will face Morocco on Thursday.

Late Monday, Amarilla issued an open letter in French and Spanish to Mbappe on social media, in which she said her problem was with the player, not the country of France. She wrote that she regretted mistreating Mbappe with "the same insults" she's received as a mixed-race person and that she had deleted her post.

But she also demanded an



apology from Mbappe, accusing him of gender-based violence in his comments about her, and threatening legal action if he didn't retract them. The Associated Press

emailed France's team media officers for comment on Amarilla's letter.

The Paraguayan government released a statement Monday afternoon condemn-

ing Amarilla's remarks as "contrary to the values and principles that inspire peaceful coexistence and respect for human dignity that our country promotes." It added that the senator's comments do not represent either the Paraguayan government or the Paraguayan people.

The French Football Federation on Monday denounced Amarilla's comments as "utterly abhorrent" and "unacceptable," adding that it would refer the matter to prosecutors.

France's president, Emmanuel Macron, and sports minister Marina Ferrari voiced support for the national team's captain.

"By targeting Kylian Mbappe, the senator is

attacking everything our captain embodies and everything our country stands for: liberty, equality and fraternity," Ferrari wrote on X.

"One more goal for Kylian Mbappe. This time against racism," Macron wrote on X, adding the captain had his "full support." France's assistant coach Guy Stephan also condemned the remarks on Monday. "In three words, it's indignant, abject, scandalous," he said. Before Saturday's match, former Paraguay goalkeeper Jose Luis Chilavert referred to France as "a squad from Africa." Philippe Diallo, president of the FFF, said Chilavert "was once a great goalkeeper" who had now "fallen into disgrace."

President Murmu unveils Durand Cup trophies



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu, on Tuesday, unveiled the Durand Cup 2026 trophy, officially marking the beginning of preparations for Asia's oldest football tournament at the Rashtrapati Bhavan Cultural Centre.

The ceremony was attended by former Chief of Defence Staff General Anil Chauhan, Chief of the Army Staff General Dhiraj Seth and Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swamina than, underlining the Armed Forces' enduring association with the prestigious tournament.

Father’s dream fulfilled as Yash Thakur makes India squad

KUSHAN SARKAR
■ New Delhi

When Vidarbha pacer Yash Thakur steps into the Indian dressing room for his possible national debut during the upcoming tour of Zimbabwe, it wouldn’t exactly be the story of a fresh-faced rookie.

It would be a tale of perseverance built over nearly a decade of domestic grind, fuelled by a father’s ambition who tragically did not live to see the dream finally coming true. The 27-year-old Thakur received perhaps the most important phone call of his professional life so far while waiting to collect his baggage at the Nagpur airport after

returning from India A’s tour of Sri Lanka recently.

It was to inform of his maiden India selection for the tour of Zimbabwe tour that will feature three T20 Internationals from July 23 to 26. “Honestly, I wasn’t expecting anything because I had only just come back from the Sri Lanka tour. I never thought I would get a call so soon,” an emotional Thakur told PTI in an exclusive interview.

His List A debut was back in 2017 and he is nearing 100 wickets after 57 appearances in the circuit. He has showed up in 74 T20s, including 22 IPL games for two different franchises. Add to that familiarity with Indian bowling coach Morne Morkel during his IPL



stint with Lucknow Super Giants. Thakur can hardly be considered a greenhorn.

He is actually a perfect product of the Indian system having played Ranji Trophy, Duleep Trophy, Irani Cup, and Vijay Hazare followed by

inclusion in BCCI’s Targeted ‘Fast Bowlers List’. Regular India A assignments convinced him that the dream was getting closer.

A dream that wasn’t his alone. His father, Ravisingh Thakur, was deeply invested

in it but is not around to witness its accomplishment owing to a fatal cardiac arrest in 2023. However, Thakur’s mother Kajal and his elder sister stood firmly by his side after the massive loss, helping him stay on course. The emotions, Thakur admitted, are still difficult to process. “It still doesn’t feel real. I am still not able to process it. It will take some time to sink in. Everyone at home is happy and all those emotions are still playing out,” the bowler said. “His dream was to see me represent India. This call-up is the fulfilment of that dream.”

Opening up about the toughest phase of his life, Thakur recalled how his father’s sudden demise left

him devastated. “I was in Nagpur at that time. It was a very difficult time for me. Initially, it took me a long time to cope with the loss.” “(But) My father always told me that whatever happens in life, I should never lose sight of our dream. He would always tell me that nothing should affect that dream. Those words stayed with me and helped me move forward,” an overwhelmed Thakur said.

Thakur has no qualms admitting that he owes his cricketing journey to his parents, who backed him despite financial constraints of being mid-level business family. “They never told me not to play or stopped me from pursuing cricket.

Whatever decision I took, they stood by me. I give them full credit. I come from a humble background.

“My father was a middle-class businessman and business always has its ups and downs. But he never stopped me because of financial reasons. Whatever I needed, he always tried to provide. I will always remain grateful to him.” Thakur had toured England for India U-19 with current Test and ODI skipper Shubman Gill but missed out on an U-19 World Cup berth that year. However, he has gone through the grind over the last eight years without many complaints. “Since I started getting regular opportunities for India A, I felt I was

one step closer to playing for India. But I also knew that whether it was domestic cricket or India A, I had to keep performing consistently if I wanted my dream to come true.”

“IPL made me tougher”: Having played 22 IPL games till date for LSG and Punjab Kings with 27 wickets including a five-for in his kitty, Thakur believes the tournament transformed him into a mentally stronger bowler.

“The IPL helped me develop the right mindset. It teaches you to be fearless because you are bowling to the best batters in the world. You plan against international players and compete with them regularly. (PTI)

Afghan pacer Shapoor Zadran dies after battling rare immune disorder



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Veteran Afghanistan pacer Shapoor Zadran has died a day before his 39th birthday after battling a rare immune disorder called Hemophagocytic Lymphohistiocytosis (HLH) syndrome for which he was being treated at a hospital here.

Zadran, a left-arm fast bowler, played 44 ODIs and 36 T20Is for Afghanistan between 2009 and 2020. HLH is a hyperinflammatory syndrome which compromises the immune system. He was brought to Delhi for treatment in January.

His death on Tuesday was announced by the Afghanistan Cricket Board (ACB). “With profound grief and deep sorrow, the Afghanistan Cricket Board mourns the passing of former Afghanistan fast bowler Shapoor Zadran,” the ACB wrote on X.

The ACB said Zadran, an imposing bowler who was a part of some memorable wins and drew attention for his flowing hair, was “one of the foundation-laying figures

of Afghanistan cricket”. “Shapoor Zadran was one of the foundation-laying figures of Afghanistan cricket, whose dedication, passion, and unwavering commitment played a vital role in the rise and development of the game in our country,” the ACB said. Several members of the Afghanistan team, including skipper Hashmatullah Shahidi, Rashid Khan, and Mohammad Nabi had visited him in the hospital during the course of his treatment.

Zadran was Afghanistan’s most successful bowler in the 2015 ODI World Cup, taking 10 wickets.

He recorded his career-best figures of 4/24 against the Netherlands on his ODI debut in August 2009, and claimed an overall 43 wickets in 44 matches for Afghanistan. In 36 T20Is, Zadran took 37 wickets with a career-best of 3/40 against Bangladesh in Dehradun in June 2018. He also played 9 First-Class matches taking 17 wickets, and claimed an overall 57 wickets in 56 List A matches and another 90 scalps in 83 T20s.

Federer returns to Wimbledon on 2008 final anniversary

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

Roger Federer was back at Wimbledon on Monday on the 18th anniversary of his memorable five-set loss to rival Rafael Nadal in the 2008 final.

Wearing a brown double-breasted suit, Federer — the record eight-time men’s singles champion at the grass-court Grand Slam — was a guest in the Royal Box for fourth-round matches.

Federer sat in the front row for the Centre Court match featuring rising player Alexandra Eala of the Philippines against 2024 finalist Jasmine Paolini. Up next, it was Grigor Dimitrov against fellow wild card Arthur Fery, who grew up just beyond the All England



Club’s gates, and French Open champion Alexander Zverev against Jiri Lehecka.

When the Zverev-Lehecka match started near 9 p.m.,

one of the most memorable matches in tennis. The defeat prevented Federer from becoming the first man since the 1880s to win a sixth consecutive championship at Wimbledon.

The 2008 final was played on July 6, which was also the date Federer won his first Wimbledon title in 2003 by beating Mark Philippoussis.

Federer, who won the last of his Wimbledon titles in 2017, retired in 2022.

Next month, he will be enshrined into the International Tennis Hall of Fame. Fellow tennis great Billie Jean King and Kimi Antonelli, the 19-year-old Mercedes driver leading the Formula 1 standings, were also in the Royal Box on Monday.

Federer was briefly by himself in the Royal Box.

Nadal beat Federer 9-7 in the fifth set of the 2008 final, which is considered

Paolini wins before Federer on Italy’s big day at Wimbledon

ANDREW DAMPP
■ London

On his first match point, Flavio Cobolli stepped up and unleashed a 135 mph first serve down the T that landed on the line and sent a puff of chalk into the air on Number 1 Court at Wimbledon.

Fifth-seeded opponent Alex de Minaur could barely touch the serve and the Australian’s weak return didn’t even go past his own service line.

Cobolli reacted by leaping into the air and pumping his fist. He launched a ball into the crowd before moving forward to shake hands with De Minaur. Then the Italian moved on to the performance he’d been waiting

for. Cobolli put his racket down and went back out into the center of the court and launched himself into the most iconic celebration in soccer: twirling in mid-air like Cristiano Ronaldo, he then landed on the grass with his feet planted wide and jerked his arms down by his side. The mostly English crowd knew just what was going on and shouted “Siuuu” along with Cobolli.

“I love his celebration. I love him,” said Cobolli, who was once a promising soccer player himself in Roma’s youth system. “I will cheer for Portugal (against Spain at the World Cup) tonight because of Ronaldo.”

In his previous match, Cobolli performed a surfing



celebration borrowed from Brazil striker Matheus Cunha. **Antonelli and Sinner:** While four-time champion Italy failed to qualify for a third consecutive World Cup, the country has no lack of sports stars and a few of them were in the spotlight at the

grass-court Grand Slam on Monday. Cobolli’s 7-5, 7-6 (4), 6-3 victory over a fellow top-10 player to reach the quarterfinals was a state- ment win as he attempts to back up his run to the French Open final.

At the same time over on

Centre Court, Jasmine Paolini ended the run of rising Filipino player Alexandra Eala with a 6-4, 4-6, 6-3 victory to return to the last eight at a Grand Slam for the first time since back-to-back runs to the Roland Garros and Wimbledon finals two years ago.

Watching Paolini from the Royal Box was Kimi Antonelli, the 19-year-old Italian driver who leads the Formula One standings for Mercedes. “I met Kimi afterward,” Paolini said. “I’ve been following him a lot lately. I’m becoming an F1 fan. He seems like a real nice kid and very down to earth.” Coinciding with Italy’s troubles in soccer, Antonelli and defending Wimbledon champion

Jannik Sinner — who plays Jan-Lennard Struff on Tuesday for a spot in the semifinals — have become the country’s most popular athletes. Cobolli, too, is rapidly gaining attention after his run to the Paris final, where he pushed Alexander Zverev to five sets.

De Minaur led 5-2 in the second set and was up a break twice in the third. But Cobolli wouldn’t be deterred.

“Alex is a stratospheric player. So beating him three sets to none makes me feel like I’m ready,” Cobolli said when asked if he’s ready for another deep run.

“This gave me a lot of answers, and I think it provided a lot of answers to my opponents, too.” (AP)

Eala provides ray of hope for Philippines despite Wimbledon exit

KEN MAGUIRE ■ London

Despite falling short of reaching the quarterfinals, Alexandra Eala still made a lasting impact at Wimbledon. The 21-year-old Filipina had ousted defending champion Iga Swiatek but couldn’t solve Jasmine Paolini on Monday, losing 6-4, 4-6, 6-3 on Centre Court.

For Filipino fans — both at watch parties back home and at the All England Club — it’s not always about wins and losses. “She’s like a ray of hope for the Philippines,” fan Roberto Ocampo Jr said Monday at Wimbledon. “Especially at her age. She made history. That’s one thing that we can tell to the next generation.” Eala, who lost in the first round a year



ago in her Wimbledon debut, became the first player from the Philippines to reach the fourth round of a Grand Slam singles tournament in the Open era, the women’s professional tour said.

“Setting foot here is already a big achievement,” said Ocampo, a London-based nurse. The left-handed Eala talked this week about

Filipino pride and being a role model for kids back home. But she also made it clear that she has big plans for her tennis career.

In dissecting her loss to Paolini, she pointed to problems with her serve. “But I have days like that. Everyone has days where they don’t play their best tennis,” said Eala, who trained at the

Rafael Nadal Tennis Academy in Spain as a teenager. “I understand that’s part of the job. I don’t think I’m going to be playing the best tennis of my life every single day.

“With that being said,” she added, “I’m really proud of how I handled things. I just have to kind of move forward and continue with my progress.” Eala, who made a breakthrough in March 2025 by reaching the Miami Open semifinals, has elevated her stardom at Wimbledon, both on and off the court. Eala met Kate, the princess of Wales, and took a photo with her. A photo of Eala diving for a ball in the match against Swiatek also has made the rounds, with edits showing Eala wearing a cape and “Superwoman” outfit.

The Philippines Embassy in the UK has tracked her progress and posted congratulatory notes.

Filipinos love their sports stars Eala spoke earlier in the tournament about her childhood memories of boxing great Manny Pacquiao. “When he would have fights, it would really be like holidays in the Philippines,” she said. “We would gather and we would watch his fights. People would go off work. It would really be an event. He is someone super inspiring as an athlete.” Filipino Olympic champions are treated as national heroes. Gymnast Carlos Yulo, who won two gold medals in the Paris Olympics, returned home to pledges of cash and gifts, including a house. (AP)

Virtual taekwondo on rise as it makes its debut at Asian Games

EILEEN NG
■ Kuala Lumpur (Malaysia)

When Vietnamese athlete Nguyen Thanh Hien Linh stepped into her first virtual taekwondo competition in Singapore in 2024, she had little idea what she was doing.

“I was just kicking into the air,” recalled the 21-year-old. Despite her background as an elite national taekwondo champion, she struggled in the



virtual arena with no clue on strategy, skills or how the technology worked.

Two years later, she won a gold medal at a recent virtual

taekwondo competition in Malaysia and was part of a growing community of the gamified combat sport across Southeast Asia. (AP)

Greaves bats WI back into 2nd Test against Sri Lanka on day 4

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ North Sound (Antigua)

Justin Greaves’ dogged innings of 180 from 325 balls against Sri Lanka on Monday played West Indies into a strong position to claim its first test cricket series victory in four years.

Greaves was the last batter out when West Indies was dismissed for 499 on Day 4 of the second cricket test in reply to Sri Lanka’s first innings of 549-9, reducing



the deficit to only 50 runs.

Sri Lanka lost first-innings century-maker Lahiru Udara to a four-ball duck and Nishan Fernando for 20 before reaching 92-2 at stumps, increasing its overall lead to 142 with a day remaining. Dinesh Chandimal was 40 and Kamindu Mendis was 30 not out in a partnership worth 60 runs by close of play. Sri Lanka scored at more than four runs an over through the last 22 overs of the day and would have to

continue at that rate to have any chance of playing itself into a winning position. It can only do so only by putting up a defensible total and then bowling out West Indies on a pitch which might deteriorate late on the final day.

West Indies won the opening match in the two-test series by an innings and 217 runs and needs only a draw to claim its first series win in the World Test Championship since beating Bangladesh in the Caribbean in 2022.